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Firefighters at the site of a Russian strike in Ukraine's Sumy region on Friday. REUTERS

Russia rejects Black Sea truce as attacks on Ukraine continue

Reuters
London, August 14

RUSSIA ON Friday dismissed the idea of a ceasefire with Ukraine in the Black Sea, saying it saw no grounds for "half-measures" that would offer a respite to the other side.

Both Russia and Ukraine have stepped up attacks in recent weeks against commercial ships in the Black Sea, driving world grain prices higher. In a statement, Foreign Ministry spokeswoman Maria Zakharova accused Ukraine of "brazen acts of terrorism" against shipping, while making no mention of Russia's own attacks.

"We view these attacks (by Ukraine) as a deliberate policy aimed at destabilising civilian shipping in the Black Sea region to further escalate tensions and prolong the conflict, all with the blatant acquiescence of regional neighbours," Zakharova said.

"At the same time, we see no signs of improvement in the situation and, consequently, no grounds for half-measures that merely grant the Kyiv regime a temporary breathing space."

Zakharova said she was commenting on a statement by Turkey's Foreign Minister Hakan

Fidan in a media interview that Ankara had put proposals to both Russia and Ukraine for a moratorium on military operations in the Black Sea.

Earlier Friday, Ukrainian officials said Russian jet-powered drones struck a home in northern Ukraine, killing a 29-year-old woman and her 9-year-old son.

The strike came a day after the United Nations said July was the deadliest month for Ukrainian civilians since the weeks following Moscow's all-out invasion of its neighbor more than four years ago.

At least 437 civilians were killed and 2,610 wounded last month, the UN monitoring mission in Kyiv said, as Russia escalated its bombing of Ukrainian towns and cities. In Ukraine's eastern Donetsk region, a Russian glide bomb demolished six floors of a 10-story apartment block, killing one person and wounding 16 others, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said.

Russia is launching around 220 glide bombs every day against settlements near the front line in eastern and southern Ukraine, Zelenskyy said, adding that in all, Russia attacked 12 Ukrainian regions overnight.

Kushner, Board of Peace officials to visit Israel and Egypt for talks on Gaza

Associated Press
Washington, August 14

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump's son-in-law and negotiator Jared Kushner will travel to West Asia next week to try to advance plans for an end to conflict in Gaza after a deal recently announced by Trump administration ran into Israeli opposition.

An official with the Board of Peace, the body Trump established to oversee the fragile ceasefire in the Israel-Hamas war, said Kushner, board high representative Nikolay Mladenov, and executive board member and former British Prime Minister Tony Blair would arrive in Israel on Sunday.

The group will then travel to Cairo, where meetings of a Palestinian technocratic group set to assume control of Gaza under a US-brokered ceasefire deal have been taking place for the past several months, the official said. The trip was reported earlier by Axios.

The official, who spoke on condition of anonymity, said the meetings would demonstrate the determination of Trump and the Board of Peace to "see peace, prosperity and sustainable security emerge" in a demilitarised Gaza where Hamas has ceded

E. EXPLAINED

Kushner steps in as Gaza deal stalls

Kushner's visit comes as a Gaza ceasefire deal, seen as a potential breakthrough, remains stalled. Based on an October truce that ended major military operations and secured the release of remaining hostages, the agreement now faces disagreements over Hamas' disarmament and Israel's withdrawal from region.

control to allow reconstruction of the devastated territory.

But Israel has dismissed a recent deal announced by Trump for Hamas to disarm and Israel to withdraw its forces from the Palestinian territory, marking a rare public display of friction with the Trump administration.

Though Hamas accepted the plan to decommission its weapons, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said in recent days that Israel would not withdraw until Hamas has completely disarmed.

HEGSETH SAYS U.S. CAN MAINTAIN NAVAL BLOCKADE IN HORMUZ 'INDEFINITELY'

US vows tougher sanctions on Iran as 2 ships hit in Strait

UAE says Tehran attacked 2 vessels transiting Hormuz

Reuters
London, Panama City, August 14

TRANSIT THROUGH the Strait of Hormuz appeared to grind to a near standstill on Friday after two more ships were attacked there and the United States said it could maintain a naval blockade of Iran indefinitely.

A senior Iranian source said on Wednesday that there had been no progress in talks to build on a June agreement to end the war. Since the ceasefire renewed in the June deal broke down, Iran has resumed attacks on ships it accuses of trying to transit the strait without its permission.

The United Arab Emirates' Abu Dhabi National Oil Company said two of its vessels were attacked transiting the strait on Thursday evening. The UAE government blamed Iran, which made no immediate comment.

Two vessels passed through the narrow waterway on Friday, according to analysis from ship tracking firm Kpler: a grain ship



Pro-government demonstrators wave Iranian flags during a gathering in a Tehran square. REUTERS

entering Iranian waters and an empty dry bulk ship going in the other direction.

A separate empty liquefied petroleum products tanker was sailing into the Gulf via the strait, the data showed. There were no crude oil shipments visible on Friday. Nine vessels passed through the strait on Thursday, up from five on Wednesday but below the average of 12 for August.

Some ships may pass through undetected with their transponders off, but the figures are nowhere near the more than

130 ships that traversed the Strait of Hormuz daily before the war launched by the US and Israel on Iran in February.

"Alongside the threat to energy infrastructure in the region, Iran's ability to restrict shipping through the strait is its main source of leverage in negotiations," said Torbjorn Solvsted, principal Middle East analyst with risk intelligence company Verisk Maplecroft.

US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth told reporters the US military has the capability to maintain a naval presence in the

region to enforce its retaliatory blockade of Iran, which has inflicted severe economic damage on the country.

"Indefinitely the United States Navy can maintain a blockade like that because we'll rotate ships in and out, as we have, and we'll continue to," Hegseth told reporters during a trip to Panama.

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the United States planned to inflict more financial damage on Iran. "Watch this space for more announcements coming next week because we are going to apply measures like have never been seen in the history of economic isolation on a country," he said in an interview on *Newsmax*.

Trump has repeatedly asserted the US has "total control" over the strait. Iran rejects that, and has said it will not allow the waterway to reopen until conditions are met. These include removing economic sanctions and releasing frozen Iranian assets.

On Thursday, an Iranian parliamentary committee approved Iran's plan for the strait. It includes a provision banning the transit of US-, Israeli- and other "hostile" countries' assets and equipment, semi-official *Tasnim* news agency reported.

Record-breaking rains flood Japan's Chiba, killing eight

Oamishirosato: Record rainfall in Japan stranded thousands of travellers at Tokyo's Narita airport on Friday, bringing floods to the surrounding area that disrupted transport, knocked out power to 20,000 homes and killed eight.

During one of Japan's busiest holiday weeks, more than 360 mm of rain fell in 24 hours in parts of the Chiba area adjoining Tokyo, inundating roads and railways, with soldiers sent to help with rescue efforts.

"This case was an extremely unusual situation," Chiba Governor Toshihito Kumagai told reporters. "I have responded to many disasters in the past, but I have never experienced a case like this."

REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

Trump asks SC to allow White House ballroom construction to continue



US President during a press conference at the White House. FILE

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump's administration on Friday asked the US Supreme Court to allow it to continue construction of his \$400 million White House ballroom after an appeals court ruled the project lacked the necessary approval from Congress. Trump administration asked the justices to keep the ruling by the US Court of Appeals for the District of Columbia Circuit on hold while it prepares a full appeal to SC. Justice Department lawyers echoed Trump's contention the ballroom project is security necessity. REUTERS

FRANCE

Social media ban for children under 15 blocked

FRANCE'S TOP court on Friday blocked a bill banning social media access for under-15s, saying it infringed upon freedom of expression. "By prohibiting minors under the age of fifteen from accessing certain online services, the law inherently requires every person, even an adult, to prove their age before accessing them," the Constitutional Council said in its decision. REUTERS

GERMANY

Wildfire forces 2,000 to flee near Belgian border

MORE THAN 2,000 people were evacuated from their homes in western Germany on Friday, after a wildfire near the Belgian border spread towards a village, local authorities said. Residents were asked to leave their residences in the village of Gey at around 4:00 am and go to an assistance centre set up at a primary school in a nearby village, the authorities said. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

Balochistan minister escapes attack on convoy

A MINISTER of Pakistan's Balochistan province escaped an armed attack on his convoy on Friday, which left six people, including three police personnel injured, an official said. The attack on Balochistan Home Minister Mir Ziaullah Langove took place in the Khad Kocha area of Mastung district as he was travelling from Quetta to Kalat, according to Balochistan government spokesperson Shahid Rind. PTI

BANGLADESH

Toxic gas leak at shipyard kills at least 8 workers

A SUSPECTED gas leak at a shipbreaking yard in south-eastern Bangladesh killed at least eight people on Friday during the dismantling of a decommissioned ship, police said. Several others were injured at the Ferdous Steel Ship Breaking Yard in the Sitakunda area, police inspector Mohammed Alamgir said. The initial death toll was six, Alamgir said, but two others died after being transported from the scene. AP

Italy recovers stolen Renoir, Cezanne, Matisse artworks



Carabinieri officers pose with recovered Cezanne, Matisse and Renoir paintings in Mamiano, Italy, on Friday. REUTERS

Rome: Italian police have recovered three paintings by French masters Paul Cezanne, Pierre-Auguste Renoir and Henri Matisse that were stolen from a museum near the northern city of Parma in March, officials said on Friday.

Carabinieri officers from Italy's cultural heritage protection unit recovered the works after what police described as a complex investigation.

The paintings were taken from the Fondazione Magnani Rocca museum in Mamiano di

Traversetolo, near Parma, during the night of March 22 to 23. Art experts said their estimated value exceeded \$10.4 million.

The recovered works are Cezanne's *Tasse et Plat de Cerises* (Cup and Plate of Cherries), Renoir's *Les Poissons* (The Fish) and Matisse's *Odalisque sur la Terrasse* (Odalisque on the Terrace).

Police released video of the theft showing two burglars entering through a window, grabbing three paintings and leaving in an operation that took less than three minutes. REUTERS

• TOPOS AZTECA, A MEXICAN VOLUNTEER RESCUE GROUP THAT WORKS WORLDWIDE AND HELPED AFTER THE SEPTEMBER 11 ATTACKS, ARRIVED IN COLOMBIA AFTER SEARCHING FOR SURVIVORS IN VENEZUELA

They spent 40 days in Venezuela, then another quake sent them rushing to Colombia

Genevieve Glatsky
Cali (Colombia), August 14

FOR 40 DAYS they laboured in Venezuela, rescuing survivors from the wreckage and recovering bodies from La Guaira, the coastal region that was nexus of death and destruction triggered by back-to-back earthquakes.

After a quake struck in neighbouring Colombia on Monday they hopped on a red-eye flight. By Wednesday morning they were at collapsed buildings in Cali, Colombia's third-largest city, trying to dig out survivors.

"By the time we were at that point in La Guaira, it was strictly body recoveries," said Alex Rodriguez, 36, who had been in

Venezuela. "And right now we're here, fighting and racing against time to find signs of life."

The rescue workers were from Topos Azteca, a Mexican volunteer search-and-rescue team that has become one of the best-known names in disaster response across Latin America and beyond.

Its members have traveled to earthquakes, floods, hurricanes, landslides and other disasters around the world, as far as Turkey, Ukraine and the United States after the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks.

Cali residents recognized the orange-uniformed volunteers almost immediately, thanking the group's founder and presi-

dent, Héctor Méndez, 80, and taking photographs amid the rubble, as he coordinated the rescue response. The mayor's office featured him in a video.

The reaction reflected a reputation built over four decades. The group's origins trace to the enormous earthquake that struck Mexico City in 1985 and killed as many as 10,000 people.

Méndez, the founder, recalled going to search for his brother after that disaster, but, after finding him unharmed, he instead stopped to help at a collapsed apartment building.

He spent about 10 hours helping rescue a woman and her niece. He emerged exhausted, with injured knees, a



Héctor Méndez, the group's founder, says he realized during a 1985 earthquake in Mexico that rescue work was his life's mission. NYT

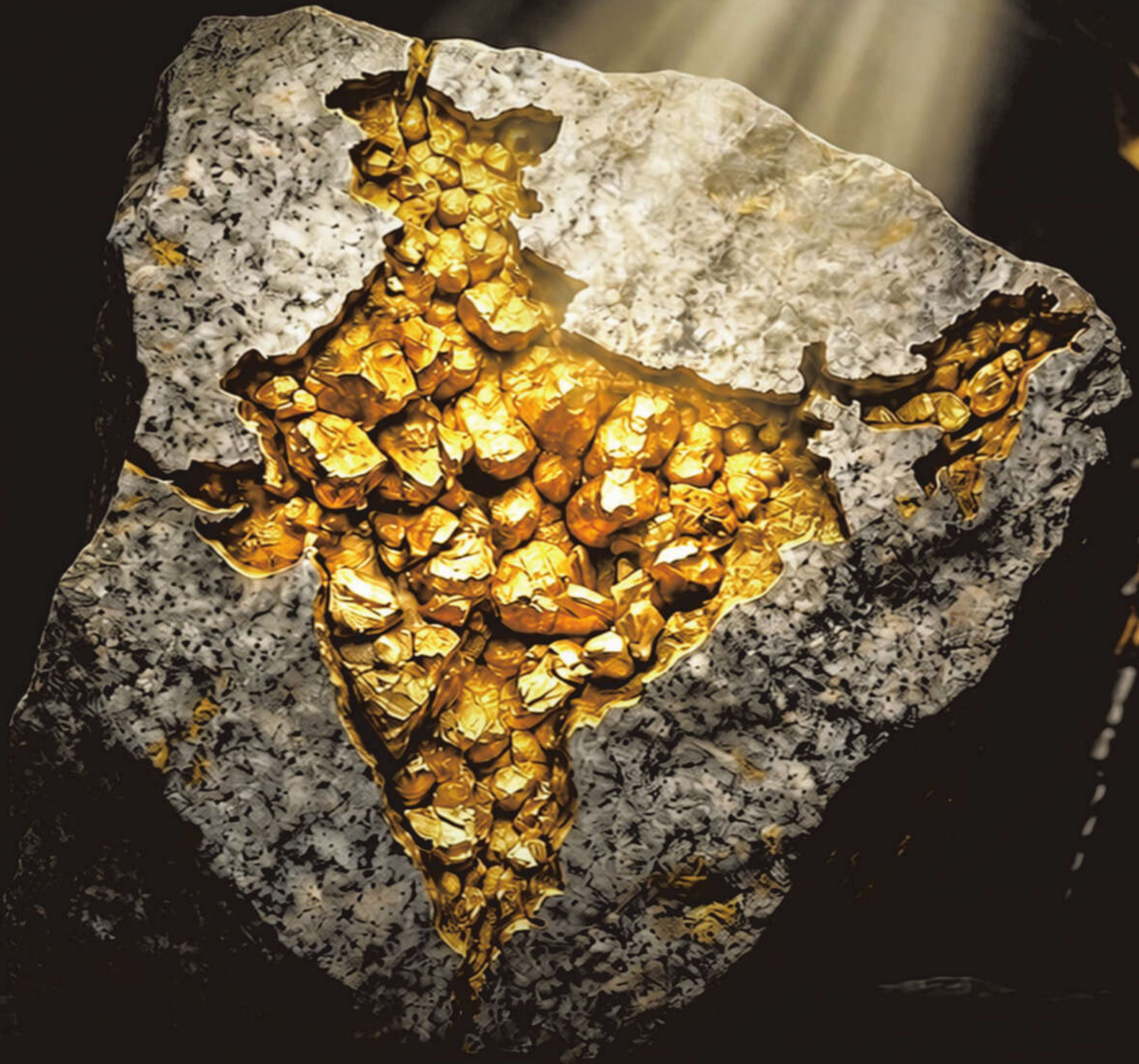
sore arm and aching fingers after working without gloves or proper equipment.

He described the experience

as an epiphany: He realized rescue work was his life's mission. Since then, Topos Azteca has expanded beyond Mexico.



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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

ECONOMICS

The threat to food prices: Weather and renewed war



HARISH DAMODARAN

BOTH WEATHER and war — this time around Europe and Russia-Ukraine than West Asia — are starting to exert upward pressure on international food prices.

On Tuesday, a massive drone strike by Ukraine destroyed two of Russia's biggest grain export terminals in the Black Sea port of Novorossiysk. The serious damage has forced suspension of operations from the two terminals that together have an export capacity of 15.6 million tonnes (mt) per year, according to a Reuters report.

Russia Ukraine war heating up

Since mid-July, Ukraine has also stepped up attacks on grain vessels, maritime infrastructure and ports on the Sea of Azov and the vital Kerch Strait that connects it to the Black Sea. These have significantly restricted movement of Russian agricultural produce through ports such as Rostov-on-Don, Taganrog, Taman, Kavkaz, and now Novorossiysk.

Russia has, likewise, targeted Ukrainian port facilities and vessel operations around the Greater Odesa region.

This shipping hub on the Black Sea coast — comprising three deep-water ports of Odesa, Chornomorsk and Pivdennyi (formerly Yuzhnyi) — handles some 90% of Ukraine's agricultural exports.

The intensification of hostilities between Russia and Ukraine over the last month comes on top of excessive heat and dry weather in the European Union (EU).

The US Department of Agriculture (USDA) has projected EU's wheat production to fall by 7.5% from 145.1 mt in 2025-26 to 134.2 mt in this marketing year, while its output of corn (maize) is expected to dip from 56.8 mt to 50.2 mt (a nearly two-decade low), barley from 56.4 mt to 52.3



mt, oats from 8.9 mt to 8 mt and rye from 7.7 mt to 7.2 mt.

All this is beginning to affect food prices. The United Nations' Food and Agriculture Organization's (FAO) benchmark food price index touched a three-and-a-half year high in July.

The latest Ukrainian hit on Novorossiysk — followed by Russia's on Ukraine's largest Danube port of Izmail in southwestern Odesa, bordering Romania across the river — have driven up prices of corn and wheat at the Chicago Board of Trade exchange by 4-5% since Tuesday.

Export prices of wheat from the US are currently ruling at \$321 per tonne, as against \$235 a year ago, while similarly climbing for grain from EU (\$239 to \$262), Canada (\$259 to \$292), Australia (\$255 to \$291) and Argentina (\$234 to \$239).

Europe's severe summer

Two things are happening. First, the reduction in crop yields due to record-breaking temperatures from late spring through the summer months are likely to push greater grain imports by the EU.

But the simultaneous escalation in the Russia-Ukraine conflict has, secondly, also



A satellite image shows smoke in a port in Russia's Novorossiysk on Wednesday. VANTOR VIA AP

meant logistical disruptions to Black Sea shipping. Low river water levels caused by drought, limiting the possibilities for alternative routes such as via the Danube and even affecting inland transportation to ports, haven't helped either.

For an idea of what the recent escalations have entailed, Ukraine recorded 57 attacks on vessels and 67 on port facilities in July. By contrast, the whole of 2025 saw ships being attacked just 14 times.

As per USDA data, Russia and Ukraine had a combined 27.4% share of global wheat exports in 2025-26, while accounting for 15.8%, 12.5% and 61.5% of the shipments of barley, corn and sunflower oil respectively.

While there is no shortage of production of grain or sunflower seed in either country, the crisis is about shipping out the produce, as the intensified cross-border missile and drone strikes leads to increased shipowner and crew reluctance, soaring insurance premiums and reduced vessel calls at ports.

Ukraine's Agriculture Ministry has already cut its forecast of the country's farm produce exports for 2026-27 from 64.4 mt to 29.6 mt, with wheat shipment estimates alone downgraded from 17.6 mt to 8.3 mt.

Russia can consider alternative routes that include ports on the Baltic, Caspian and Far East seas or overland rail links. At the end of the day though, more than 80% of its grain exports go through the Sea of Azov and Black Sea.

The current surge in Russia-Ukraine hostilities has huge implications. The FAO food price index had peaked in March 2022 when the war had just begun. Prices remained elevated till early 2023, by which time grain shipments had resumed through safe maritime corridors in the Black Sea established under a UN-backed initiative.

With Russia and Ukraine launching a fresh wave of strikes on vessels and ports along one of the world's most strategic shipping lane for agricultural produce, it could potentially add to the problems from the continued blockade of the Strait of Hormuz — not to speak of heatwaves in Europe and El Niño.

In short, while the Strait of Hormuz has drawn the world's and India's attention through much of this year, the other major trade chokepoint — the Black Sea, Sea of Azov and the Kerch Strait — may matter no less in the coming days.

STRATEGY SHIFT

After years of criticising adversaries for drawing non-state actors into cyber campaigns, US is now building its own mechanism.

But this model is not entirely identical. It's much more formalised than, say, in China or Russia.

How this will work

The programme will be run by the National Coordination Center under the Homeland Security Task Force, and overseen by officials nominated by the Departments of Justice and Homeland Security.

Companies will have to sign contracts with either department and pass

checks covering their technical abilities, previous cyber operations, personnel, reliability, and physical security. Large tech companies and smaller firms are both eligible.

The targets are supposed to be criminal organisations attacking US persons or interests, and not entities that are formally part of a foreign government or wholly under its direction. There are nevertheless risks. Cyber attackers routinely hide behind compromised computers belonging to innocent organisations, making attribution, and avoiding collateral damage, difficult.

Echoes of China and Russia

The approach has some parallels with a model Washington has repeatedly accused China and Russia of using — mobilising private or nominally independent hackers to extend the state's cyber capabilities.

In China, US authorities have described an extensive "hacker-for-hire" ecosystem in which private cybersecurity companies and freelance hackers work for Beijing. Last year, the FBI said a private firm working with the Chinese government sometimes took government assignments and sometimes hacked targets independently before trying to sell the stolen information to state agencies.

Russia's model is even less formal. Chatham House research has described an ecosystem ranging from criminal gangs and hacktivists to private companies, some directly linked to intelligence agencies, some financially supported, and others simply tolerated as long as their activities broadly serve Russian interests.

LEGAL

No provision for blanket enrolment freeze, BCI role narrow

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 14

ON THURSDAY, the Bar Council of India (BCI) directed state bar councils to not enrol graduates of NALSAR University of Law's 2026 batch over their protest against the convocation invitation to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant. Within hours, however, the BCI withdrew the order and closed the proceedings. The episode raises larger questions over what powers the BCI actually possesses under the Advocates Act of 1961. Can the BCI actually tell state councils to stop enrolment?

The NALSAR-CJI row

The row began when around 450 students of NALSAR objected to the CJI attending their convocation as chief guest. The BCI then wrote to state bar councils, telling them to hold off on enrolling anyone from the batch, citing an inquiry it wanted to run against what it called "an organised campaign" against the CJI.

By late evening, however, BCI chairperson Manan Kumar Mishra reversed course, saying the council was satisfied that the batch had no role in any "disturbance or movement" and closed the matter.

On Friday, the CJI said: "Students have the right to protest. The BCI action was absolutely unnecessary."

The BCI order

BCI's rules contain mechanisms that

allow urgent decisions to be taken quickly.

Ordinarily, the council is expected to meet after notice to its members. But its rules permit meetings to be convened at short notice where urgency demands it.

There is an even faster route — decision-making by circulation. Instead of convening a meeting, a proposal can be circulated among members and acted upon once the required approval is obtained, subject to later confirmation by the council.

The chairman also possesses limited independent powers. Rule 18 allows the chairman to pass interim orders in matters arising out of the council's supervisory jurisdiction. Because such orders are interim, they may also be modified or withdrawn without a full BCI meeting.

There is a formal review provision too. Section 48AA of the Advocates Act states that the BCI or any of its committees, except a disciplinary committee, may "of its own motion or otherwise review any order" within sixty days.

BCI can't enrol advocates

The Advocates Act creates a two-tier structure: State Bar Councils under Section 3 and the BCI under Section 4.

Section 7 empowers BCI to lay down "standards of professional conduct and etiquette for advocates", supervise State Bar Councils, promote legal education and recognise universities whose law degrees qualify for enrolment as an advocate. Section 49 gives it broad rule-making powers.

What it can and can't do

The Bar Council of India can lay down 'standards of professional conduct and etiquette for advocates', supervise State Bar Councils, promote legal education and recognise universities.

But no provision in the Advocates Act of 1961 gives it the power to actually enrol a person as an advocate.

Many of these powers begin only after a person enters the profession. A law graduate who has not yet been enrolled is not an advocate.

But none of those provisions actually gives the BCI the power to enrol a person as an advocate. That function belongs to State Bar Councils. Section 6 lists among its functions of a state bar council the power "to admit persons as advocates on its roll".

The carve-out

The BCI, however, is not completely absent from the enrolment process. Section 26 of the Advocates Act creates a narrow carve-out. If the enrolment committee of a State Bar Council proposes to reject an application, it must refer the matter to the BCI along with "a statement of the grounds in support of the refusal of the application". Section 26(3) then requires the State Bar Council to dispose of the application "in conformity with the opinion of the Bar Council of India".

Section 26 deals with individual applications that a State Bar Council has already proposed to reject. It does not expressly contemplate a blanket freeze on an entire graduating class before any applications have even been filed.

The Advocates Act also contains specific grounds for disqualification.

Section 24A bars enrolment of a person convicted of an offence involving "moral turpitude", offences under the Untouchability Act, or dismissal from government service on similar grounds. The disqualification lapses after two years.

The BCI's communication on Thursday acknowledged that it was not proceeding

under Section 24A. Instead, it said that allowing enrolment while an inquiry was pending could create a "fait accompli".

Even when enrolment is denied, the Act builds in checks. Section 26(2) requires a state council to lay down its grounds for refusing to enrol someone in writing. The BCI's role kicks in only after a state council has proposed such a denial. Where the BCI wants to remove a name already on the roll over fraud or misrepresentation, it must first give that person a hearing.

Senior Advocate K K Manan told *The Indian Express*: "We are living in a democratic country. To criticise or to do any agitation, it is our fundamental right given by our constitution. Nobody can take that away. BCI should withdraw it, failing which we will start our agitation against BCI."

The limits of BCI's powers

The BCI regulates legal education, recognises degrees, supervises state councils and exercises disciplinary jurisdiction over advocates. But many of those powers begin only after a person enters the profession.

Chapter V of the Advocates Act deals with disciplinary proceedings against advocates. Sections 35 to 37 concern misconduct by advocates and appeals from disciplinary orders. Those provisions apply to persons already enrolled on a state roll.

A law graduate who has not yet been enrolled is not an advocate. The disciplinary framework does not naturally extend to such a person.

DEFENCE

Photo-recce missions: Airborne imagery was key in Kargil, and remains crucial

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, August 14

OPERATION SAFED Sagar — the acclaimed Netflix series based on real events from the air operations conducted by the Indian Air Force (IAF) during the 1999 Kargil war — highlights the photo reconnaissance (photo-recce) missions executed by the No. 17 'Golden Arrows' squadron during that time.

The squadron, equipped with MiG-21 aircraft, played a crucial role in conducting multiple photo-recce sorties. These missions, along with those carried out by other IAF fighter squadrons, were instrumental in identifying the extent of the Pakistani intrusion along the Line of Control.

What is a photo recce mission?

A fighter aircraft photo-recce mission is one in which a fighter or fighter-derived aircraft is tasked with collecting the imagery of an area, installation or activity for intelligence purposes, rather than attacking the target.

It is different from a strike and an air defence missions, which are meant, respectively, for destroying a decided target, and for locating and engaging one. An aircraft on a photo-recce role may fly into or close to a hostile location, capture images and return.

They are typically used to map enemy positions, identify and locate targets for subsequent strike missions, assess damage after an air strike, monitor military activity, and update intelligence on enemy deployments and defensive positions.

They can also be used to conduct terrain or route reconnaissance, particularly around difficult or contested areas, assist in battle-damage assessment after an operation and provide imagery for mission planning, including routes, target coordinates and changes to the battlefield.

Such missions can also be flown to locate wreckage of any aircraft.

Which aircraft and squadrons had a dedicated photo recce role?

The erstwhile Canberra PR.57/67 and



A Su-30 fighter. Currently, Su-30s and Jaguars perform photo recce missions. FILE

MiG-25R squadrons were dedicated to photo-reconnaissance roles. Aside from that, the Jaguars, MiG-21s, MiG-27s, Mirage 2000s and the latest Su-30s have also been

earmarked for this role at different points.

For instance, the No. 17 squadron, depicted in *Operation Safed Sagar*, was flying dedicated photo reconnaissance missions in the initial part of the Kargil conflict and was later given bombing roles. Similarly, the No. 14 squadron played a critical role in photo recce missions during Operation Parakram, which followed the Kargil conflict.

As of today, with all MiG-21 squadrons being phased out, only the Jaguars and the Su-30s perform photo reconnaissance missions. That is just one of their many roles.

How were such missions carried out?

Earlier, older cameras with photographic film were used for such missions. The film would then be later developed into high-resolution images and analysed to decide the further course of action.

During the Kargil war, tactical photo recce was carried out by MiG-21s using the Vinten 751 camera. Its focal length of only three inches — a shorter focal length provides a wider field of view — helped the air-

craft in taking pictures from a low level, said Air Chief Marshal B S Dhanoa (retd), who was then the Commanding Officer of the No.17 'Golden Arrows' squadron.

"It was a British camera placed inside a Russian fuel tank," he said. While Dhanoa's squadron specifically conducted tactical photo reconnaissance missions, strategic photo reconnaissance missions were undertaken by other IAF squadrons.

Air Vice Marshal Sunil Nanodkar (retd), who was the Commanding Officer of the No. 14 Squadron during Operation Parakram, explained that the Jaguars would fly multiple sorties for strategic photo recce. The Ambala-based No.14 Squadron is equipped with Jaguars.

"We would stay within the border and undertake oblique photography up to 75 km, using Long-Range Oblique Photography (LOROP). (The) camera would capture imagery of major enemy deployments deep inside the enemy territory," he said.

Nanodkar explained that multiple types of cameras and equipment were deployed

around that time to capture imagery, including the LOROP, Vicon pods and the British Aerospace pod.

Can't drones replace such missions?

Photo recce missions have evolved significantly since then.

Nanodkar explained that recce light pods and Litening targeting pods are now used for photo recce missions. "The images are no longer captured in a photographic film but are relayed directly to commanders through ground stations on a real-time basis and are simultaneously examined for further course of action," he said.

But with the increased deployment of satellites and drones, are fighter photo recce missions still required? Yes, particularly during wartime. "All three can provide real-time images of the ground. However, satellites have specific revisit times, and drones can be vulnerable during a conflict or war. In such situations, fighter jets could carry out high-speed photography at any given time," Nanodkar said.

SATURDAY, AUGUST 15, 2026



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●FOR THE FIRST TIME, Vande Mataram will be rendered during I-Day celebrations at Red Fort.

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY

ISSUES NOTICE OVER NOW-WITHDRAWN DIRECTIVE TO NALSAR

BCI action uncalled for, students have right to protest: CJI

Pulls up Bar Council: 'It's dialogue between students and me'

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, August 14

SAYING STUDENTS have the right to protest, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant Friday rebuked the Bar Council of India (BCI) for directing state Bar councils not to enrol the 2026 batch students of NALSAR, Hyderabad, after a section of the students opposed inviting him to the law university's

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

The walk back: BCI chief acted on own, say members

Vineet Bhalla
New Delhi, August 14

A DIRECTIVE issued by Bar Council of India (BCI) chairman and Senior Advocate Manan Kumar Mishra Thursday evening, barring the 2026 graduating batch of NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, from enrolling with state Bar councils and seeking an inquiry against them, was

THE EDITORIAL PAGE
BAR COUNCIL BREAKS THE LAW TO CRAWL. ITS CHIEF MUST GO **P10**

walked back twice within hours.

In the six hours between issuing the directive and rolling it back fully, at least four of the BCI's 19 office bearers pushed back on it immediately — three

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Safeguard present, future of our students: President

Divya A
New Delhi, August 14

WEIGHING IN on the recent student protests at Jantar Man-tar over the NEET (UG) paper leak, President Droupadi Murmu, in her address to the nation Friday on the eve of the 80th Independence Day,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



President Droupadi Murmu addresses the nation on the eve of Independence Day. PTI

Movements for nation's good must not stop: 99-yr-old freedom fighter to Gen Z

Kiran Parashar
Bengaluru, August 14

IT WAS 1942. YC Revanna, then 15, jumped out of the school window, as did many of his friends and classmates. Instead of classes, they ran to join the Quit India movement. All of them were more or less convinced that they were part of something bigger, something that could drive the British out of the land they called home.



Y C Revanna was 15 years old when he joined the Quit India movement in 1942

Now 99, Revanna, one of Mysuru's last two surviving registered freedom fighters, believes the leaders of the time had inspired them to skip classes that day. "The leaders we had were very promising: Devaraj Urs, S Nijalingappa, and MN Jois (popularly known as Lion of Mysore), they made us feel the significance of freedom. It (joining the protest) was really about a fascination with

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Sarojini to Dubai via UK: Drug kingpin's run ends

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, August 14

FUGITIVE DRUG kingpin Vi-render Singh Basoya, who was arrested in the UAE in June, has been extradited to India and arrested by the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB).

In a social media post, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said the Narendra Modi government is "relentlessly"

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 9



Virender Singh Basoya being produced at the Rouse Avenue Court in New Delhi, Friday. PTI

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

CJI on BCI action

annual convocation.

“BCI is unnecessarily taking action. If the students have a cause to protest, they have the right to protest. Students might have written a letter to me. It’s a dialogue between students and me. Who are they (BCI) to unnecessarily raise an issue? This is totally uncalled for. BCI has nothing to do with this,” the CJI said while hearing a plea challenging the now-withdrawn BCI directive.

The CJI made the remarks during mentioning hours — when matters requiring urgent attention are brought to the notice of the court — after Senior Advocate K Parameshwar informed the bench that a plea had been filed challenging the directive.

BCI chairman Manan Kumar Mishra had issued the directive Thursday, asking state Bar councils not to enrol students of NALSAR’s 2026 batch

following the protest. He withdrew the circular hours later, saying the BCI had closed the proceedings after concluding that the students had “no role in any disturbance or movement”.

Issuing notice to the BCI, the bench, also comprising Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana, said, “Upon being orally mentioned by Mr K Parameshwar, learned Senior Counsel appearing on behalf of the petitioners, the matter is taken on Board. Issue notice, returnable on 03.09.2026. Ms. Radhika Gautam, learned counsel appearing on behalf of respondent No.1 – Bar Council of India, accepts notice. She states that the offending Circulars have since been withdrawn. Be that as it may, let the counter affidavit be filed within two weeks. Meanwhile, no punitive action shall be taken against the students or Faculty of NALSAR University of Law

at the instance of Bar Council of India or any State Bar Council in respect of the incidents mentioned in the subject letters.”

Parameshwar said that although the directive had been withdrawn, the cause of action survived. He said it raised questions over the manner in which BCI chairman Mishra had acted. He pointed out that a Bar Council member had already opposed the circular.

“BCI has no business of what’s going on in a university,” Parameshwar said.

Recalling his own days as a student, the CJI said he had been actively involved in student activities and that students were raising their voice peacefully and should be allowed to do that.

“I myself, during student days, was involved in student activities. Peacefully, they are raising voice, they should be allowed. Even if they are wrong, assuming, they have the right to protest. Who can stop them? So long as they are lawfully and peacefully raising

a voice, they must be heard. Why should the Bar Council or any other body should interfere?” he said.

After the order was dictated, the CJI told Parameshwar, “You tell the students, get the licence at the earliest. Join the Supreme Court Bar. We will empanel them for legal aid cases, and let them do legal aid. This will be the befitting answer to all those who caused impediment in their career.”

Justice Bagchi asked, “Was BCI convened to take a resolution like that? We want to know.”

The plea by two NALSAR alumni, Mihira Sood and Abhishek Tiwari, said the Council did not have the statutory authority to conduct the inquiry as proposed or to impose a pre-emptive restriction on the enrolment of law graduates. They said participation in a student campaign or the pendency of a university inquiry is not among reasons under the Advocates Act to disqualify a law degree holder from enrolment.

President’s address

emphasised on “ensuring national security” as well as safeguarding “the present and future of our students”.

Calling students “the architects of India’s future”, the President said, “Just as the government and society must remain united to ensure national security, everyone must contribute through joint and concerted efforts to safeguard the present and future of our students.”

“Public examinations become gateways to the opportunities for our students,” she said, adding that the government is undertaking comprehensive steps to reform these examina-

tions.

“The objectives of these reforms are to completely curb the use of unfair means in public examinations, make the examination system more transparent, more secure, and more trustworthy for the youth,” she said.

The recent student protests, led by Cockroach Janta Party, centred on widespread anger over systemic corruption in the public examination system, repeated question paper leaks, and cancellation of the high-stake NEET exams, leading to the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

During the Monsoon Session which concluded Thursday, Parliament passed the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, enhancing penalties with upto 10 years in prison and fines reaching Rs 10 crore. The legislation also introduces fast-track courts and a strict two-month investigation deadline for examination fraud.

“Through the government’s initiatives and emerging economic activities, a wide range of new avenues are opening up for the youth. By exploring such new opportunities, our young people can embark on new paths to success,” the President said.

Recalling India’s May 2025 Operation Sindoor against terror bases in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir and Pakistan, she said, “That historic operation against terrorism... sent a clear and firm message to terrorists and those who support them, that no matter where they hide, they will have to face the consequences of their actions”.

Suspension of the Indus Waters Treaty with the country that harbours terrorism is a decisive step in the interest of our nation, especially the farmers, she said. India put the treaty in abeyance after the Pahalgam terror attack last year, and New Delhi has said it won’t change until Pakistan takes credible steps to end cross-border terrorism.

The President also spoke about the responsibilities of the executive, legislature and judiciary, as clearly defined in the Constitution. “Giving voice to the aspirations of the people is the duty of their representatives in the legislature. The Executive is responsible for implementing policies that serve the interests of the nation and its people. It is the duty of every person associated with the judicial system to ensure that no one is deprived of justice due to lack of resources.”

All citizens, especially those belonging to deprived sections of the society, should have equal

access to timely justice with dignity, she said.

She made special mention of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel’s role in the integration of princely states, and that of social reformer Jyotiba Phule contribution towards social justice.

“Our country is celebrating the 200th birth anniversary of Mahatma Jyotiba Phule. Mahatma Phule and Kranti-Jyoti Savitribai Phule made historic contributions to social justice, education, women’s empowerment, and equality.”

Following their ideals, the upliftment of the deprived sections of society has been given priority at the national level during the past few years, she said. “History of the world bears witness to the fact that development rooted in a strong sense of cultural identity is both rapid and sustainable. Today, there is a growing awareness in the country that a sense of cultural pride bolsters the inner strength of the nation.”

India has developed the world’s largest and best digital infrastructure, she said. “Digital payments are now common even in small rural shops and among street vendors. More than half of the world’s real-time digital transactions take place in India.”

According to economic projections, the growth rate of the Indian economy is expected to be more than twice the average global growth rate. The Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan, she said, has further strengthened the foundation of the country’s economic progress and national security.

National interest, the President said, is the foundation of India’s foreign policy. “Peace, co-operation, dialogue, and the ideal of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam are the pillars of our foreign policy. We have entered into Free Trade Agreements with many countries to enhance economic cooperation and strengthen mutual relations. We are playing a leading role among the countries of the Global South.”

BCI chief acted on own: Members

opposing the order outright, and a fourth seeking changes. NALSAR’s Vice Chancellor refused to implement the directive immediately, calling it potentially “unconstitutional” and the Cockroach Janta Party, which spearheaded the Jantar Mantar protest, sprung into action, calling all “legal cockroaches to unite”.

Besides barring the 2026 batch from enrolment, Mishra’s original directive, issued around 6.30 pm Thursday, also asked NALSAR’s Vice-Chancellor to conduct an inquiry into who had started a campaign among the university’s students, earlier in the week, against inviting Chief Justice of India Surya Kant to their convocation.

Five BCI office bearers told *The Indian Express* that Mishra had taken the decision on his own, without consulting colleagues, and had signed and published the directive, on the BCI letterhead, before seeking his colleagues’ approval in the council’s WhatsApp group.

“This was a decision taken by Mr Mishra on his own,” Advocate Manoj Kumar N, Vice-Chairman of the BCI’s executive committee, told *The Indian Express*. “After issuing

the letter, it was posted in the WhatsApp group for approval.” Kumar said he was “really shocked” to see it.

Ten of the BCI’s 19 office bearers approved the letter on the group, according to two office bearers, while at least three opposed it outright: Kumar, Senior Advocate Y R Sadasiva Reddy, the BCI’s Co-Chairman, and Advocate A Rami Reddy, Member, BCI. A fourth, Co-Chairman Advocate Ved Prakash Sharma, did not oppose the letter outright but asked for it to be modified.

Both Sadasiva Reddy and Rami Reddy confirmed their disapproval of the directive. Sadasiva Reddy said Mishra had told members not to worry, and that he would modify the order.

“The chairman immediately agreed to the suggestions given by the other members,” said a fourth BCI member, who spoke on condition of anonymity. “Sometimes it is done with the confidence that it will be approved by the other members, but this time it was not, and the members expressed different views.”

He also said that the discussion had centred on proportionality: “The BCI should not get into this because there is no

complaint or report of any enormous acts of indiscipline by the students, so the students should not get punished unnecessarily.”

It is learnt that several members in the council were unaware that the directive was already in the public domain when it was being discussed for over an hour on the WhatsApp group.

Later that evening, around 8.20 pm, the BCI published a second letter stating that “after detailed deliberation, the BCI has modified its earlier directions”, withdrawing the bar on enrolment. The letter also distanced itself from the first: it referred to the earlier directive as “the letter issued by the Chairman, Bar Council of India” – not as a decision of the council – and said members had, “after thorough discussion,” reached the “unanimous view” to “modify the order of the Chairman”.

At 8.28 pm, Mishra also personally responded on X to a post by Saurav Das, Co-convenor, Cockroach Janta Party calling “legal cockroaches to unite” and hold the BCI chairman accountable. “Council has already withdrawn that letter,” Mishra said.

However, within a few

hours, Professor Srikrishna Deva Rao, Vice Chancellor of NALSAR, issued a press statement stating that the BCI directive to conduct an inquiry against students will not be implemented immediately.

“Given the nature of the request, the University will have to consider whether conducting such an inquiry will be a constitutional exercise of its powers. In order to assist the University, assess whether conducting such an inquiry would be constitutional and permissible under the University’s governance regulations, the matter will be placed before the Executive Council of the University,” the statement said.

That order, too, did not survive the night. At 12.43 am Friday, Mishra announced on his X account that “after considering the representations and reactions of Senior Advocates, learned members of the Bar, law students and public spirited citizens,” the BCI had closed all proceedings against the 2026 batch and that no further action would be required from the university administration – closing the inquiry order that the second letter had retained.

The Indian Express made multiple attempts to seek Mishra’s comments via phone and WhatsApp, but there was no response.

Freedom fighter

how our participation could drive out the British, and we could rule ourselves,” says Revanna, who will be turning 100 next year around Independence Day.

On August 15, he hopes to hoist the national flag at Mysuru’s Freedom Fighters’ Park or Subbarayanakere Park, where the Independence Day celebrations take place every year.

Even after 79 years of freedom, Revanna says, our country still has a long way to go. “Swarajya was just a part of Indian movements. The youth must continue to organise and agitate till we attain Ramarajya,” he emphasises.

The 99-year-old served as president of the Mysore freedom fighters’ association in its heydays, when it had 145 registered members. Today, only Revanna and Male Gowda are there to recall how the Quit India movement had shaken the British.

Revanna’s first participation in the protests in 1942 had cost him dearly. Those days, the British Police used to arrest and jail leaders and protesters who were above 18 years. But the rules were different for minors.

In the first instance of being caught at a protest, minors were abandoned in forests, where the police hoped the children would lose their way. In Mysuru, the forest where they were infamously abandoned was ‘Kakana Kote’, some 73 km away from Mysuru and now part of the Nagarahole Tiger Reserve. Then, as now, wild animals, including elephants, tigers and leopards,

roamed the canopy-covered trails of ‘Kakana Kote’, named after tribal leader Kaka Nayaka who walked its paths and went on to openly revolt against the Mysore kingdom’s tax collectors.

After being detained, Revanna and his friends were similarly abandoned. “The first time I got arrested with my friends, we were taken deep into the forest and were left in the pitch-dark night. It took some days to return home,” he says.

In the second instance of being caught, not even minors were spared from jail.

Revanna, however, continued to attend the protests. “This time, the police were waiting for us, waiting to put us in prison. But that did not stop us from fighting for Indian independence,” says the 99-year-old with a grin.

After matriculation, he was admitted to Class 11, but his desire to be a part of the independence movement eventually drove him to skip schooling. “I quit midway and participated in the Indian freedom struggle on the lines of Mahatma Gandhi,” he says.

A Gandhian by heart

YC Revanna recalls learning the meaning of freedom at a very young age from the local freedom fighters and their stories. At seven years of age, when he was visiting his sister in Mysore in January 1934, Mahatma Gandhi was visiting the city as part of his campaign against untouchability.

“I was very young. Everyone ran towards the main road to

see Gandhi. I was a curious child and got a glimpse of him from afar. But later, his ideas and philosophies always stayed with me,” he says.

Born on 25 August 1927 to Channaveera Devaru and Rudramma in a small village named Hale Yedathore, some 45 km from Mysuru, Revanna says that later in school, he sharpened his political ideas.

Devaru was a trader during British rule but a few years after his son’s birth, Hale Yedathore that lay on the banks of the Cauvery river was totally destroyed in the floods. Then Maharaja of Mysore, Krishnaraja Wadiyar IV, built a town named Krishnarajanagar, or popularly KR Nagar, for the displaced people, some five km from their destroyed village. At KR Nagar, Revanna’s family started a new life.

“We used to hear about the freedom struggle, which was happening in the country, but were not aware of its significance. By the time I turned 15, I was a student at Sri Krishnarajendra Government Boys High School in KR Nagar. Leaders then were encouraging youngsters to participate in the freedom movement,” he says.

It didn’t take Revanna long after that to join.

Five years later, on August 15, 1947, when India eventually attained independence from the British, an elated Revanna, like many others, celebrated. But that was not the end of it.

The then king of the Princely State of Mysore, Jayacharamaja Wodeyar, had signed the Instrument of Accession to join the Indian Union only days before Independence, on August 9, 1947, but did not easily agree to a democratically accountable state government. Protesting this,

the Mysore State Congress, led by KC Reddy, launched a satyagraha on 1 September 1947, named ‘Mysore Chalo’, a slogan inspired by Subhas Chandra Bose’s ‘Delhi Chalo’.

Revanna also marched. He was leading a padayatra of nearly a 1,000 youths in KR Nagar and was supposed to cover 45 km, but was arrested mid-way. He was released only after the Maharaja conceded to an interim government on September 24, 1947.

Once out of jail, Revanna worked as a government school teacher and served as one until 1983, when he retired. Throughout, he continued writing and participating in agitations and social work. Till recently, Revanna was attending school and college programmes to raise awareness about the significance of freedom and how society needs to move forward.

Currently, though, he lives a quiet life in Sharadadevi Nagar in Mysuru. His health deteriorated after his wife Kamalamma passed away last year in February.

But his spirit of dissent is inviolable. “Be it the British or the people in power today, whenever there is injustice, the youth need to step up and fight. Agitations and movements must never stop... It must continue for the good of the nation,” he says.

Comparing his era and now, he says, “Unfortunately, the country has been divided based on religion and caste, and there are no quality leaders who can take everyone along. Sometimes, when I see these things, I feel it would have been better if India never won freedom from the British or from the Mysore king. But I hope the youth will change my opinion.”



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Munak Canal water loss in focus, Delhi, Haryana set to hold survey

Around 30% of water supplied by Haryana to Delhi is lost every day

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 14

EVEN AS Haryana releases 330 cusecs of drinking water every day for Delhi from the Yamuna river through Munak Canal, the Capital receives only 230 cusecs after accounting for 30% conveyance loss, according to officials. Eyeing a resolution of the persistent leakage issue, the Delhi and Haryana government are now planning to conduct a joint survey. The Indian Express has learnt.

Three meetings have already been held between the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) and the Haryana Irrigation department for the repair of the Delhi Sub-Branch canal (DSB), the key channel that originates in Haryana and supplies drinking water to the Capital, and address the transmission losses, said officials. The matter was also reviewed in a recently-held meeting on the Yamuna rejuvenation by the Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh.

Highlighting another measure that is being considered, a senior government official explained, “The Delhi Chief Secretary has written a letter to Haryana Chief Secretary for a joint survey to ascertain the right way to develop a 1,000-cusec new pipeline,” a senior government official said.

Another official added, “Haryana’s Irrigation department has informed that a consultant for preparing a detailed project report (DPR) afresh is to be appointed... Delhi has already



Haryana supplies 330 cusecs of water from Yamuna river.

conveyed consent to bear its share for the lining of the DSB.”

During the meeting with the Delhi Water Minister, the ongoing problem of river pollution and frothing was also discussed, said officials, adding that a six-point action plan has been made to reduce the frothing in the Yamuna.

The action plan includes redesigning of the Okhla barrage to moderate the plunge and churn at the barrage gates that whip surfactant-laden water into foam, stop dumping of garbage into the river and clear solid waste accumulated in the channel, clear water hyacinth and other floating vegetation whose decay adds to the organic load.

Besides, there are also plans to remove the dhobi ghats, to end the direct discharge of detergent into drains, and unauthorised units discharging untreated effluent into the drainage system.

Officials said that between December 1, 2025 and July 22, 2026, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) in a survey inspected 11,230 units and closed 584 water-polluting units. Besides, the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) also flagged 188 polluting industrial units in non-conforming areas between April 8 and July 23 and shared details with the MCD for action.

‘One of the most dehumanising chapters’: Vice-President recalls horrors of Partition

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 14

THE INDIA-Pakistan partition marked one of the most tragic and dehumanising chapters in the country’s history, Vice-President C P Radhakrishnan said on Friday stressing that the Partition Horrors Remembrance Day was not meant to “reopen old wounds with bitterness” but to remind the country of the suffering and sacrifices that accompanied Independence. He made the remarks at a national seminar organised to mark the day by the Centre for Independence and Partition Studies (CIPS), University of Delhi, in collaboration with the Indian Council of Historical Research (ICHR).

“Our children deserve to know the truth of Partition,” said V-P Radhakrishnan, who is also the DU Chancellor, adding, “The catastrophe of such magnitude could not be reduced to a few lines in a textbook.”

In his address as the chief guest, Radhakrishnan paid tribute to Partition survivors



Vice-President C P Radhakrishnan with DU V-C Yogesh Singh. ANI

present at the seminar and said, “The country must pause, on the eve of Independence Day, to remember those who endured the violence, displacement and suffering of 1947... Freedom has not come to us without any cost, without any sufferings, without any sacrifice. This type of horror should never happen again in our motherland,” he said as he felicitated 15 Partition survivors during the event.

The Partition, he added, resulted in one of the largest mass migrations in human history,

with more than one crore people uprooted. “Families were torn apart. Neighbourhoods that stood for centuries were emptied overnight,” he said, adding that countless men, women and children lost their lives. The Vice-President also spoke about the suffering of women during Partition, referring to accounts of abduction, assault, forced marriage and conversion. He said some fathers had taken the lives of their own daughters rather than see them subjected to such violence. “It is most im-

possible for us sitting here in safety to fully imagine the depth of this despair,” he said, adding that for many survivors the loss of their homes had also permanently affected their sense of identity and belonging.

The University of Delhi’s Centre for Independence and Partition Studies, established in 2023, had recorded the testimonies of more than 100 Partition survivors in a short period, he said. The centre, he said, was also reaching out to young students through lectures, archives and public events.

“Time will heal everything. Time will fade everything but certain history should not fade...,” he underlined, stressing that the experiences of those who lived through Partition must remain part of the collective memory.

Radhakrishnan said the hurried redrawing of borders had created disputes whose consequences continued to be felt, including in India’s defence policy, national security and relations with neighbouring countries.

High Court, airport get hoax bomb threat



Outside the Delhi High Court on Friday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, August 14

A DAY before India celebrates its Independence Day, bomb threats were received at multiple establishments in Delhi, including the Indira Gandhi International Airport and the Delhi High Court, besides several other government offices and locations. Nothing suspicious was found at any of the sites, officials said.

The threats come at a time when security arrangements have been heightened across the national capital ahead of

the August 15 celebrations. Soon after the threats were received, police, bomb disposal squads, fire department personnel and other emergency response teams were dispatched to the locations.

The locations that reportedly received the threats include Jam Nagar House, the Jhandewalan Building, an office in Saket, the Delhi Cantonment SDM office and Terminal 3 of the IGI Airport, officials said. Police teams are continuing to verify the contents of the email and ascertain the source and credibility of the threats.

JNU professor’s Independence Day school address cancelled amid security concerns, academicians protest the move

Sophiya Mathew & Alok Singh
New Delhi, August 14

AN INDEPENDENCE Day address by Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) professor emerita Zoya Hasan at a Delhi school was cancelled last minute on Friday amid security concerns. Sources claimed that a group of 10-15 people, purportedly belonging to a right-wing outfit, had gathered outside the premises in protest and a larger police contingent was subsequently deployed.

Hasan had been invited as the chief guest for Sardar Patel Vidyalaya’s Independence Day and scholarship award ceremony and was scheduled to hoist the national flag and address students. The invitation issued by the school said the programme was to begin at 10 am at its Lodi Estate campus.

The school confirmed to *The Indian Express* that Hasan’s speech and entry had to be cancelled due to security concerns. “Unfortunately, some unruly elements gathered outside the school early in the morning, following which the situation escalated due to political concerns,” a school faculty member aware of the matter said.

The school administration did not comment on whether the decision was taken following a police direction or by the school itself.

The event faced no disruption and was held at the school’s auditorium, school authorities told *The Indian Express*. Gujarat Education Society (GES) president and school alumna Shveta Kalyanwala replaced Hasan. GES is the parent body that manages the school.



JNU professor Zoya Hasan

The Delhi Police said it was informed by the school about a security threat, and that the school must have taken the decision to cancel Hasan’s participation. Denying having forced the cancellation, police said its personnel were deployed only to provide protection.

Reacting to claims that the VHP was involved, President Alok Kumar said, “I have per-

sonally verified this. I am stating with full responsibility that the VHP had nothing to do with the said incident.”

VHP national spokesperson Vinod Bansal, in a post on X late Friday, said, “The claim by a section of the media that a protest was held there by the Vishva Hindu Parishad is nothing but a misleading report. We have no connection whatsoever with that so-called protest.”

He, however, added, “It is not appropriate for a prestigious school in the capital, named after Sardar Patel ji and inspired by him, to invite as the chief guest a person who has herself insulted our Iron Man. We are pleased that the school administration, taking cognizance of this matter, has barred such a person from its program, thereby protecting the students’ minds from any new in-

fection that he might spread.”

“It is in the interest of society to keep all such anti-national accomplices and associates of the ‘tukde-tukde gang’ away from public platforms.”

Hasan, a political scientist, was expected to speak to students on pluralism.

When contacted, she said she’d been formally invited by SPV on August 14, with principal Anuradha Joshi in touch with her over the past couple of weeks.

“Today at 8.30 am, I received a message from the teacher concerned that she... would be reaching my residence by 9.30 am,” Hasan said.

However, the professor said the school’s security head arrived instead and informed her that the event had been cancelled. She said the security head told her police had arrived at the school after a protest and

were “very concerned” about Hasan’s security as well as that of the students. Hasan said she had not been contacted directly by the police.

She also said she’d told the school that her topic would be ‘Why pluralism matters’, and no concerns were raised. “They were not suggesting what I should speak on, and to be fair, neither did they suggest I shouldn’t speak on this,” Hasan said.

Academicians protested the move. Economist Jayati Ghosh alleged on X that police had prevented Hasan from speaking at the event and that school authorities had been forced to cancel the programme on security grounds.

Academic Apoorvanand also alleged that police should have restrained the protesters rather than prevent Hasan from meeting students.

80वें स्वतंत्रता दिवस

की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएं

तेजी से विकसित होते भारत की एक झलक

कृत्रिम उपग्रह

अंतरिक्ष में भारत

उड़ान भरता भारत

महिला सशक्तिकरण

शिक्षा का प्रसार

जान और अनुसंधान

स्वास्थ्य सेवा

स्टार्टअप और नवाचार

आत्मनिर्भर भारत

मजबूत रक्षा

सशक्त किसान

कृषि समृद्धि

स्वच्छ ऊर्जा

एक्सप्रेसवे और बेहतर सड़कें

मेट्रो का विस्तार

स्पीड और स्केल

डिजिटल इंडिया

इनोवेशन

स्वतंत्र भारत

सशक्त भारत। समृद्ध भारत। विकसित भारत

नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री

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रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

Amul

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HAPPY INDEPENDENCE DAY



*Brand Finance's Global Food & Drinks Report, 2024.
*ICA World Cooperative Monitor, 2025.



Why Integrated Theatre Commands Could Soon Become Reality

India’s plan to reorganise its military under Integrated Theatre Commands (ITCs) appears to be entering a decisive phase, with the government considering the final restructuring roadmap and the armed forces moving steadily towards greater jointness.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi first placed the broader vision of a more integrated military at the centre of defence reform in his August 15, 2019, Independence Day address, stating that India could no longer afford a fragmented approach to military power. The creation of the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) and the Department of Military Affairs followed, with theatre commands identified as a key next step.

At its core, theatrisation means bringing Army, Navy and Air Force capabilities assigned to a particular geographical or strategic theatre under one operational commander. Instead of individual services planning and fighting largely through separate command structures, forces would operate as a single joint formation.

The urgency is being driven by the changing character of warfare. Future conflicts are unlikely to remain confined to land, sea or air. Cyber operations, satellites, artificial intelligence, drones, autonomous systems, long-range precision weapons and information warfare are increasingly

interconnected. India’s military therefore needs to generate effects across several domains simultaneously.

That is where integrated commands become important. A unified commander could reduce delays in inter-service coordination, improve the use of scarce assets and enable faster operational decisions. Joint logistics and common planning could also reduce duplication and improve resource utilisation.

The reform already has an important legal foundation. The Inter-Services Organisations (Command, Control and Discipline) Act, 2023 gives commanders of joint organisations authority over personnel from the three services, creating a framework for unified command and discipline.

The proposed architecture has included geographically focused theatres, including northern and Western Fronts, alongside a maritime command. Meanwhile, specialised tri-service capabilities in cyber, space, communications, drones and cognitive warfare are being developed.

Future wars will be contests of integration, of sensors, shooters, data, intelligence and decision-making. India’s theatre command project is therefore an attempt to ensure that its Army, Navy and Air Force do not merely fight alongside one another but fight as one force.

“

India’s journey towards Atma Nirbhar Bharat in Defence is a decisive step towards strengthening national security and strategic autonomy. With a growing focus on indigenous design, development and manufacturing, India is steadily reducing dependence on foreign defence technologies and supply chains. The emergence of capable Indian defence companies, startups and MSMEs has accelerated innovation across critical domains including unmanned systems, counter-drone technologies, surveillance, electronic warfare and advanced weapon systems. Atma Nirbharta is not merely about import substitution; it is about building a resilient defence ecosystem with indigenous intellectual property, advanced manufacturing capabilities and globally competitive products. Sustained collaboration between the Armed Forces, DRDO, industry and academia will be instrumental in making India a self-reliant defence power and a credible global defence technology partner.”

LT. CDR. JOHN LIVINGSTONE (RETD.),
Founder & CEO, Johnette Technologies

THALES IN INDIA: A Strategic Partner for India's Self-Reliance in a Dynamic Defence Landscape

The geopolitical environment is evolving rapidly, reshaping the nature of warfare and redefining national security priorities. As India places strategic autonomy and self-reliance at the heart of its defence and technological ambitions, Thales’ long-standing commitment to the country has never been more aligned with its vision.

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To strengthen India’s defence and aerospace ecosystem, we have systematically invested in local teams, industry partnerships, and in-country capabilities. Today, 2,400+ employees work with Thales and our JVs in India. Our Engineering Centres in Bengaluru and Noida serve as hubs of innovation in cybersecurity, defence, and aerospace, while our MRO centre in Gurugram supports avionics maintenance and modernisation. The launch of Thales Research & Technology

Mr. Ankur Kanaglekar,
Vice President - India, Thales

INDIAN ARMY TRANSFORMS: Building A Force for Future Warfare

From the traditional manpower-intensive model to a leaner, the Indian Army is transforming itself into technology-enabled force ready for the challenges of future warfare.

At the heart of this transformation is a battlefield where drones, artificial intelligence, electronic warfare, cyber capabilities and precision weapons increasingly determine the speed and outcome of operations. The Army is consequently working to integrate drones into formations while connecting surveillance, intelligence and strike capabilities through increasingly networked systems.

Drones have emerged as one of the clearest symbols of this change. Instead of treating unmanned systems as specialised equipment, the Army is moving towards a layered architecture combining surveillance drones, armed platforms and counter-drone systems with artillery, air defence, electronic warfare and intelligence assets. The objective is to detect threats faster, identify targets in real time and shorten the gap between finding a target and engaging it.

The lessons of Operation Sindoor further reinforced this approach. The operation underlined the need for real-time intelligence, precision engagement, unmanned systems and coordinated response in a rapidly evolving conflict. For the Army, the experience has strengthened the case for preparing for short, intense wars in which technological superiority can be decisive.

Structural changes are accompanying the technological shift. New formations and capabilities, including Bhairav Battalions, Rudra All Arms Brigades, Ashni Platoons, Shaktibaan Regiments and Divyastra Batteries, are part



dependence on foreign supply chains while encouraging faster innovation.

The transformation is ultimately about changing how the Army fights. Future battlefields will span physical, digital, electromagnetic and cognitive domains.

The Indian Army’s challenge, and its opportunity, is to ensure that technology, organisation and the soldier evolve together into a force capable of responding faster, striking more precisely and adapting continuously.

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The spirit of freedom

(From left) Ahead of India's 80th Independence Day, last-minute preparations were in full-swing at the Red Fort in Old Delhi on Friday; Delhi Assembly illuminated with the Tricolour. AMIT MEHRA

• Skywatch



Forecast: August 15, 2026

Generally cloudy sky. Very light rain to light rain.

MAX: 31-33

0.8°C below normal

MIN: 25-27

1.5°C above normal

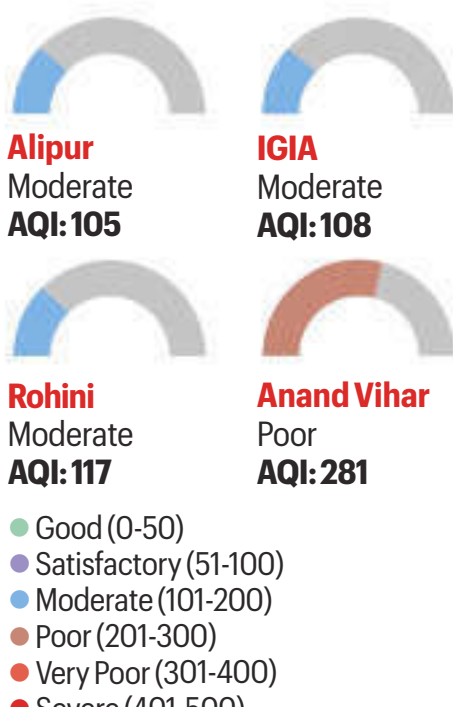
• *Sunrise: 5:51 AM (August 16)*

• *Sunset: 7:01 PM (August 15)*

• *Moonrise: 9:19 AM (August 16)*

• *Moonset: 8:36 PM (August 15)*

• AQI Tracker



Master Plan 2047: High-rises could soon come up on Capital's third Ring Road

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 14

DELHI COULD soon see high-rises along the Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II), a 75-km corridor that stretches from the Capital to Haryana. The proposed Master Plan for Delhi (MPD) 2047 envisages compact, mixed-use development along the corridor, with buildings of up to 10 floors under a new High Density Corridor (HDC) policy. MPD 2047 was approved by the DDA earlier this week and is awaiting the Centre's approval.

In 2025, Prime Minister Narendra Modi opened the Alipur-Dichaon Kalan stretch of UER-II — also known as Delhi's third Ring Road — and links to Bahadurgarh and Sonapat. Of its total length, around 54.2 km falls within Delhi.

The policy

The HDC policy is envisioned to optimise land use along the executed stretch of UER-II in Planning Zones K-I, L, N, P-I and P-II. It states that the objective is to "enable seamless connectivity, reduce travel demand and optimise utilisation of road and public transport infrastructure", while promoting "sustainable, walkable urban growth" along UER-II.

The proposed HDC will comprise a 250-metre-wide corridor on either side of UER-II. Officials said the policy will also apply to future stretches of UERs proposed in the Master Plan once they are executed.

Height of buildings

As per the policy, eligible plots in the corridor will be allowed a floor area ratio (FAR) of up to 400. This could work out to roughly 10 floors where the maximum permissible ground coverage of 40% is used. "The actual height of individual buildings, however, would remain subject to regulations," said an official. A major incentive for participating landowners is the higher FAR: the policy allows a maximum permissible FAR of 400 for residential, commercial and public/semi-public (PSP) use.

The policy also allows a "vertical mix of uses", except on plots earmarked for warehousing and logistics. This means residential and non-residential



During the launch of the UER-II last year. FILE

uses can be accommodated vertically within a development, subject to separate entries, exits and other requirements.

The high-density development does not mean every plot along the road can automatically have a high-rise building. Participation in the policy is also voluntary. Landowners who do not opt for it will continue to be governed by the prevailing Master Plan provisions.

A K Jain, former principal commissioner of the DDA, said the policy allows a FAR of up to 400, with maximum permissible ground coverage of 40%. "If you develop a group housing society, the ground coverage

can go up to 40%. But if the ground coverage is kept at 25%, the number of floors can increase and buildings can go beyond 15-20 storeys. It also depends on the architect. In areas where there are no restrictions, 30-40-storey buildings can also come up," he said.

Jain, however, said the government should first focus on ensuring social equity and then bringing in private players, so that economically weaker sections have access to better housing.

Another DDA official said there is also a bonus FAR of 100, taking the total permissible FAR to 500 in certain cases. "The UER-II connects North Delhi

with South Delhi. Unlike the previous policy, the plan particularly focuses on the new urbanisable areas along these routes. There are no height restrictions except around the airport and other restricted areas. The permissible ground coverage is between 25 and 40 per cent. Leaving aside locations where there are restrictions, other areas can definitely see high-rise residential complexes with 30-40 floors," the official said.

The official added that developers could also opt for a high-rise, multi-storey tower at the centre of a project while leaving larger portions of the site as green areas.

The criteria

For a plot to qualify, the final HDC plot must have a minimum plot size of 4,000 square metres. This requires surrendering 50% of the "Original Plot" area, which must be a minimum of 8,000 square metres. The policy states that FAR benefits will be provided to HDC plots for the portion of land surrendered to the DDA beyond the maximum limit of land deductions of 50%, for

road widening and public facilities. This, however, is subject to approval.

Affordable housing

The affordable housing provision is another key feature. The policy mandates that "20% of the permissible FAR" be used for affordable housing, with dwelling units of less than 60 square metres carpet area.

HDC rules

It will not apply to environmentally sensitive areas, low-density areas, monument-prohibited and heritage areas, or cantonment and defence areas, said officials. The policy also proposes an HDC fund, with charges paid by landowners.

Faster approvals

The committee responsible for sanctioning HDC projects will have a maximum 60-day time limit to approve a complete proposal, including the building plans. If approval or rejection is not communicated within 60 days, the project will be deemed approved on the DDA's Online Building Permit System, states the plan.

12-yr-old girl on way to I-Day function in school killed as DTC bus hits scooter

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 14



Kayna Pal, the victim

A 12-YEAR-OLD girl on way to school to attend an Independence Day programme was killed and her uncle seriously injured after a DTC electric bus collided with their scooter in East Delhi's Dallupura on Friday morning. The girl, a student of Class 8, was also run over by the bus after she fell on the road, said police.

Police identified the deceased as Kayna Pal, a Class 8 student who lived with her family in Khichripur. Her uncle, Gajendra Pal (35), was taking her to school in Vasundhara when the accident took place.

"The two were travelling through Kondli towards Dallupura when the DTC electric bus collided with their scooter. The impact was so severe that both fell onto the road and sustained serious injuries," an officer said.

Police took the two to a nearby hospital where doctors declared Kayna dead. Gajendra is undergoing treatment, they added. The bus driver, who allegedly fled the scene after the accident, was later arrested.

Police identified him as S K Murad (45). A case has been registered at New Ashok Nagar police station.

Kayna's father, Aman Pal, a bank manager, was seen wait-

ing outside the mortuary as the body was taken for a post-mortem examination.

"My younger brother was taking her to school for the Independence Day programme when the bus came from the wrong side and struck their scooter. The impact threw the child onto the road, following which her head came under the wheels of the bus," he said.

Kayna is survived by her parents, an eight-year-old sister and a two-year-old brother. The family lives in a joint household with Gajendra. As per her family, Kayna was a bright student and wanted to become an engineer.

Following the incident, angry locals pelted stones at the bus, damaging its front windshield and windows. Eyewitnesses alleged that the driver fled the spot after the collision while passengers were still inside the bus. Police said they controlled the situation from escalating.

Once DDA notifies area for town planning, participation must

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 14

THE MASTER Plan for Delhi-2047 has introduced town planning schemes (TPS) as an alternative under the existing land pooling policy — as per which it is mandatory for landowners in a particular area to pool their land together — allowing the DDA to require landowners in notified areas to participate in planned development.

The move is aimed at overcoming the disputes and delays that have stalled the policy. The DDA sees land pooling as a key route to address the city's housing shortage, with the potential to unlock up to 20 lakh homes.

What is land pooling?

Under the existing system, private landowners assemble their parcels for development.

They give 40% of the pooled land to the DDA for roads, parks and other public infrastructure, while retaining 60% for residential and commercial development. Until recently, the DDA would acquire land directly. But the acquisition, as per DDA, has become increasingly tedious due to high costs, litigation and procedural delays.

The policy seeks to create world-class neighbourhoods with high-rises in the rural belt of Outer Delhi, such as Narela, Bawana and Najafgarh, where haphazard development is currently underway.

Why has it struggled?

It was first introduced in the 2007 Delhi Master Plan-2021. Regulations followed in 2013 and were revised in 2018, covering 138 sectors across six zones. However, eight years on, no

work has begun in any sector.

There are several reasons behind it:

■ **Land assembly difficult:** Owners had to persuade others to participate and prepare layout plans, often resulting in disputes.

■ **Forming a consortium was a hurdle:** Landowners of at least 70% of contiguous land in a sector had to come together to form a consortium (a representative body that will take decisions) before a scheme could even be processed. With some sectors covering two or three villages, there were frequent disagreements between landowners.

■ **No fixed timeline for development:** Rural landowners were expected to give up their land in exchange for a rise in the value of the property they get in return. However,

there was no fixed timeline for when work would begin.

What has changed?

Under a TPS, landowners assemble parcels, which are then reconstituted after land is deducted for roads, open spaces and infrastructure and other services.

Most importantly, once the DDA notifies an area under a TPS, participation will be mandatory, unlike the existing land pooling scheme. It is a more structured method, which has been used in Gujarat.

Jagan Shah, former head of the National Institute of Urban Affairs and currently Professor of Practice at IIT Delhi, welcomed the availability of different mechanisms to assemble and redevelop urban land. He, however, cautioned, "The DDA has the discretion in selecting

areas it notifies under TPS, which gives rise for opportunities of rent-seeking." There are several other key changes too:

■ **Forming a consortium is not necessary anymore.** Under the new policy, landowners with contiguous parcels above 20 hectares can approach the DDA directly.

■ **Plan permits "any other model"** to be specified through future regulations. This gives the DDA flexibility in implementation. "The DDA shall act as a main anchor for preparation of schemes and development of all roads, parks and playgrounds, utilities, services, social infrastructure, social housing etc. as per the approved scheme," the plan stated.

■ **Land-use changes for individual parcels** that do not conform to a sector plan will take place automatically.

Why is it needed?

Delhi's affordable housing supply has collapsed even as its population has grown. According to data from real estate consultancy Anarock, the share of newly-launched homes priced below Rs 40 lakh fell from 62% in 2020 to just 11% last year, while units priced above Rs 1.5 crore rose from 13% of new supply in 2019 to 70% in 2024.

Much of the city's legal housing growth has moved to Gurgaon, Faridabad and Noida, since Delhi lacks regulations for high-density greenfield construction. This has resulted in unauthorised and haphazard growth on the city's fringes: internal DDA assessments show over 3,500 hectares — land the size of 4,900 football fields — has come under unauthorised construction in land pooling areas.

• ONE OF INDIA'S BIGGEST WHOLESALE MARKETS OF ITS KIND, SAY TRADERS

From Lal Kuan to the skies: How Old Delhi's kite market comes alive for I-Day

Anusree KC
New Delhi, August 14

THE LANE from Chawri Bazar Metro station to Lal Kuan Bazaar Road is rarely still — e-rickshaws honk in impatient bursts, bikes squeeze through impossible gaps and shopkeepers unload sacks of goods.

But look up, and the crowded Old Delhi market reveals another world: paper kites in every colour hang at narrow stalls, with faces ranging from Doraemon, Super Mario, Pokémon and Chhota Bheem to Spider-Man, and Karan Aujla. For a few weeks every year, ahead of Independence Day, Lal Kuan — described by traders as one of India's biggest wholesale kite markets — transforms into a market full of shops

overflowing with kites and saddis (plain cotton thread).

"At least 200 people come every day, but only around 150 actually buy," says Jamal Ahmed (54), who has run Ayaan Party Store for five years.

A kite enthusiast, Jamal knows where the best of the lot comes from. "The kites from Bareilly are the most in demand, as they are of good quality and reasonably priced. The ones from Rampur are the cheapest but those from Moradabad are the finest. But they are expensive," he says.

Prices range from Re 1 to Rs 1,500, depending on size and quality, and rise as August 15 approaches, he adds.

A few shops away, Mohammad Khalid (75) of Haji Kite House has seen the market

change since 1972, when his father first opened the store.

He rattles off kite sizes — Majholi, the regular-sized kite; Addhi; Pauni and Tawa, the largest. "The smaller kites are mostly made of plastic, usually printed with cartoon and superhero characters," he says.

The biggest kite available in the market — 6 Tawa — is used in competitions. The term "tawa" refers to the sizing scale based on standard paper sheets. These kites require a stronger Panda saddi to support its weight, he says. The length of the *charkhis* — spools, the thread winder used to control and navigate a kite — also vary. Beginners usually start with 250-500 m, while festival *charkhis* can hold 1,000 to 2,000 m of thread.



People buy kites at the Lal Kuan market. TASHI TOBGYAL

However, not every trader is a permanent fixture in the market. Mohammed Adil (26) travelled from Jaipur to set up R

B Rajasthan Patang House for the summer and Independence Day season. "We go to Bikaner, Jaipur and Delhi. We came to

Delhi two months ago, during the summer holiday season, when the sales season began. It will last until August 15."

He orders in bulk and well ahead of time. "One bundle consists of 5,000 pieces, and about 20-22 bundles are prepared at once," he adds, with stock booked two to three months in advance from suppliers in Bareilly and Jaipur.

The market, meanwhile, is caught between *saddi* and *manja* — abrasive, glass- or adhesive-coated specialised string used to fly a kite. Though *manja*, which is banned, is not sold in the market, traders like Utkarsh Gupta say *saddi* often

gets swept up in raids meant for nylon threads and manjas.

The National Green Tribunal had banned nylon and glass-coated kite string across India in 2017 after linking it to injuries and deaths involving people, birds and animals. Delhi's own ban has been in

force since January 2017, with violations carrying fines and up to five years of imprisonment. Many competitive flyers use *saddi* on the lower or handling parts of their set-up to protect their hands, reserving *manja* for the cutting edge.

For Utkarsh of Virender Trading Company, now in its fourth generation, the problem

is the confusion between *manja* and the traditional cotton *saddi* sold in the market.

But what survives, ban or no ban, is the pull of the festival itself. Abu Sufiyan Khan, founder of Tales of City, an experiential heritage and cultural tourism platform, has spent five years organising a rooftop kite-and-fireworks gathering timed to August 15. His Patang Aur Pech Festival, which began with 30 guests, has grown to nearly 200.

Astha Singh attended Abu's event in Old Delhi. "I did not know that Independence day is celebrated like Diwali in Old Delhi. We were all flying kites and as the dusk settled over Chandni Chowk, fireworks joined the kites in the sky. It is a sight to behold," she says.



The Indian EXPRESS

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RAMNATH GOENKA

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BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Bar Council breaks law to crawl, its chief must go

THE BAR COUNCIL of India has rolled back its illegal, arbitrary and overreaching direction to State Bar Councils to not enrol 2026 graduates of NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad. But that cannot, and should not, be the end of the matter. It is necessary to rewind and pause on the now-withdrawn decision — to see how it combines a repressive reading of citizens’ fundamental rights with an overblown understanding of the restrictions that can be imposed on them; how the BCI arrogates to itself powers that are not, by law, vested in it; how the institutional failure of the Bar to hold up its end undermines the justice delivery system. The BCI’s attempt to impose blanket restrictions and administer collective punishment on an entire batch of law students came after about 450 students of NALSAR objected to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant attending their convocation as chief guest — earlier, a remark by the CJI had become the trigger for the formation of the Cockroach Janta Party, and another comment on the students’ protests subsequently seemed to underline perceptions of the Court’s insensitivity. On Friday, CJI Surya Kant himself snubbed the BCI: “It’s a dialogue between students and me. Who are they (BCI) to unnecessarily raise an issue?” The CJI’s rebuke is welcome and reassuring. But the need remains urgent for the BCI to conduct an honest reckoning.

The BCI is mandated to regulate legal education, recognise law degrees, supervise State Bar Councils, exercise disciplinary jurisdiction over advocates. Its abortive bid to curb the freedom of expression of young citizens and cramp their right to disagree with a constitutional authority by blackballing them is a blatant misuse of its powers. The Advocates Act, 1961, under which the BCI was established as an independent statutory authority, provides a finite list of grounds for disqualification from enrolment — participation in a peaceful students’ campaign is certainly not one of them. In its zeal to cosy up to the judicial and/or political establishment, the BCI ignores that the constitutional guarantee of free speech includes the right to protest peacefully, and that the SC has laid down that restrictions must be tailored narrowly. The attempt to silence budding advocates is especially jarring in the aftermath of the students’ protests — it shows an institution that has not learnt any lessons from the movement on the street.

The CJI’s rebuke isn’t enough. BCI chairman Manan Kumar Mishra has embarrassed himself and undermined the institution he leads. The attempt, on his watch, to intimidate tomorrow’s bar and, indeed, the bench, to shrink the spirit of tomorrow’s court, calls for a course correction that can only begin with his exit. If the Bar Council needs to do justice to its mandate, Mishra must go.

Kerch Strait warning, a call for vigilance

IN MARCH 2022, the FAO’s benchmark food price index hit an all-time high, following Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine. More than four years later, those fears of a global food crisis have revived with an escalation of two-way strikes on ports, grain terminals and cargo vessels across the Black Sea, Kerch Strait and Sea of Azov. From an agricultural trade perspective, the intensified tensions in this region arguably pose a greater threat today than the conflict in West Asia. The world has somewhat adjusted to the supply disruptions from the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz. This was also the case with Russia-Ukraine, where the initial cycle of major missile and drone exchanges had given way to a gradual resumption of grain shipments.

That period of relative calm has been shattered by the effective halting of operations in the Greater Odesa port complex that handles about 90 per cent of Ukraine’s agricultural produce exports. More than 80 per cent of Russia’s grain exports move through ports on the Sea of Azov and the Black Sea, which have all again been targets of Ukrainian attacks. The resultant paralysis of export trade can spill over into a global food supply crisis similar to that in 2022. Russia and Ukraine together account for over a quarter of the world’s wheat exports, with these shares at roughly 15 per cent in corn and barley and 60 per cent-plus for sunflower oil. Past supply shocks show these spreading from one commodity to another; when sunflower oil becomes scarce, it drives up soyabean and palm oil prices, too.

Those risks are also magnified through the interactions of different “systems” — in the present scenario, that would include both wars (Russia-Ukraine and US-Iran) and weather (El Niño and European heatwaves). A perfect storm from such interactions cannot be ruled out. All the more reason for policymakers to stay vigilant. The Modi government can be credited with reasonably insulating Indian consumers and farmers from the shortages in transport fuels, LPG, LNG and urea triggered by the West Asia war. Similar supply-side management may be required if the Kerch Strait becomes no less a cause for concern than Hormuz.

The historian who looked from the margins

IN *Essays of a Lifetime: Reformers, Nationalists, Subalterns*, Sumit Sarkar writes: “As the shining promise at the dawn of Independence began to dim by the late 1960s and early ’70s, and as a new wave of popular struggles began in various forms against the post-colonial ruling classes, I felt it was more important to explore the historical limits of mainstream nationalism”. Sarkar, who died on Thursday, did not focus just on nationalist icons. He explored the textures of the lives of farmers, workers, lower caste and class communities.

Sarkar entered academia when modern Indian history was still largely framed through the binary of colonial oppression versus Indian resistance. From his first major work, *The Swadeshi Movement in Bengal*, he demonstrated how ordinary people could be both hierarchical and democratic, communal and nationalist. This commitment to history from below found its most eloquent expression in *Modern India*, the textbook that helped make him one of the founding figures of Subaltern Studies. Sarkar would eventually distance himself from the group as it increasingly turned towards cultural theory. The historian, he believed, had to take the challenge of communalism head-on.

Sarkar the historian was inseparable from the public intellectual who refused to submit to doctrine. The teacher, whose classes in Delhi University brought alive the possibilities of Marxist social history, would return the Rabindra Puraskar in protest against West Bengal’s Left Front government’s treatment of the Nandigram protest. As history textbooks continue to be “streamlined” and “rationalised”, Sarkar’s words in *Essays of a Lifetime* resonate: “So far, we Indian historians have written the histories that we wanted to write, following no agenda but our own. That seems to be a fast-vanishing luxury.”

The nationalism that evokes pride, the nation we are

INDEPENDENCE DAY discourses, speeches and poetry oscillate between, to borrow Freudian terms, the pleasure principle and the reality principle. The pleasure principle is the affirmation of India’s grandeur. It offers, like all nationalisms, a vicarious sense of pride, achievement and hope. No political project, especially a nation, can thrive without a sense of pride, the mechanism by which we produce identification with a people or a cause. It is difficult for a politician to be successful without evoking pride, self-belief, and even a sense of romance. Anger and a sense of injustice only get you so far in politics. But almost as a counter-reaction, there is the temptation to counter the pleasure principle with the reality principle: What is the actual state of the nation?

The Hindi poet Raghuvir Sahay was the master of this. In his poem ‘Adhinayak’, he captures the three standard counters used by the reality principle: Authoritarianism, material deprivation and the maintenance of illusion. He poignantly asked: Who is the Adhinayak who makes us sing these praises? Harcharan, the ordinary impoverished citizen, is conditioned to sing the national anthem, without either true freedom or prosperity. The conditioning is to keep up appearances, to go through the liturgical motions of nationalism, keeping the illusion alive for the rulers that all is well. We are asked to sing its songs but are not allowed to speak in our own voices.

Nissim Ezekiel, in ‘The Patriot’, used exaggerated Indian English to mock the superficial nationalism during the Emerg-

ency. The remarkable thing is that every single theme he touched on in 1977 still applies almost verbatim. The first is the gap between the professed fidelity to tradition and actual conduct: The profession of non-violence and paeans to Gandhi do not abate the violence. But how much of the adherence to tradition is performative? “Ancient Indian Wisdom is 100% correct/ I should say even 200% correct/ But modern generation is neglecting — / Too much going for fashion and foreign thing.” There is a reference to unrest: “Other day I’m reading newspaper/ (Every day I’m reading Times of India/ To improve my English Language/ How one goonda fellow/ Threw stone at Indirabehn/ Must be student unrest fellow, I am thinking.” The discerning citizen reads the *goonda* as student unrest.

The conversion of a student-unrest fellow into a *goonda* is the alchemy of the authoritarianism and coercion of Emergency, gestured at in the next lines: “Lend me the ears — / Everything is coming/ Regeneration, Remuneration, Contraception.” There is the genuine concern of the Patriot: “What you think of prospects of world peace? Pakistan behaving like this/ China behaving like that/ It is making me really sad/ I am telling you/ Really, most harassing me.” There is a mocking pun on abstinence being mistaken for complete virtue: “I’m the total teetotaler/ completely total.” And then there is the poignant: “One day Ram Rajya is surely coming.” This very Indian formulation manages to combine complete certainty



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

India is great because now we have to learn to speak of ourselves as great, and the more bombast with which we speak, the more evidence we have of our greatness

An I-Day wish for my daughter



PADMAPRIYA JANAKIRAMAN

ON THIS day in 1947, Jawaharlal Nehru promised the country dignity and opportunity, adding that the pledge would be redeemed “not wholly or in full measure, but very substantially”. Seventy-nine years on, it’s worth asking: Which part of that promise did Indian women actually receive?

Simone de Beauvoir wrote that one is not born a woman but made one. In Indian households, this translates into daily instructions: Sit properly, do not laugh loudly, that job is not for you, ask permission. NO. Shh.

This year, I didn’t just read that sentence, I lived it. Revathy, a fellow actor, and I resigned from an actors’ association in Kerala we’d belonged to for years. Walking away was self-respect. What lingered was the harder question: What does independence mean if you can enter a room but never get to run it?

The issue isn’t only that women don’t get to run the rooms they enter. It’s that we haven’t fully entered most rooms that matter. India produces the world’s highest share of female STEM graduates, yet only 27 per cent reach the STEM workforce. Women hold under 30 per cent of teaching posts in central universities. Among senior advocates, women constitute 3.4 per cent. Women hold just 13 per cent of key department-head roles in entertainment, and at India’s leading newspapers, 87 per cent of editors and proprietors are men.

Kerala’s reckoning makes the point better than any statistic: Be it the Hema Committee report or the allegations and cases that continue to surface across universities, the music industry and cultural institutions. Different stages, same script, same silence beforehand.

On the rare occasion a woman reaches the top of her field, another ceiling awaits. An actress can become the biggest star in her industry and still find the door to directing and producing shut, unlike a male co-star with a fraction of her following. A sportswoman can lead her country to a World Cup and still have little say in how her federation is run.

Somewhere between being visible and being in charge, female ambition gets re-labelled: Difficult, too emotional, not a team player. Expected to absorb it quietly, she gets a word for it when she does: Resilient. We should be less impressed by

how well women endure and more curious about why endurance keeps being the job requirement.

I read an essay this year by a woman describing the 13 years her assault case was in court, how she was sorted endlessly into victim or liar, fragile or ambitious. A complicated person is harder for the system to process than a label. The recent acquittal in the wrestlers’ harassment case belongs here too: A courtroom decides one man’s guilt, but can’t answer whether an athlete has real recourse when the person she complains about also controls her career.

Set against all this is the argument that our laws favour women who pose as victims. Researchers looking for evidence keep finding none. What exists, reliably, is a conviction rate for crimes against women, stuck around one in four, with 19 of 20 cases still in trial. A system rigged in our favour is doing an astonishingly terrible job of it.

The label problem got personal for me this year. A daughter arrived and turned one recently, and the news coverage fixated almost entirely and incorrectly on my age. Male actors, on the other hand, become fathers to celebratory headlines, not an audit of their birth certificates. It’s the same old instinct of reducing a woman to a label easiest to print, skipping the part where she’s an actual person.

Here is what freedom should mean this August 15 — walking home at the hour a brother does, without a lecture attached; unpaid work counted as work, not person-ality; being believed the first time, not the fourth. And for a one-year-old who joined this argument without being consulted, never having to be extraordinary just to receive the dignity that should have arrived with her birth certificate.

Beauvoir wrote: “Representation of the world, like the world itself, is the work of men; they describe it from their own point of view, which they confuse with absolute truth.” She wrote that in a world still deciding whether women deserved a vote. It does not have to remain true by the time my daughter is old enough to read. That’s the only inheritance worth arguing for this Independence Day.

The writer is an actor, producer and co-founder of the Women in Cinema Collective

(surely) with radical uncertainty (one day).

If the pleasure principle demands assurance, the reality principle has to confront the radical uncertainty. Looking at Independence Day speeches, it is quite remarkable how much uncertainty dominates them till Lal Bahadur Shastri’s tenure. Jawaharlal Nehru’s Independence Day speech in 1960 almost gives up on the pleasure principle in favour of the reality principle. It is all the more remarkable because this is before the war with China in 1962. Nehru reminds his audience that only two courses are open to India’s destiny: “Either to hold our heads high and march forward or downfall if we are weak. There can be no middling status for us.” This is meant to be a call for action. But then he immediately goes on to say, “However, this is not in my hands. You have made me Prime Minister for a few days so I am here. There are innumerable defects in me.”

This could be false modesty, absolving himself from blame, or merely reminding his audience that the nation will not be made from declamations from on high. But then comes the mirror to the nation. Referring to India’s Independence, Nehru said “After hundreds of years, India shone once again and the world heard her voice, which had a profound impact because it was the true inner voice of the nation. India began to be respected once again. But very soon the same people of India who had shown great courage seemed to revert to their own weaknesses and began to fight among them-

selves in the name of religion or caste, language and province. The world began to wonder if it had made a mistake in judging this nation.” Shastri’s first speech as Prime Minister was pithy and direct, this time confronting the fact that India was facing a potentially catastrophic food crisis.

In Nehru’s speeches, the confrontation with fragility, vulnerability and uncertainty is central. There is the constant refrain that there are two dispositions that can keep India down. The first is pettiness. Pettiness is not the same as self-interest. Self-interest can at least be tied to prudence; pettiness is more destructive. It is almost as if Nehru is haunted by Gandhi’s remark, that “our besetting sin is not our differences, it is our littleness”. The second is fear. He writes: “Telling lies and deceit are all the offspring of fear.”

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s speeches over the years have been varied. The Viksit Bharat framework has one virtue. It puts a timeline on Ram Rajya’s arrival. Ezekiel’s “one day” is 2047. But Modi is focused on satisfying the pleasure principle of nationalism. That has got trapped in its own circular logic. India is great because now we have to learn to speak of ourselves as great, and the more bombast with which we speak, the more evidence we have of our greatness. In 2014, the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan forcefully confronted India’s filth. But alas for the reality principle, it seems like our national self-esteem has, since then, reached heights our municipal councils are yet to discover.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

I stood up for a fellow citizen. I would do it all over again



DEEPAK KUMAR

WHEN I look at our country today, I feel we have not truly achieved freedom. To me, freedom means a person can breathe freely. That they can live their life with their family, friends, and relatives without fear. That they can practise their religion and interact with their neighbours and society at large with dignity. In recent years, for our fellow Muslim citizens, that freedom has become increasingly harder to come by. This brings shame to our country and Constitution. Every community has sacrificed for India’s independence. This country is made by all of us, it is of all of us, it belongs to us all. This is why I always stand up for my fellow countrymen. In January, I was celebrating Republic Day at a friend’s shop when I noticed that seven to eight men from the Bajrang Dal had barged into the shop of an elderly man, Vakeel Ahmed, and started misbehaving with him over the name of his shop, claiming the word “Baba” belonged to Hindus alone. I tried to calm them down, but when that didn’t work and they started asking me for my name, I said, “My name is Mohammad Deepak.” It was to say to them: We are all Indians.

In the days that followed, Bajrang Dal members put up an Instagram post calling for all “Hindu” men to unite and teach me “a lesson”. Another group of men claiming allegiance to the outfit reached Kotdwar from Dehradun. They hurled threats and abuses against my family in front of my gym. I am willing to die for my country, but when it comes to your family’s safety, you are forced to think of the consequences. I have a five-year-old daughter, a wife, a mother. After the incident, my daughter couldn’t go to school for some time. I was forced to stay inside my house for two-and-a-half months. My gym is my only source of income. I have a house loan and my daughter’s school fees. Before the incident, my gym had 150-200 members; that has dropped to 40-42.

I do not believe these groups’ actions represent the Hindu faith. Even as they accuse the “other” of being against Hinduism, it is they who muddy the name of our religion and gods. They do so by intimidating others and inflicting pain, disrespecting other religions and people in the name of our gods. “Hindus” aren’t angry with me. Recently, I attended an event in Dehradun, attended mostly by Hindus. Nearly everybody came up to me and expressed appreciation for what I had done. I have received love and appreciation from people of all backgrounds, who have helped me at a very difficult time.

I have no regrets, and would do it all over again. As much as I have been harassed, whether by these groups or the police by way of an FIR and summons, I have also been blessed to witness more and more people speaking up for what is right. I see on social media now that when goons come to shut down shops, others resist. People tell me that by raising my voice, I have managed to dent the climate of fear.

Today, the Hindu-Muslim divide has become so deep I fear it will not leave people’s hearts and minds in the foreseeable future. Governments are stoking hate for political gain. My country and its people are so much more than this. If there are wrongdoers, there is no paucity of those willing to stand up for the greater good. Change happens when people stop watching from the sidelines and start facing the situation. The time for that change has come.

The writer owns a gym in Uttarakhand

40 YEARS AGO

August 15, 1986



Sloop on Badal group

THE POLICE arrested more than 100 workers of the Akali Dal, led by Parkash Singh Badal, on the eve of the party’s protest day. The arrests were made throughout Punjab to ensure peace during Independence Day celebrations in the state, official sources said.

Reforms proposed in tax laws

ACCEPTANCE OF self-assessed income-tax returns, increase in the basic general exemption for wealth tax from Rs 2.5 lakh to Rs 5 lakh and extension of benefit of deduction from taxable income to payments made towards cost of new residential property,

including repayment of loan and interest, are among the major proposals for simplification and rationalisation of direct tax laws. The Finance Ministry has also proposed exemption from tax on capital gains from transfer of agricultural land and from shifting of industrial undertakings from congested areas. Existing provisions resulting in computation of artificial or notional income are proposed to be deleted to get a new concept of the real income.

President’s warning

THE PRESIDENT, Zail Singh, asked India to be vigilant over the known efforts by some external powers to take advantage of the situation

for disrupting the unity of the country.

SAARC call to fight terrorism

THE TWO-DAY meeting of the SAARC foreign ministers in Dhaka ended with condemnation of the act of terrorism and calling for concrete measures to fight the menace. The SAARC council of ministers in its first meeting since the launching of the forum in December last year accepted undisclosed recommendations of the study group on terrorism and asked the experts to report on measures of implementation to identify the offences which are to be regarded as terrorist and which, for purposes of extradition, are not to be regarded as political.



From the freedom that was won to the Bharat we build



C P RADHAKRISHNAN

ON THIS great occasion of the 80th Independence Day celebrations of Bharat, I extend my heartiest congratulations to each Bharatvasi. I also pay my respectful tributes to all freedom fighters who sacrificed themselves to secure independence for Bharat.

Last week, during my visit to the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, I had the honour of hoisting our national flag as a part of the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign and commemorating the first hoisting of the Tiranga by our great patriot, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose. It was a deeply moving experience for me to stand on the sacred soil where Netaji's Azad Hind Fauj first raised the Tiranga on Indian territory on December 30, 1943. This occasion also brought to my memory Netaji's visit to Madurai in September 1939 at the invitation of Pasumpun Muthuramalinga Thevar. This historic moment inspired countless patriots of the region.

Another deeply inspiring moment was my visit to the National Memorial Cellular Jail, where the great sons of Mother Bharat, Veer Savarkar, Yogendra Shukla, Batukeshwar Dutt, Sachindra Nath Sanyal, and many others were imprisoned and kept in solitary confinement by the colonial forces. Even today, the walls of the National Memorial echo the stories of courage, suffering, and supreme sacrifice of those who laid down their lives so that Bharat might live in freedom and dignity. The visit inspired me to pen this article as a mark of my homage to all the torchbearers who ignited the flame of patriotism within millions of people, leading the nation towards Independence.

I was immensely pleased to launch the Har Ghar Tiranga Campaign in the Andaman Islands on August 9, as we commemorated the Quit India Movement. In 1942, the Father of the Nation, Mahatma Gandhi, launched the Quit India Movement, giving the nation a stirring slogan, "Do or Die". As a result of this call, a fervent desire for inde-



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

pendence spread across the country. Today, thanks to the generation that stood against the colonial forces, we are fortunate to breathe the air of freedom and live with constitutional rights under a democratic system. Millions of freedom fighters across the nation fought with unwavering dedication and sacrifice, and many laid down their lives to see our Mother Bharat free.

Freedom fighters, be they from Kashmir in the north or Tamil Nadu in the south, from Gujarat in the west or Assam in the east, people belonging to all regions, backgrounds, ages, and genders, joined together for one common goal — the freedom of Mother Bharat.

The valour of Rani Lakshmi Bai of Jhansi, the enduring symbol of resistance during the First War of Independence; the courage of Mangal Pandey, the fearless call of Bal Gangadhar Tilak, who awakened a nation with the declaration, "Swaraj is my birthright, and I shall have it" — every voice strengthened the march towards freedom. V O Chidambaram Pillai challenged colonial economic domination by launching India's first indigenous shipping enterprise, proving that the fight for independence was waged not only on the battlefield

I pay homage to Tiruppur Kumaran, known as Kodi Kaatha Kumaran (Kumaran, the protector of the flag). He came to be known by this title after sacrificing his life in Tiruppur (my hometown), refusing to let the national flag fall even in the face of death

but also in commerce. The revolutionary zeal of Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev inspired generations to embrace sacrifice in the cause of liberty, while the indomitable spirit of Rani Gaidinliu kept the flame of resistance burning in the Northeast against British rule. In Assam, the young Kanaklata Barua, carrying the national flag with unflinching courage, laid down her life while leading the Quit India Movement. Bhagwan Birsa Munda and many other tribal leaders led historic resistance against colonial rule. Many more are the stories of resilience, courage and determination that can be pulled out from the pages of history. Together, they form a rich tapestry of courage and sacrifice, reminding us that India's freedom was won through the collective resolve of countless heroes whose legacy continues to inspire generations.

As we celebrate this Independence Day, I pay homage to Tiruppur Kumaran, popularly known as Kodi Kaatha Kumaran (Kumaran, the protector of the flag). He came to be known by this title after sacrificing his life in Tiruppur (my hometown) during the freedom struggle, refusing to let the national flag fall even in the face of death.

Even at a young age, the flame of patriotism burned brightly in

Kumaran's heart. Inspired by the call "Swaraj is our birthright", he joined the freedom struggle. Deeply influenced by Mahatma Gandhi's ideals, Kumaran founded the Desabandhu Youth Association to awaken the spirit of nationalism within the people, especially the youth. Kumaran firmly believed that true freedom could be achieved only when people became conscious of the injustices of colonial rule and developed the courage and clarity to resist them. Committed to Gandhian principles of social reform, he actively championed the cause of prohibition, viewing it as an essential step towards social and national regeneration. As part of this, he participated in the picketing of toddy shops, encouraging people to shun alcohol and embrace self-discipline in the larger cause of India's freedom.

Holding the national flag in his hands and accompanied by a few brave souls, Kumaran led a march on January 10, 1932, during the Civil Disobedience Movement. Powerful chants of "Vande Mataram" echoed in the streets of Tiruppur. The colonial forces attacked the group and Kumaran sustained head injuries, laying down his life for the nation with 'Vande Mataram' on his lips and the flag held close to his body. He was only 27 years old.

As I write down the age of Tiruppur Kumaran, I am reminded of other youths who sacrificed their lives for Mother Bharat, including Bhagat Singh (23), Sukhdev (23), Rajguru (22), Khudiram Bose (18), Kanaklata Barua (18), Anant Laxman Kanhere (19) and Vanchinathan (25), and many more.

I commend the initiative of Prime Minister Narendra Modi in bringing the unsung heroes of our national movement to the centre stage. I pay my tributes to the known and the unknown freedom fighters.

On this momentous occasion, let us reflect and renew our commitment to our motherland. Let us dedicate ourselves to building a Viksit Bharat @ 2047 in this Amrit Kaal and work together for the progress and prosperity of our nation. That will be the most fitting tribute we can pay to the bravehearts who fought with unwavering courage and sacrificed their lives to win our freedom.

Jai Hind. Long live Mother Bharat.

The writer is the Vice President of India

For decades after 1947, socialism was the shackle



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

SEVERAL POSTS on social media have underlined how the Leader of the Opposition ignored two leading corporate leaders at a private function in Delhi. His constant diatribe against the economy and vilification of those corporate giants were in the news. They remind us of the early decades of Independence, when socialism became the fad of the ruling class and hatred for profits and wealth creators was the prevailing order.

A recently released movie on an OTT platform deals with the consequences of that socialist mindset. It shows how in early 1991, India's forex reserves tumbled below \$1 billion, creating a massive balance of payments crisis. People attribute India's economic turnaround to the reforms brought about by P V Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh. But the film highlights the role played by Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar, who was running a lame-duck government in 1990-91.

The crisis was so acute that then RBI governor S Venkitaramanan said that the only option left was to mortgage India's gold reserves to the Bank of England and the Bank for International Settlements, Switzerland and borrow dollars. Chandra Shekhar, who began his political career under the tutelage of socialist stalwarts like Acharya Narendra Dev and Ram Manohar Lohia, faced an ideologi-

On this Independence Day, when India has comfortable forex reserves of \$700 billion, including 880 tonnes of gold reserves, we can breathe easy

cal dilemma. But Venkitaramanan convinces him that the country is more important than his socialism.

On this Independence Day, when India has comfortable forex reserves of \$700 billion, including 880 tonnes of gold reserves, we can breathe easy

It began with Jawaharlal Nehru's visit to Moscow in 1927 to participate in the decennial celebrations of the October Revolution. He started calling himself a socialist after his return and declared in 1929, as the president of the Indian National Congress, that "India will have to go the socialist way". When he persisted with this rhetoric, a revolt happened in the Congress Working Committee in 1936. Seven senior leaders, including Sardar Patel, Rajendra Prasad, C Rajagopalachari, J B Kripalani and Jammnalal Bajaj, resigned. Gandhi had to elicit a commitment from Nehru that he would not make socialism Congress's official policy. Nehru was forced to honour that commitment as long as Gandhi and Patel were alive. But after 1950, he returned to his pet theme.

In 1955, the Congress session in Avadi, Tamil Nadu passed a resolution declaring a "socialist pattern of society" as the goal of his govern-

ment. Policies that emphasised state-led growth and discouraged individual entrepreneurship through the licence-permit-quota system were put in place through five-year plans. The results were evident soon. The decadal data in 1965 showed that the poverty rate in the country had gone up from 52.66 per cent to 58.60 per cent. India was the only country to have continued with food rationing two decades after World War II. Agricultural productivity remained one of the lowest in the world. Lohia created a flutter in Parliament in 1963 when he asserted that 270 million Indians were living on a horribly meagre income of three annas (19 paise) a day while Nehru's pet dog cost nearly three rupees a day.

Despite this disastrous experience, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi continued with those policies and used the infamous 42nd Amendment to insert "Socialism" into the Preamble. China discarded the fallacy of socialism in 1978, when Deng Xiaoping introduced "Four Modernisations". The Soviet Union simply collapsed in the early 1990s. We finally managed to shed the socialist baggage in 1991 and began the new journey of economic openness and market reforms.

But those lost decades must not be forgotten, especially when some opposition leaders continue to rubbish our vibrant economy.

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

Jagjivan Ram to Kharge, the distance not covered



ANSHUL AVIJIT

THE CHILLING incident in Haldwani reminds us that caste prejudice will not die until the system itself is throttled. It will show up again and again, like a shapeshifting virus, not just in the meetings of Dalit leaders but in the everyday lives of millions — in schools, playgrounds, offices and temples. Caste in India is the most perverse project of humiliation ever conceived, and in 2026, it is alive and well.

The Haldwani purification rite, after Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge had left the stage, has a personal resonance. In 1978, when my grandfather Babu Jagjivan Ram was deputy prime minister, he went to Ba-

naras to inaugurate the statue of Sampurnanand, an upper-caste Kayastha leader who had been CM of Uttar Pradesh in the 1950s. The venue was at the entrance of Sampurnanand Sanskrit Vishwavidyalaya.

As Jagjivan Ram arrived, the atmosphere was tense with the sneers of right-wing student groups and caste Hindus. The paradox of an overachieving Dalit man, wielding great power and turning the caste *dharma* on its head, was the stinging point. As soon as the statue was garlanded, casteist insults were hurled at my grandfather for having defiled the statue of a venerated Hindu elite. After the event, the statue was smeared with cow dung and washed with *gangajal* amid the chanting of Vedic verse.

The incident made national news. In the following session of Parliament, there was an uproar across party lines — from the rul-

ing Janata Party and the Congress opposition — followed by speeches of condemnation, apologies, and demands for inquiry and punishment. Jagjivan Ram is believed to have stayed silent as the debates raged for two days, but one of his comments echoes the sentiment of Congress President Kharge on Haldwani: If this could happen to him in his position, then what is the day-to-day plight of ordinary Dalits? As was the case

For the pro-caste warriors, there was a danger that prejudice was flattening or sub-optimal. That the incident in Haldwani came after the Jantar Mantar protests may not be a coincidence

then, Parliament needs to suspend all else and debate casteism again, particularly because it's 48 years later. Casteism collapses the concept of time and makes it dysfunctional. Regrettably, the reverse is not true.

For the pro-caste warriors, of whom there are far too many, there was a danger that prejudice was flattening or sub-optimal. That the Haldwani incident came after the Jantar Mantar protests may not be a coincidence. "Gen Z" may be a temporal category, but these socially diverse protesters had deep ideological moorings and awareness. Social justice and inclusivity seemed fundamental to the agitation even though the immediate target was the paper leaks. To the upholders of classical *dharma*, irreverent, wokeish interlopers, especially masses of youngsters, were dangerous and needed to be dealt with. The recently whitewashed NCERT text-

books that blanketed out the existence of caste-based prejudice altogether had clearly not made any impact. Which is why there has been a concerted effort by caste votaries and saffron groups to politely reach out to the protestors, hoping to co-opt them. Others in Haldwani have had to enact de-contamination rituals as a symbolic assertion of caste power and a warning to potential disrupters. Both reactions have a common impulse.

In liberal circles, there has always been talk about ending discrimination and bigotry, most of it insincere, some patronising, some even well-meaning. But this misses the point. It is the caste system that is the head of the snake; all discrimination flows from it. It is this that must go. Perhaps this defining generation will decide its future.

The writer is national spokesperson, Congress

How independent does my state want me to be?



SIDDHESH GAUTAM

EVERY YEAR on Independence Day, I find myself wondering about two different worlds. One is the world of the nation of flags, speeches, celebrations and the nostalgia of freedom from colonial rule. The other is a more intimate world, the world of lived experiences, where independence feels limited, unevenly distributed and often denied. These two worlds keep floating in my head, conflicting and yet coexisting.

As someone who comes from a Scheduled Caste background, I often try to understand independence through the memories and histories of marginalised communities. What did freedom mean for us before the departure of the alien ruler? And what did it become afterwards as we remain dependent on other forms of power, of caste hierarchies, social exclusion and inherited inequalities? For many people, independence is a feeling, a philosophical idea and even a state of mind. Perhaps it can be, if one possesses land, labour, resources and social acceptance. But for the rest of us, independence remains a deeply political and material question. It remains, in many ways, a state affair.

I often ask myself: How independent does my state want me to be? What freedoms does it encourage, and what dependencies does it cultivate? Who is allowed to dream, dissent, organise and love? These questions become difficult to ignore when we look around us. We celebrate freedom in a country where Dalits are still murdered for asserting dignity, where Adi-vasi communities continue to lose their forests and homes for the benefits of a few billionaires, where Muslims are often viewed with suspicion, where Christians are frequently mistrusted, and so on. A nation cannot claim complete independence while entire communities continue to negotiate their basic right to exist with dignity. Freedom cannot merely be the absence of a foreign ruler; it must also be the presence of justice among the people.

I worry, too, about the independence of young minds. We often imagine that today's generation has limitless opportunities. Yet many young people are trapped inside dreams they never chose for themselves. They inherit aspirations manufactured by markets, by algorithms rather than imagination. Success is increasingly defined by consumption, status and competition. We are encouraged to become efficient workers before we become thoughtful citizens. To me, one of the greatest struggles of our time is the struggle to free ourselves from the pressure to chase lives that may be profitable but not meaningful. Independence is not only the freedom to choose between careers or products. It is the freedom to imagine a different society altogether, to ask uncomfortable questions, to



ILLUSTRATION: SIDDHESH GAUTAM

dream beyond what is currently available.

The question of independence becomes more urgent when we think about women and queer people. How independent is a woman if her mobility, safety, clothing or choices are constantly scrutinised? How independent is a queer person if their identity is a subject of debate or meme rather than acceptance?

I also think about the independence of dreamers. Across the country, there are countless young people whose ambitions are not defeated by a lack of talent or hard work, but by corruption, discrimination and caste privilege. They encounter systems that reward connections over merit, hierarchy over potential. If a dream is denied because of caste, gender or social status, it should not merely be observed as an individual tragedy, it must be documented as a national failure.

We often speak proudly about India's diversity, yet we rarely ask whose culture gets celebrated and whose is expected to disappear. Which languages are considered refined? Which histories are preserved? Whose gods, stories and traditions are seen as truly national? Cultural independence cannot mean the dominance of one culture over all others. It must mean the flourishing of many cultures together. A democracy that enforces cultural uniformity eventually weakens its own imagination.

For me, Independence Day is therefore also a reminder of the unfinished work before us. We certainly need freedom from colonial mindsets, but we also need freedom from the discriminatory values. We need independence from caste prejudice, communal hatred, patriarchy, homophobia, corruption and the belief that some lives matter more than others.

India's future depends not only on how we remember our freedom struggle, but also on how honestly we confront the unfreedoms among us. True independence is a continuous project of expanding dignity, justice and possibilities. Only then can Independence Day become more than a commemoration, a promise fulfilled. And then, we will not even need to celebrate independence on one day. We will feel it every day in our skin and bones.

The writer is a graphic artist and author of The Blue Book

Jemimah ruled out of Asia Cup and Asiad due to tear in right hamstring



Jemimah Rodrigues. PTI
Express News Service
Mumbai, August 14

JEMIMAH RODRIGUES has been ruled out of the upcoming Women's Asia Cup and Asian Games after suffering a high-grade right hamstring tear, the BCCI announced on Friday. Rodrigues sustained the injury on August 3 while playing for Southern Brave in The Hundred in England. She subsequently underwent a clinical assessment by the BCCI Medical Team at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru, which confirmed the severity of the injury. "Jemimah Rodrigues sustained a right hamstring injury on 3rd August while playing in The Hundred in England. The BCCI Medical Team clinically assessed her at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru, and the assessment confirmed a high-grade tear. Consequently, she has been ruled out of the upcoming ACC Women's Asia Cup in the UAE and the Asian Games in Japan," a BCCI press release said.

Pratika Rawal has been named Rodrigues' replacement in the Asia Cup squad, and her inclusion offers India an extra batting option at the top. She hasn't yet played a T20I, but has featured in one Test and 27 ODIs. Rawal was bought by UP Warriorz at the Women's Premier League (WPL) auction in November last year but did not play in WPL 2026 after not fully recovering from the ankle injury she sustained during the 2025 ODI World Cup.

Rodrigues was part of India's squad for the T20 World Cup in June and was expected to remain an important part of the team's plans for the Asia Cup and Asian Games.

Rodrigues has played 131 T20Is for India since making her debut against South Africa in 2018 and has scored 2824 runs at a strike rate of 119 with 16 half-centuries. She was part of the Indian side that won gold in the 2023 Asian Games in Hangzhou.

The women's Asia Cup starts on August 28, with India's first match against Thailand on August 30. They will next take on Hong Kong on September 3 before facing Pakistan in their final league stage fixture on September 5.

All matches will be played in Dubai, with the tournament serving as an important part of their preparations ahead of the Asian Games in September.

INDIA'S ASIA CUP SQUAD: Harmanpreet Kaur (C), Smriti Mandhana (VC), Shafali Verma, Bharti Fulmali, Deepti Sharma, Richa Ghosh (WK), G. Kamalini (WK), Arundhati Reddy, Prema Rawat, Radha Yadav, Sree Charani, Renuka Thakur, Nandni Sharma, Kranti Gaud, Pratika Rawal

Ranji Trophy-capped TNPL player fined for anti-corruption breach

Varinder Bhatia & Venkata Krishna B
Chandigarh & Chennai,
August 14

A TAMIL Nadu all-rounder who made his Ranji Trophy debut last season has been barred from featuring in the remainder of the ongoing Tamil Nadu Premier League (TNPL) edition for breaching anti-corruption protocols.

The Indian Express understands that the Anti-Corruption and Security Unit (ACSU) of the BCCI recovered a mobile phone — which the player had not declared — when he was in the Player and Match Officials Area (PMOA).

According to those in the

know, the incident occurred on August 10 at the NPR College ground in Dindigul's Natham. The ACSU reported it to the Tamil Nadu Cricket Association (TNCA) after conducting its probe.

"We have received a letter (from the ACSU) about this incident," TNCA secretary U Bhagawandas Rao said. "We have instructed the team owners not to consider him for selection until the enquiry is over. We are currently investigating the matter and will take appropriate action," he added.

As this is the first instance of this player violating the anti-corruption code, a fine of Rs 1 lakh has been recommended by the ACSU. ACSU sources



A robodog carries the TNPL trophy for the 2025 season. FILE/TNCA

“We have received a letter (from the ACSU) about this incident. We have instructed the team owners not to consider him for selection until the enquiry is over. We are currently investigating the matter and will take appropriate action”

U BHAGAWANDAS RAO,
TNCA SECRETARY ON THE CASE.

confirmed to this paper that the player was caught with a mobile phone, "which is a gross violation of the code of conduct for the players".

Sources in the ACSU added, "The player was confronted first but he could not explain the violation. He was served notice and asked to reply, which he did. His reply too was found unsatisfactory and thus a fine of Rs 1 lakh was imposed on him". The TNCA will decide on additional punishment only after it completes its own investigation. The TNCA summoned the player on Friday for an inquiry. It is understood that though the ACSU didn't find any activity directly linked to contact with bookies in the mo-

bile phone recovered from the player, hiding a communication device from the authorities is a breach of PMOA and anti-corruption protocols.

Once the incident came to light, the player in question was immediately withdrawn from the franchise, which is currently in Dindigul for the first leg of matches that conclude on Saturday before the action shifts to Chennai. The said player didn't feature in the franchise's next match and has also not been included for their fixture on Friday.

According to TNCA officials, other franchises have already been informed about the development and the withdrawal of the player.

INDIA VS SRI LANKA: FIRST TEST MATCH PREVIEW

Staring at India: A Dutch fort, and now familiar spin demons

After chastening by Kiwis and Proteas spinners at home, India's batsmen seeking redemption in the island

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 14

THE GALLE weather in August is unpredictable. It is usually warm and humid like most parts of Sri Lanka. But in the southern coast with the monsoon winding up, showers can show up impromptu. Just like the weather, the strip at the picturesque venue overlooking the Galle Fort can be equally tough to predict, particularly during the second half of a Test. It can create illusions in batsmen's mind, its notorious invariable bounce never makes batsmen feel completely comfortable.

Ajantha Mendis, the mystery spin OG, was eagerly awaiting this showdown as far back in February. "They may well come very well prepared. Because, if New Zealand and South Africa spinners can do it, then Sri Lanka spinners can definitely cause more problems," he had told *The Indian Express*.

On Saturday, when India take the field for the first Test, more than their opponents, their biggest enemy would be the conditions. Against an injury-depleted batting line-up that may struggle to put up a commanding score against a strong India attack, there are enough reasons to be optimistic for an Indian fan. But bring the conditions into equation and the vulnerabilities of Indian batsmen's against tweekers in spin-friendly pitches, where the turn and the bounce is hard to predict, they are staring at a familiar ghost they wouldn't want to frequent.

The last time India visited these shores for a Test series, they blanked the hosts 3-0. But it feels like a different age. They didn't have the best of batsmen to take down the hosts' spinners, yet their collective calibre was such that Sri Lanka couldn't make a match out of the series.

This time, the batting group,



“They may well come very well prepared. Because, if New Zealand and South Africa spinners can do it, then Sri Lanka spinners can definitely cause more problems”

AJANTHA MENDIS,
ON INDIAN BATTERS TACKLING SPIN AFTER DEFEATS AT HOME.

comprising mostly of the future, isn't a shadow of what Sri Lankans are used to witnessing. In the island nation across Palk Strait, it is still a common sight to find old timers regaling about the batsmanship of Sunil Gavaskar and Mohammad Azharuddin against spinners over a malt or arrack.

At shacks or clubs, they have idolised and groomed batsmen who have painted their own success stories.

An Indian team landing in Sri Lanka usually generates interest. This time, though, the story is a little different. With the likes of Virat Kohli, Rohit Sharma, Cheteshwar Pujara and Ajinkya Rahane moving on, the new crop has struggled to make runs in their own backyard. If the whitewash at the hands of New Zealand in 2024 came as a harsh reality, the blanking by South Africa in 2025 felt like the new normal.

Against two teams with spinners who provide exceptional control and stick largely to basics, Indian batsmen



Indian skipper Shubman Gill during a training session ahead of the first Test in Galle. PTI

didn't have any answers. They simply wilted under pressure, sucked into the illusion of demons lurking around, when there was actually none.

Eschewing mistakes

At Galle, a predominantly red-soil surface, the spinners will thrive on bounce. As part of their preparations, India's batting group has been working hard to not repeat the mistakes they committed against New Zealand and South Africa. With batsmen being tentative to employ sweep, and not applying pressure on the spinners by use the feet to come down the track, they ended up in a trap. If they repeat it here, Sri Lanka spinners would be ready to pounce.

"You talk about sweep, but on a red-soil pitch like Galle it can be hard to control with the bounce. If you sweep, you have to pick the right deliveries, not to length deliveries because you can end up top-edging,"

former India batting coach Robin Singh said.

Those are conditions India routinely confronts at home, in particular in Mumbai and Chennai or in certain pockets in the west. India captain Shubman Gill struck the parallels. "The big similarity is spinners play a huge role. The spinners and fast bowlers, when the bowl gets old, they play a huge role," he said.

Bounce plays big role

"The differences (of what) we have seen here in the matches that were played recently, is that there is a good bit of bounce on the wicket. I would say it is similar to playing on a red soil wicket. Here, the spinners get good bounce. There are a lot of dismissals, caught in the slips or the close-in fielders, who play a huge role here with that bounce."

As Mendis said, Sri Lanka's spinners led by left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya

would look to create doubts in the minds of batsmen and make them tentative. When they are tentative, India's batsmen have shown a tendency to get into a shell, thus playing into the hands of the spinners. Adding more pressure are the uncertain spots in the batting line-up and those striving to fix it. Devdutt Padikal faces a litmus test at No 3, while the likes of Rishabh Pant and Dhruv Jurel are out to prove a point or two. If it rains, then there would be help for seamers. If the sun is harsh, the pitch can break open in no time. The word around is that batsmen can breathe easy for the first two days.

So, India's challenge would be to bat big in the first innings, failing which they would be staring at uncertainty. Team for team, India may definitely start favourites, but their biggest opponent would be themselves.

LIVE ON: Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV, 10 am

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 14

SRI LANKA'S two-Test series against India carries significance beyond the rivalry. Sitting sixth in the World Test Championship (WTC) standings, they have little room for error if they are to remain in the race for next year's final.

Sri Lanka have not beaten India in a Test since 2015, but this is an opportunity to make home conditions count and collect points against a side in transition. Their first-Test squad reflects necessity, experience and a search for new options, with injuries ruling out Kusal Mendis and Pathum Nissanka.

The most striking selection is the return of Niroshan Dickwella. The wicketkeeper-batsman is back after last playing in March 2023, and his recall follows a difficult period that included disciplinary issues and a suspension for cocaine use.

"The only thing I have to tell Niroshan Dickwella is to keep well. That's why he's in the team. Dickwella had to leave the Test squad over the last few years because Kusal Mendis went to No. 7, and Kusal has played well there in the last few years, so Dickwella didn't get a chance to come back. But when you play at Galle, the most important thing is that the player with the best glove-work plays," captain Dhananjaya de Silva said on Friday. Dickwella's return is part of a broader batting reshuffle. Nishan Fernando and uncapped Pasindu Sooriyabandara are among those given an opportunity. Fernando scored two half-centuries in the recent warm-up against India, while Sooriyabandara has earned his chance after strong domestic performances.

Chandimal impact

Mendis and Nissanka's absence also puts the onus on Dinesh Chandimal. The right-hander's 162 not out in the second innings of the 2015 Galle Test was instrumental in rescuing Sri Lanka from 95/5 and setting India a target of 176 runs for victory, which proved enough in the end.

Keshara Nuwantha has earned his maiden Test call-up



Niroshan Dickwella returned to the Test side after 2023. AP

after impressing in domestic cricket and against India A, where he took five wickets in the second unofficial Test at Galle. He also featured against India in the recent warm-up. The off-spinner joins Prabath Jayasuriya and Ramesh Mendis to give Sri Lanka three specialist spin options for the series opener.

With India likely to field several left-handers, Sri Lanka's combination could become a key tactical subplot. India have also struggled against spin in recent Tests, making Sri Lanka's spin-heavy attack particularly relevant in Galle, where conditions are expected to increasingly favour slow bowlers.

Sri Lanka have also recalled Dilshan Madushanka, whose left-arm pace adds variety. He has played only one Test, in 2023, and returns alongside Asitha Fernando, Lahiru Kumara, Vishwa Fernando and Milan Rathnayake.

For Sri Lanka, selection debates ultimately lead back to the WTC table. They need to maximise the points available from their home Tests, and beating India would provide both a significant boost to their campaign and a long-awaited result in the rivalry. With two established batsmen unavailable, Dickwella's return and two uncapped players pushing for places, Sri Lanka must make home advantage count. The challenge is turning an unsettled squad into a side capable of making the most of familiar conditions in this series.

• 3 YEARS AND COUNTING?

BCCI officials to meet Agarkar about his extension

Devendra Pandey
Mumbai, August 14

THE BOARD of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) office bearers will meet selection committee chairman Ajit Agarkar after India's two-Test series against Sri Lanka to discuss a one-year extension.

Agarkar, a former India all-rounder, will complete three years as chairman in September, but is eligible for a one-year extension as per the rules. The meeting comes in light of differences of opinion between the selectors and the BCCI about the future of former India captain Rohit Sharma.

Though the selectors had informed Sharma that they were looking to replace him in the squad at the end of the England series in July, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia gave a differing view when he said Sharma

"will continue to represent the country as long as he is in the scheme of things".

The BCCI, it is learnt, wants the selectors to assess Sharma's future series by series ahead of the 50-over World Cup in 2027. Selectors are unhappy with Saikia's comments given that it came after they told Sharma that he would not be selected post the white-ball series in England. The Indian Express had reported that Sharma wanted to continue playing ODIs for India but the selectors, in consultation with the team management, wanted to give others like Yashasvi Jaiswal an opportunity at the top of the order after the England series.

Having scored 11 and 26 in the first two ODIs in Birmingham and Cardiff respectively, Sharma made 138 in the third match at Lord's on July 19. It is learnt that Sharma, who plays



Agarkar will complete three years as chief selector in September. AP

only ODIs, spoke to a few BCCI officials on the sidelines of the England series, and the opener wasn't happy with the decision of the selectors to look beyond him.

Sources told this paper that post Sharma's meeting with a top BCCI official and his

hundred at Lord's, Sharma could be included in the squad for the home series against the West Indies.

"I want to firmly assert that there has been no such discussion that Rohit will be playing his last match at Lord's on Sunday. Rohit is a regular

member of the Indian ODI team and he will continue to represent the country as long as he is in the scheme of things. In other words, Lord's ODI won't be his last match," Saikia had told PTI.

The Agarkar-headed selection committee removed Sharma as ODI captain last year, replacing him with Shubman Gill. The BCCI was keen on Agarkar continuing till the 2027 World Cup. However, a decision will be made after meeting Agarkar.

Sharma captained India to the 2023 World Cup final, where the team's all-out attacking approach from the top of the order redefined how India batted in the format.

The following year, the aggressive strategy remained in place as India won the 2024 T20 World Cup title under his leadership.

Skipper Gill optimistic about pacers' performance

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 14

INDIA WILL resume their bid to qualify for next year's World Test Championship final when they begin a two-Test series against Sri Lanka in Galle on Saturday. The Shubman Gill-led side will enter the series opener after a warm-up game last week, with a decision still to be made on who partners Mohammed Siraj as the second pacer.

The 26-year-old praised Gurnoor Brar for his ability to extract something from the old ball, while admitting that he has rarely seen Prasidh Krishna bowl better. "They both are very skilled bowlers, and they bowled really well in the practice match. We have seen how good Gurnoor is with the old ball when nothing is happen-



Pacer Gurnoor Brar. PTI

ing," Gill said in the pre-match press conference on Friday.

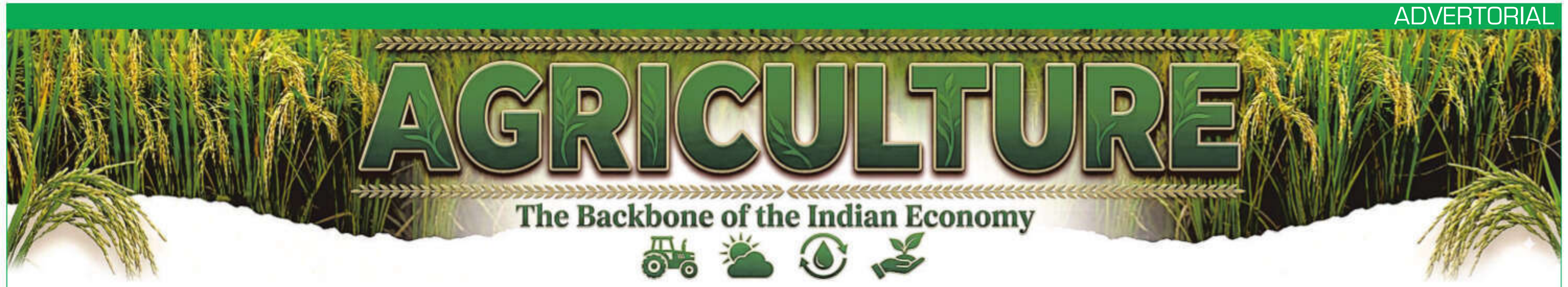
"You need that extra pace, extra bounce. He's obviously very tall as well. But I think Prasidh recently has been bowling the best that I have ever seen him bowl. In the red ball and also in white ball. So it would be a very tough decision for us to be able to just pick one."

"Bumrah is not here. But I

think it is a really good opportunity for some of the other bowlers to really step up and leave a mark on the series," he added. Gill also spoke about the possibility of the pitch offering little assistance to the bowlers in the early stages of the Test and the need to find different ways of taking wickets.

"The Test itself is a little bit slow. So, you have to keep trying different things to be able to take wickets, especially in the subcontinent. You have to create opportunities, especially on Day 1 and Day 2."

"If there is not much happening from the wicket, how can you create pressure? How can you not let the game slip away too much from you? So yes, having those kinds of creative fields helps our bowlers," Gill said.



India’s agricultural journey finds a new engine of growth



AS INDIA marks another year of Independence, its journey from food scarcity to greater self-reliance acts as a powerful reminder of how closely the nation’s progress has been linked to its farms. At the time of Independence, the main challenge was ensuring food for the rapidly growing population. The concern was to make agriculture central for both food security and economic reconstruction.

The transformation that followed, particularly the Green Revolution, helped India move from dependence on food imports towards greater domestic production and self-sufficiency. Years later, the role of agriculture has expanded beyond foodgrain production. It now spans horticulture, dairy, fisheries, food processing, exports and technology-driven farming, making it a vital engine of rural livelihoods and economic activity.

As India moves into its next phase of growth, agriculture continues to be one of the country’s strongest economic and social pillars, evolving with the times while remaining rooted in the foundations of national development.

Agriculture as the economic backbone of the nation

For a nation like India, agricultural importance extends far beyond the farm gate. As per the Economic Survey 2025-26, agriculture and allied activities account for nearly one-fifth of India’s national income at current prices and 46.1 per cent of the country’s workforce. Such performance influences food security, rural incomes and consumption, while a stronger



farm economy can boost demand for goods and services across rural India.

Besides, the sector is quite closely linked to manufacturing and services through fertilisers, farm machinery, food processing, storage, logistics, retail and exports. As horticulture, livestock and fisheries gain importance, these linkages are further widening. Agriculture, therefore, is not an isolated economic activity; greater farm prosperity can create a multiplier effect across rural businesses, employment and the wider economy.

The journey from green revolution to farm economy

The Green Revolution marked a defining chapter in India’s agricultural journey, transforming foodgrain production and helping the country strengthen its food security. But the story of Indian agriculture has continued to evolve. Over the decades, farming has expanded beyond traditional cereals, with horticulture, dairy, fisheries, livestock and poultry emerging as important contributors to

rural incomes. This shift reflects changing consumption patterns, as growing demand for fruits, vegetables, milk, protein-rich foods and processed products creates new opportunities across the agricultural value chain.

Diversification is also helping broaden the income base for farmers. By combining crop cultivation with allied activities, farmers can reduce their dependence on a single source of earnings while responding to changing market demand. As India’s food economy becomes more varied and value-driven, this transition from a predominantly grain-focused system to a diversified agricultural ecosystem can play an important role in creating more resilient livelihoods and strengthening rural prosperity.

Sustainability as a pillar of farm prosperity

For Indian agriculture, sustainability is increasingly becoming an economic necessity. From changing weather patterns, water stress and extreme weather events, every event affects the yield of crops, farm in-



comes and food security, making climate resilience an essential part of the sector’s future. Greater adoption of climate-resilient crops and farming practices, along with efficient irrigation, better soil health management and crop diversification, can help farmers manage these risks while conserving vital natural resources.

Such transformation brings in economic gains. Renewable energy for farm operations, efficient equipment and improved water-use practices can help reduce input costs and environmental pressure over time. Apart from this, protecting soil, water and other natural resources - an efficient farm sector can help secure both the livelihoods of today’s farmers and the productivity needed to feed tomorrow’s India.

Agriculture and the Viksit Bharat ambition

A developed nation cannot be formed without a prosperous and resilient rural economy. The contribution of agriculture now extends beyond food security to em-

ployment, exports, food processing, manufacturing and rural consumption. As the country moves towards the vision of Viksit Bharat, strengthening the agricultural economy can help ensure that growth reaches all the communities across the country and creates wider opportunities beyond urban centres.

The focus is shifting from producing enough food to building a more productive, profitable and sustainable farm economy. Much importance is given to integration of technology, infrastructure, modern markets and value-added processing that can improve competitiveness while opening new avenues for farmers. In this process of transition, food security, farmer prosperity, value creation and sustainability are emerging as interconnected priorities for India’s next phase of development.

A new chapter for the farm economy

The agricultural journey in India since Independence mirrors the country’s larger

From the Green Revolution to the rise of digital and climate-resilient farming, Indian agriculture has continually adapted to the country’s changing needs. Its next transformation will focus on productivity, profitability and sustainability, with farmers at the centre of the journey.

story of adaptation, resilience and self-reliance. The concern is no longer about producing more but about creating an agricultural ecosystem where farmers can earn more. Technology, modern infrastructure diversification and sustainable practices can provide the foundations for this next phase.

The spirit of self-reliance that once drove India’s transformation from food scarcity to food security can now take on a broader meaning. As the country looks towards its next phase of development, the ambition must be to build a farm economy that is productive, resilient, competitive and prosperous while strengthening not just agriculture, but the economic foundations of a confident and growing India.



INDIA’S PROGRESS BEGINS IN ITS FIELDS.

Every farmer’s effort adds to India’s progress. This Independence Day, we celebrate the hands that nurture our nation and help build a stronger tomorrow.

Together, let’s grow a self-reliant India.

HAPPY
Independence Day



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Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 14

BY THE time India's players assemble in a semicircle at the top of the 'D' on a June morning in Bengaluru, their training jerseys are already drenched in sweat.

Manpreet Singh crouches to receive the injection from vice-captain Hardik Singh. Rajinder Singh readies himself to flick, while Yashdeep Siwach, Abhishek Nain and Shilanand Lakra take up positions around the circle.

Everyone is present for India's penalty-corner drills. Almost. Well, almost. India's captain, and the team's great big-match weapon, Harmanpreet Singh is instead stretched out on the physio's table in the dug-out.

After a series of hamstring, lower back, ankle, wrist and finger injuries over the last two years, it is difficult not to wonder whether Harmanpreet and India — have another problem. He then joins the team's short, high-intensity five-a-side games, easing concerns over his fitness.

That will be crucial over the next fortnight, with India's hopes of ending the 51-year wait potentially hinging on the fitness and form of the player whose match-winning flicks ended the decades-long Olympic drought.

Hockey is never a one-man show; India would not have reached the Olympic podium without PR Sreejesh's brilliance, Hardik Singh's intelligence and Manpreet Singh's versatility.

Yet, given how heavily India relies on penalty corners for goals, it's difficult to overstate Harmanpreet's influence. At two of the last three major tournaments — the Tokyo and Paris Olympics — the drag-flicker scored a significant share of India's goals as the team claimed back-to-back bronze medals. The one exception was the 2023 World Cup, where Harmanpreet struggled, and India crashed out before the quarterfinals.

Which is why, over the next two weeks, Craig Fulton's side will need a fully fit Harmanpreet. For his aerial range, his ability to split defences with long, grounded passes and, of course, his flicks.

"I think in January-February, after the Hockey India League, he wasn't himself," Fulton told The Indian Express. "We took a good, hard look at



Harmanpreet remains India's big weapon

Drag-flicker has powered team's Olympic podium finishes, but tougher defences have made penalty-corners harder to convert.

getting him into the right nutrition pattern and training regime. And he's done a fantastic job. So he's getting better and better every week."

The need for Harmanpreet has become more pronounced as penalty corners have become harder to convert.

At the previous World Cup, almost 38 percent of all goals were from penalty corners. But conversion rates have been squeezed by increasingly sophisticated defences and the aggressive, well-drilled runners sent out to charge down flicks.

"In the last two-three years, because of protection and the ability for runners to run very, very consistent, aggressive lines against the drag-flickers,

the defenders always seem to get in the way somehow," Fulton explained. "So you have to have more ways to score off the penalty corner now than ever before."

India dedicate three hours a week practising penalty corners, a measure of how much they value the set piece. Fulton called India's penalty-corner defence "probably one of the best parts of our game at the moment". But it is the attacking end that has demanded more work.

India's Plan B

Much of 2026 has been spent building a back-up battery of penalty-corner specialists. That June morning in Ben-

galuru, as Harmanpreet watched from the sidelines, Jugraj Singh and Amit Rohidas got their chances, followed by younger options of Rajinder Singh and Sanjay.

They need those alternatives because even Harmanpreet, for all his pedigree, has found penalty corners harder to convert. At the Paris Olympics, his conversion rate was 1707 percent, despite finishing as the tournament's top scorer with 10 goals (7 out of 41 PCs; 3 from penalty strokes). German and Belgian flickers, by comparison, averaged 25 percent.

His goal tally, too, has come down over the last few years: 42 goals in 33 games in 2023, 35 in 39 in 2024 and 15 in 18 last year.

This year, he has scored twice in 10 matches.

That does not necessarily mean India has a fading drag-flicker. The game may simply have caught up with one of its most closely studied specialists.

"When you have a specialist, the other teams study him, make plans [for him]. That's the progression of international sport," Fulton said. "We obviously can use him in different positions; we can use him in different ways on the penalty corner."

Harmanpreet has been trying to stay ahead of that curve. At the start of 2026, he told The Indian Express he was working on different drag-flick variations, which he would 'reveal

E. EXPLAINED

Why every game will matter for India

For India, this could be the best chance to reach the World Cup semifinals for the first time since 1975. Apart from the continuity in the core group and the addition of a few exciting new faces, the format — and the draw — will also play a role. India are in Pool D alongside England, Pakistan and Wales and are expected to finish in the top two and progress to the second round, given their superior records against Pakistan (in the last decade) and Wales. However, it'll be crucial to gain as many points as possible, as they will be counted in the next stage.

There is no quarterfinal at this World Cup. Instead, the FIH has introduced a second pool stage. The top two teams from Pool D will be paired with the winners and runners-up of Pool A, which comprises the Netherlands, Argentina, New Zealand and Japan. Together, they will form a new Pool E.

•Harman's decreasing goal tally

YEAR	MATCHES	GOALS
2023	33	42
2024	39	45
2025	18	15
2026*	10	2

*UP TO JUNE; SOURCE: FIH

at the right time'. He was also focusing on short sprints to improve mobility and strengthening his lower back, shoulders and arms — key areas for generating power in his flick.

India will hope all that effort comes together at the Wagener Stadium. Because the alternatives may give them more ways to score. But Harmanpreet remains the one India cannot easily replace. When he scores, India's win percentage rises to almost 66 percent.

The World Cup starts Saturday. India will need their captain to give them more reasons to believe in that number.

India vs Wales, 4.30pm, Live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar

Esports World Cup: Indian challenge ends in quarters as Arjun, Nihal crash out



Arjun Erigaisi lost to Hikaru Nakamura in the quarter-finals. EWC

Mayank Chaudhary
Paris, August 14

THERE WAS a glimmer of hope for Indian fans when an extended field and dedicated zonal qualifiers were announced for chess at the Esports World Cup (EWC) 2026. In Riyadh last year, Arjun Erigaisi had reached the semifinals before falling to Alireza Firouzja and then losing to Hikaru Nakamura in the third-place playoff. Nihal Sarin, the other Indian in contention, met Magnus Carlsen in the quarterfinals, ending a campaign that had otherwise looked promising.

A lot has changed in a year, but the script for the Indians remained largely the same in Paris. Of the four Indians who qualified for EWC 2026, Arjun and Nihal were once again the two who made it to the top eight. But fate dealt them the same hand, as both were knocked out in the quarterfinals by giants of the game. Just like in Riyadh, Nihal's campaign ended at the hands of Carlsen, while Arjun crashed out before facing Nakamura as his final opponent.

Nihal was handpicked as his quarterfinal opponent by defending champion and face of the event, Magnus Carlsen, and it was clear that the Indian had to punch well above his weight to match the Norwegian, who had been battling illness since the tournament began.

Carlsen had no real trouble navigating against Nihal, quickly getting down to business by winning the first two of

four games to take a commanding 2.0-0.0 lead. In the must-win third game, Nihal managed to put slight pressure on Carlsen, but the slippery Norwegian saved the game and sealed his place in the top four. The other quarterfinal between Arjun and Nakamura was far more closely contested. In the four-game set-up, nothing separated the two players, as both brought their best game to ensure no one gained a decisive edge. With the scoreline locked at 2.0-2.0 after all four games ended in draws, the tie moved to Armageddon.

Arjun made a bold yet risky call as he bid a lower time than Nakamura to secure the back pieces and play with draw odds. He had 6 minutes and 45 seconds against the American, who played with winning odds as White with 10 minutes on the clock. Nakamura got a better position from the opening, but Arjun equalised quickly in the middlegame. It was in the endgame that the Indian let his guard down, allowing Nakamura to make small dents and snatch a close win.

Arjun and Nihal's top-eight finishes see each player take home \$75,000 (~INR 71.5 lakh) in prize money. S8UL Esports' Pranesh M, who exited in the Lower Bracket a day earlier, secured \$55,000 (~INR 52.5 lakh), while his teammate Aravindh Chithambaram, eliminated in the Play-Ins, earned \$23,000 (~INR 21.9 lakh) from the total \$1.5 million (~INR 14.3 crore) prize pool.

(The writer is in Paris at the invitation of the Esports Foundation)

{ B W F WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS }

Satwik's first racquet, watching Taufik, bomb threat: Stories from 2009 Worlds

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, August 14

AT THE 2009 Badminton World Championships in Hyderabad, a father in the stands stretched his hand and caught a racquet that newly crowned men's doubles world champion Cai Yun had flung into the stands after winning the title.

Seventeen years later, the boy who grew up with that racquet is Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, one half of India's best ever badminton duo with Chirag Shetty, and the official who caught the racquet was his late father Kasi Viswanadham.

"I was recalling that moment some days back. It all started with the racquet my father caught. I had no idea whose racquet it was," Satwik told *The Indian Express*. "However, now I realise how big it was. It's been a long journey and playing in India at the World Championships is kind of surreal as my journey started with a racquet from Worlds."

His elder brother Ramcharan Rankireddy, who served as a volunteer during the event, recalled the sequence of events. "My father was in the stands and he had a habit of collecting racquets. So when the Chinese shuttler threw it after winning the title, my father caught it and had to hide it from others behind his t-shirt like a sword," he told this paper.

After Satwik's father caught the racquet, the current world number five won multiple state and district medals with the racquet. "That was his (Satwik's) first racquet. He won many tournaments with it," Ramcharan said.

While everybody suggested Kasi keep it as a memory, the financial struggles of the family meant that the keepsake came



HS Prannoy (R) and Sumeeth Reddy (second from right) at the 2009 World Championships. BAI

into use. "We were not financially stable at that time, so instead of keeping it we decided to use it. I remember stringing it multiple times for Satwik," said Ram.

Apart from being a catalyst in Satwik's journey to the elite level, the 2009 edition also served as an inspiration for young Indian shuttlers like HS Prannoy and B Sumeeth Reddy.

A photo posted two months back by the Badminton Association of India shows Prannoy and Sumeeth peeking from the crowd as two young boys.

Fascinated by stars

One of top doubles players in India during his playing career, Sumeeth, was also watching the men's doubles final and that is where the score in the final game fascinated him.

Cai Yun and Fu Haifeng won their second world title defeating Jung Jaesung and Lee Yongdae of Korea. The final was a thrilling contest with the deciding game ending with a score of

28-26 sparking wild celebrations from the Chinese duo. "The final game of the men's doubles was the most memorable for me. It was a brilliant match. And I remember cheering constantly along with HS," said Sumeeth.

Prannoy, who shifted to Hyderabad in 2008, was excited to watch the legends up close he had only seen on VCRs sent by his uncle from Singapore.

"It was extraordinary for somebody like me. I had shifted to Hyderabad the previous year and watching all these legends like Lin Dan, Sony and of course Taufik Hidayat was an unreal experience," Prannoy told *The Indian Express*.

Prannoy, who would later go on to win a bronze medal at the 2023 edition, mentioned how the viewing experience changed him. "I watched these guys way too closely for the first time in my career at that point. And that made a huge difference to be honest. I think that memory kind of gave the belief to work harder going forward. The next few years were

something which I think I learned a lot from that entire week," said Prannoy.

Similarly, Sumeeth started executing his learnings immediately. "We were doing our sessions and watching the World Championships also. We would replicate the strokes, movements and situations during our sessions," he said.

The experience of the 2009 Worlds played a role in shaping India's first batch of Badminton superstars.

Bomb scare

However, everything was not rosy at the 2009 edition and English badminton team featuring Olympic silver medallist Nathan Robertson, pulled out of the tournament with the shadow of the dreaded Lashkar-e-Toiba looming over the tournament. As officials from Indian intelligence agencies visited the Gachibowli Stadium, several teams examined the security protocols.

The 2008 Mumbai attacks and attack on the Sri Lankan test



"I was recalling that moment some days back. It all started with the racquet my father caught. I had no idea whose racquet it was"

SATWIKSAIRAJ RANKIREDDY ON RACQUET FROM 2009

team in Pakistan made things more speculative once the news came out.

While other teams like China, Malaysia, and Denmark were satisfied with the protocols, the English team along with the Austrian pair of Peter Zauner and Jurgen Koch pulled out.

Ramcharan, who served as a volunteer during the championships, remembers the sequence. "I was one of the team bus managers. I think during the early days, I was designated for the English team bus and after a few days of practice, they stopped coming," recalled Ram.

"I wondered what happened to them. There was no social media back then for quick updates. Later, we came to know that they had left due to the terror attack scare."

India's badminton prowess is at a different from what it was back 2009 as the world's best descend in New Delhi for another edition from August 17, one would hope that next gen Prannoy, Sumeeth and Satwik are present in the stands.

Sindhu is the stuff Chinese nightmares are made of

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 14

BOTH TOP Chinese Chen Yufei and Wang Zhi Yi have been on record, admitting to the intense pressure PV Sindhu's attack has put them under in the last few months. The sentiment is old.

China hasn't won a women's singles World Championships title for the last 10 editions, since Wang Yihan in 2011. Another parallel timeline is eye-popping: China hasn't won the title since PV Sindhu showed up and started medalling in 2013, almost always at their expense.

Her Chinese scalps—2 in 2013 (Yihan and Shixian Wang), 1 in 2014 (Shixian), 1 in 2015 (Xuerui Li), 2 in 2017 (Sun Yu & Shixian), 1 in 2019 (Chen Yufei), 1 in 2025 (Wang Zhiyi). That's 8 Chinese taken out over 9 editions—7 of whom were Top 7 names, and could've gone on to win the title. Many ended up being helpful assists for Carolina Marin or Nozomi Okuhara, while Sindhu won gold herself in 2019. But even in her struggling phase last year, she conjured an eviction of Wang Zhi Yi, on the upswing. So, the Chinese must be quite fed up of running into the Indian, all the more now that Sindhu's game is stinging once more.

Wang Zhi Yi might come well prepared for her quarters should both make it that far in Delhi. But the Sindhu-sword hangs once more on Chinese progress.

But how did a 17-year-old lanky Indian in 2013, manage to reduce the Chinese challenge by half, taking out two of their finest?

The big smash

It has always been the big smash. A weapon so exclus-



China hasn't won a title since PV Sindhu showed up and started medalling in 2013, almost always at their expense. BAI

ively lethal that Sindhu's then coach Pullela Gopichand, consciously decided to not clutter her brain with other weapons. "Both Saina and Sindhu had two of the biggest smashes in singles. They were developed not to work around with too many skills. Instead of 5 strokes, we focused on one smash, maybe one sharp drop as opposed to a strike," he said. "The Chinese hate the big smash," Gopichand explains, and it's because they tend to be rhythm players. Any kind of start-stop footwork and a big smash hit from random places on the court, would put them off their game.

So Sindhu would follow a Plan A devised to crack their deception. Coaches and players would go into a hyper huddle, and bring out a "video-analysed response." But if that got countered with Plan B, they almost always struggled. But the beauty of the beastly smash was that nobody could quite counter it.

When top Indians played the Chinese, they uncannily had the weapons to make them uncomfortable. "2012 December, Sindhu defeated Li

Xuerui, the Olympic champion. That set the tone," he said.

Perhaps the only match that kept Coach Gopichand awake and wondering was Kidambi Srikanth vs Lin Dan in quarters at the Rio Olympics. "It was a possibility," he says wistfully of an opponent he led 2-1, "but Lin Dan transformed himself. Evolved."

Other Chinese tend to be beatable always, when put under pressure. It's why he backs Sindhu for an encore. "Sindhu's playing really well right now. The Chinese will come prepared because they've had time. We just need to plan," he insists of what must be a 10-day opponent-specific training after the draw was released.

Were a SWAT analysis to be done, Sindhu has the big smash in the big stadium, whereas Wang Zhi Yi doesn't. The Chinese can run down everything, is a courageous retriever and doesn't relent. But her game is fitness-based.

The Chinese are determined to break their long title drought, now in its 15th year. They see An Se-young as the obstacle.

But taking on the Korean means the Chinese, especially Wang Zhi Yi who could play her in the semis, will need to ration their intensity, and pace their week. Saving energy, playing slow, finding their rhythm: all things that can eventually dislodge the World No 1. But not necessarily factor in the out-of-syllabus Sindhu, the rhythm-shatterer. It's how the Indian who won a Japan Super 750 last month, has beaten the Chinese before -- stomping with a no-holds-barred smash.

They know it's coming. They've known it won't stop. Sindhu playing at a home World's - stuff nightmares are made of.



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Jamshedpur FC sold for Rs 100 to Churchill Brothers



Jamshedpur FC's ISL exit had shaken Indian football. FILE
Express News Service
Delhi, August 14

TATA STEEL has sold Jamshedpur FC to Churchill Brothers Football Club for a token amount of Rs 100, with the latter taking charge of the former Indian Super League (ISL) Shield winners' first team and coaching staff. Tata Steel said in a statement the committee of directors it had constituted to carry out the sale of the club, approved "the transfer of entire 100% equity stake comprising of 4,08,00,000 equity shares of face value Rs 10" to Churchill Brothers.

Tata Steel said that all of its stakes in the Jamshedpur Football and Sporting Private Limited (JFSP), the subsidiary it had formed to operate the club, were transferred to Churchill Brothers. This includes the contracts of the 12 players who played for Jamshedpur FC and the two coaches in its staff, in addition to the club's ISL sporting licence.

It thus ends Jamshedpur FC's chapter in ISL. The club was founded in June 2017 and played its first season in the ISL that year. They went on to finish top of the league in the 2021-22 season and won the League Shield. It also confirms Churchill Brothers' entry into the ISL and thus a possible end to a roller coaster ride since the 38-year-old Goan club finished top of the table in the 2024-25 season of the I-League and initially being declared champions. After that was reversed and awarded to Inter Kashi, Churchill refused to play in 2025-26 and were relegated to the third division.

Tanzid's maiden Test ton puts Bangladesh on top

Associated Press
Darwin, August 14

TANZID HASAN posted his maiden century in just his second cricket Test to help guide Bangladesh to 351-6 at stumps Friday and into commanding position over top-ranked Australia after two days of the Top End series opener.

Tanzid raised his hundred with a single off Nathan Lyon from 188 deliveries but after a patient and resilient innings, he added just one more run before lofting a ball from the veteran Australian spinner to Mitchell Starc at long-off soon after.

He survived two dropped chances and shared two big, important partnerships to set No. 9-ranked Bangladesh on course for a big first-inning lead. Tanzid combined with Mominul Haque (49) in a 102-run second-wicket stand and 93 with skipper Najmul Hossain Shanto for the third.

Shanto went on to score 84 from 126 deliveries before he was one of the three wickets to fall in a four-over period soon after the Australians took the second new ball.

Bangladesh resumed Friday at 96-1, 102 behind on the first innings after dismissing Australia for 198, and finished Day 2 with a 153-run lead and four wickets in hand.



Tanzid Hasan hit 101 runs off 197 balls on Day 2 of the first Test. AP

Tanzid said he curbed his attacking instinct and "I did what the team required." "I can't describe it in words but it is very special for me," he said of his 101. "I was trying to play normal cricket, and keep calm."

In their first test on Australian soil since 2003, the Bangladesh players were just as disciplined with the bat as they were with the ball on the opening day.

Mehidy Hassan Miraz (32) and Hasan Mahmud (13) shared a 43-run unbroken partnership - surviving a dropped catch on the last ball of the day - for the seventh wicket to get Bangladesh to stumps in the kind of position that few expected ahead of the series.

The reunion of Australia's so-called Big Four - pacemen Pat Cummins, Josh Hazlewood and Starc and veteran off-spinner Lyon has so far been blunted by the visiting batters in the warm, tropical conditions of far north Australia.

"They batted really well," Australia opening batter Jake Weatherald said in a post-stumps TV interview. "We obviously missed a few chances but credit to them."

BRIEF SCORES: Bangladesh 351/6 in 110 overs (Tanzid Hasan 101; Najmul Hossain Shanto 84; Mitchell Starc 2/68, Josh Hazlewood 2/68) vs **Australia** 198 all out.

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Bezos-backed consortium buys minority stake in Liverpool

London: A consortium including Amazon founder Jeff Bezos has reached a definitive agreement to buy a minority stake in Liverpool, the Premier League club's owners Fenway Sports Group said on Friday.

A source familiar with the matter said the stake is about one-third. British media re-

ports said the deal was worth more than £1.5 billion, which values the club at over £5 billion (\$7 billion).

FSG, which bought Liverpool in 2010 for £300 million, will maintain the majority share and operational control of the club. The consortium, named 1892 Holdings, is led by

former Queens Park Rangers chairman Amit Bhatia and also includes the Mittal Family Trusts, EE Capital and the K5 Sports fund, where Bezos is the lead investor.

"As we considered this opportunity, it became clear that Amit and the consortium shared our long-term philos-

ophy and appreciation for what makes Liverpool special," FSG president Mike Gordon said in a statement. "Their experience and perspective will complement the strong foundation already in place, and we look forward to working together." Bhatia will become the club's new vice chairman. REUTERS

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Teaming Up

WITH THE curtains drawn on the Monsoon Session of Parliament, the BJP is learnt to have shifted focus on its most pressing organisational priority — national president Nitin Nabin's new team. Sources said the team comprising both experienced and young hands has been finalised and is likely to be announced early next week.

Random Check

WEEKS AFTER taking charge, Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar undertook a random late night tour of all 15 police districts earlier this week as part of the Independence Day security review. Generally, the route map of the Commissioner's visits is shared in advance and the DCPs concerned plan accordingly. This time, too, details of Kumar's route were shared, but it didn't go as planned and took several police officers by surprise. The move has sent a clear message inside the force — no more scripted visits; just random checks to keep everyone on their toes.

Temple entry row: Karnataka MLA's daughter booked for assaulting cop

Express News Service
Bengaluru, August 14

KARNATAKA MLA B Suresh Gowda's daughter, Aishwarya, has been booked for allegedly assaulting, abusing and threatening a woman police sub-inspector during a dispute over entering a temple in Mandya during Bhima Amavasya celebrations. The alleged incident took place on August 12 at Maramma temple in Ukkada. Aishwarya, married to Assistant Commissioner of Police K C Goutham, was booked after a complaint by Savitha B Patil, posted at the Mandya women's police station. Patil was deployed at the temple for special security duty from 2pm-10pm, and Aishwarya allegedly sought permission to enter the sanctum sanctorum directly instead of waiting in a queue. Patil said she asked Aishwarya to wait to avoid inconvenience to devotees in the queue. Aishwarya then allegedly abused Patil and struck her on the head. Aishwarya also threatened her by referring to her status and obstructed her from performing her duties.

Aadhaar to passport: 14 of 40 Census queries are additions or modifications to 2011 list

Deeptiman Tiwary & Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, August 14

THE POPULATION enumeration phase of the Census, scheduled to begin next month, will have 14 new or modified questions compared with the 2011 Census.

Incidentally, several of these questions were also part of the National Population Register (NPR) schedule notified in 2020. Some of them, including those seeking details of a person's father and mother and their places of birth, had sparked controversy at the time amid fears that the NPR was being used to prepare the ground for a nationwide National Register of Citizens (NRC) exercise.

The Registrar General of India (RGI) on Friday notified the schedule (questionnaire) for population enumeration, comprising 40 questions. These range from personal and parental details to nationality, education, bank accounts and the place where a person received a Covid-19 vaccine. The question on Scheduled Caste (SC)/Scheduled Tribe (ST) has also been modified to include "caste".

The 14 new or modified questions, compared with the 2011 Census, are — spouse

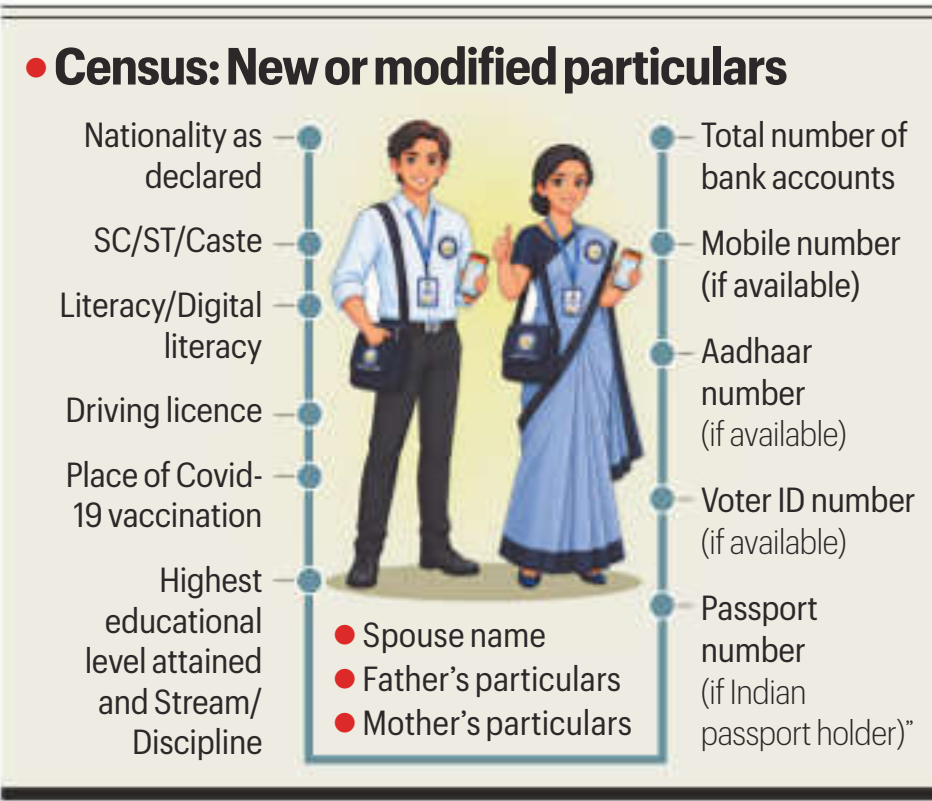
name, nationality as declared, father's particulars, mother's particulars, SC/ST/Caste, literacy/digital literacy, highest educational level attained and stream/discipline, place of Covid-19 vaccination, total number of bank accounts, mobile number (if available), Aadhaar number (if available), voter ID number (if available), passport number (if Indian passport holder), and availability of driving licence.

Of these, particulars on nationality, father's particulars, mother's particulars, mobile number, Aadhaar number, voter ID, passport number, and driving licence were also included in the NPR schedule notified in 2020.

The NPR is the register of "usual residents" of the country. It is governed by the Citizenship (Registration of Citizens and Issue of National Identity Cards) Rules, 2003, framed under the Citizenship Act, 1955. The rules provide for preparation of a Population Register and envisage its verification for preparation of the National Register of Indian Citizens.

The 2020 NPR schedule had sought, among other things, the date and place of birth of a person's father and mother, including the district and state

Several questions were also part of the National Population Register schedule notified in 2020



and, in case they were born outside India, the country of birth. These questions had created considerable controversy in 2019-20, particularly after the passage of the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA).

Opposition parties and civil society groups had argued that the NPR was a precursor to a nationwide NRC and that the collection of parental birth details

could subsequently be used to determine citizenship. Several opposition-ruled states passed resolutions opposing the NPR exercise. The controversy was amplified by statements from Union Home Minister Amit Shah, who had repeatedly spoken of a nationwide NRC and sought to link the NRC with the CAA through his reference to the "chronology". At the peak

SC cancels defamation case against Rahul over Savarkar remarks

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 14

THE SUPREME Court on Friday cancelled a criminal defamation case and summons issued by a Lucknow magistrate against Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over his remarks on Hindutva ideologue V D Savarkar, noting that the Uttar Pradesh government had not granted the sanction required to prosecute him.

"In the affidavit filed by respondent state of Uttar Pradesh, there is no disclosure of sanction having been granted to prosecute the accused/appellant. In such view of the matter, the complaint and order passed by the magistrate stand quashed," a bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu ordered.

The Lucknow court had summoned Gandhi after a private complaint by advocate Nripendra Pandey, who alleged that in 2022, in Maharashtra, the Congress leader had made derogatory remarks against Savarkar. Though Gandhi challenged this before the Allahabad HC, the HC rejected his plea on April 4, 2024, following which he moved the Supreme Court.

Hearing his appeal on April 25, the court has taken stern exception to his comments. A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Manmohan told Gandhi, "You don't treat freedom fighters like this..." and cautioned that it would initiate suo



Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi

motu proceedings against him if he repeated such statements.

"Does your client know Mahatma Gandhi also used 'your faithful servant' while addressing the Viceroy? Does your client know that his grandmother, when she was the PM, also sent a letter praising the gentleman (Savarkar). You don't treat freedom fighters like this when you know the history. Why do you comment like this? Justice Datta had told senior advocate A M Singhvi, who appeared for Gandhi.

The judge also asked him not to make such statements in future.

"Let him not make irresponsible statements about the freedom fighters. Is this the way you treat freedom fighters?" The court had stayed the proceedings, saying he had a "good case on law" on the point of sanction.

Taking it up Friday, Justice Datta asked the counsel for the state, "Where is the sanction?... you have to follow the law."

Nabin invokes Partition horrors to launch fresh attack on Nehru-Gandhi family

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 14

BLAMING THE Nehru-Gandhi family for the Partition as a maneuver for "political power", BJP president Nitin Nabin on Friday hailed fresh attacks on the Congress and described the observance of 'Partition Horrors Remembrance Day' (August 14) by Prime Minister Narendra Modi as an effort to learn from history and also as an avenue to make the new generation aware of the 1947 tragedy.

Addressing a remembrance event in Gurugram, where he paid tributes to the martyrs and the displaced families affected by the Partition, Nabin attacked Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi for his behaviour, adding that it was not acceptable to the nation's youth. "Today is a day to remember the sacrifices of the martyrs and memories of the families who endured the pain of displacement... Those who had dreamed of political power for themselves attained power, but millions of Indians who had dreamed of freedom were forced to witness a bloody chapter," Nabin said.

Referring to the Nehru-Gandhi family, the BJP president asserted that those who divided the country "solely for political power have still not changed their mindset" and "are working to divide the society today". "The Congress never publicly apologised to the families who suffered the pain of Partition... During the tragedy of 1947, over 1.5



Union Minister Manohar Lal Khattar, BJP national president Nitin Nabin and others during a 'Partition Horrors Remembrance Day' programme in Gurugram on Friday. PTI

crore families suffered displacement, over 30 lakh people lost their lives, and countless women sacrificed their lives to protect their honour," Nabin said.

"Some people did not want these figures to find a place in the pages of history... It is a matter of happiness that, through Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji's decision to observe Vibhajan Vibhishika Smriti Diwas, the present generation has received an opportunity to learn about these truths." Further, seeking to underscore the contributions of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and leaders such as Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Nabin attacked former PM Jawaharlal Nehru for keeping "Kashmir separate from the rest of the country".

"It is fortunate that a personality like Sardar Patel worked to

of the anti-CAA protests, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in December 2019 that the government had not taken any decision to conduct the NRC. The Home Ministry and Shah subsequently reiterated that position on several occasions.

The 2020 NPR exercise was ultimately postponed because of Covid-19 and was not notified afresh when Census operations were revived this year.

The new Census questionnaire thus brings back several of the questions that had been at the centre of that earlier controversy, even though there is currently no notification for conducting the NPR or any decision announced by the government to undertake a nationwide NRC.

Under Rule 3(4) of the Citizenship Rules, the Centre may decide a date by which the Population Register is to be prepared by collecting information on all persons "usually residing" within the jurisdiction of a Local Registrar. Rule 3(5) provides that the Local Register of Indian Citizens will contain details of persons after verification from the Population Register. Rule 4 further provides for marking the particulars of individuals whose citizenship is considered doubtful during the verification process for further inquiry.

It is this statutory link between the NPR and the NRC that had made the 2019-20 exercise politically contentious.

The NPR data was first collected in 2010, along with the houselisting phase of the 2011 Census, and was subsequently updated through a door-to-door exercise in 2015. The RGI revived the NPR through a notification in August 2019, and the exercise was scheduled to be carried out along with the houselisting phase of the 2021 Census.

The NPR exercise, however, was postponed due to the Covid 19 pandemic. Although the Union Budget 2026-27 allocated Rs 6,000 crore under the head "Census, Survey and Statistics/ Registrar General of India" for Census 2027 and NPR, the government did not notify a fresh NPR exercise when Census operations were taken up this year. The houselisting phase was notified for April 1 to September 30, but the notification made no mention of the NPR.

A Home Ministry official had said the allocation was in line with provisions made in previous budgets since 2020 and was intended to ensure funds were available "if and as and when" the government decided to conduct the NPR.

On the recent students' protest at Jantar Mantar, Nabin clarified that if there is any person, government or institution that "understands today's young generation", it is BJP's and Modi's leadership. "The people in the Opposition never worked to channel the energy of the youth; rather, they have only used that energy for the sake of power. Today's young generation is writing its own future. It is moving forward not only to seek employment, but also to create employment," he added.

"If we have to build Viksit Bharat by 2047, we have to build a secure and prosperous India for the young generation... Given the kind of conduct displayed by Rahul Gandhi, we believe today's young generation can never give any place to such behaviour. The world is watching the kind of words the LoP uses to describe the head of the country." When India's diplomacy and foreign policy were giving us a distinct position in the world due to Modi's leadership, the LoP "mocks that leader and uses insulting words against him".

"India has been a symbol of respect. It has been a symbol of the traditions of the Gurus. India lives by those traditions in which elders and senior members are respected, where mothers and sisters are regarded with dignity and respect... You mock that as well... Today's Gen Z wants to live for India and wants to die for India. It is not going to follow anyone's national political agenda," he said.

Govt to launch Reform Utsav to capture citizen suggestions

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, August 14

THE UNION government plans to launch a three-month campaign — Reform Utsav — with the aim of capturing "citizen voice" and effecting reforms, *The Indian Express* has learned.

The two key objectives of the initiative, expected to be launched on October 2 (the birth anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi), are to institutionalise reforms through citizen participation and build a responsive reform pipeline, a source said.

The "end goal" of the campaign is that "citizen voice is captured as a suggestion, converted into an actionable reform and, finally, implemented or progressed on a committed roadmap", sources said.

The seed of the initiative came about amidst the students' protest over the NEET paper leak which ultimately led to the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

As per sources, the proposed Reform Utsav campaign will have three levels: Jan Manthan (discover), Vimarsh (deliberate), and Samadhan and Sankalp Siddhi (resolution).

The first level (discover) will commence on October 2 and continue for a month. During this period, citizens can give their suggestions through a designated portal. Several outreach activities, including public meetings and webinars, will also be organised.

Once suggestions are in, AI will be used to sort them. In addition, a multilingual call centre may also be established.

During the second level (deliberate), the identification of 'quick win' reforms and roadmap for structural reforms will be undertaken. Finally, in the third level, the coordination committee will review the progress on a bi-weekly basis, sources said.

Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan will head the coordination committee for the proposed initiative. He has been holding meetings with chief secretaries so that state-level bodies can be formed and nodal officers identified.

Amid row over DGP selection, Odisha gives charge to senior IPS officer

Sujit Bisoi
Bhubaneswar, August 14

AMID LEGAL stalemate over the selection of police chief in Odisha, the state government on Friday assigned senior IPS officer Vinaytosh Mishra to remain in the additional charge of DGP and head of the police force from August 16.

Odisha's incumbent DGP Y B Khurania retires on Sunday. A native of Bihar, Mishra is a 1993-batch IPS officer who's currently serving as the DG of CID and Crime Branch. He will head the state's police force until the appointment of a full-time DGP. Mishra will also superannuate in November.

Haunted by Partition, Punjab needs a new revolution — to sustainable future

Manraj Grewal Sharma
Chandigarh, August 14

NOT MANY people know that Shaheed Bhagat Singh's uncle Ajit Singh, one of the main architects of the farmers' agitation 'Pagdi Sambhal Jatta' against the British agricultural laws, died on the day India got Independence. He had been ailing for some time, living in Dalhousie with his wife. He was 66. Some of Ajit's relatives say he heard Jawaharlal Nehru's iconic "Tryst with Destiny" midnight speech before breathing his last at about 3.30 am on August 15, 1947. His last words, by many accounts, were "Jai Hind". For Punjab, August 15, 1947, marked freedom and devastation. The country became Independent, but Punjab was divided, forcing millions to leave homes, lands and lives built over generations. Since 2021, the central government has observed August 14 as Vibhajan Vibhishika Smriti Diwas or Partition Horrors Re-

membrance Day. A few families in Punjab are untouched by that pain and trauma, passed down from one generation to another. Yet the generation that came to India following their displacement after Partition did not have only the burden of loss. It carried a deep nostalgia for the "Baar", the canal-colony settlements of western Punjab that they had been forced to abandon.

Sitting in his Amritsar home, Professor Darbari Lal, former Deputy Speaker of the Punjab Assembly and education minister, while remembering his village in the Baar, once said, "The Chenab flowed right across it. Sohni must have been swept this way when she was separated from Mahiwal." For centuries, large parts of western Punjab had remained uncultivated due to lack of irrigation. In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, the British built an extensive canal network in the region. But water alone was not enough; farmers were needed. Many from what is

now Indian Punjab, including retired soldiers, moved to larger settlements there and were allotted land called *murabbas*, each measuring 25 acres.

New settlements were given administrative numbers: Chak 8, Chak 20, Chak 503 and many more. Often, they carried the names of the migrants' original villages, such as Chak 503 Narangwal. The land was arid and took years to turn fertile. But, when the Partition took place, those who had transformed such lands were forced to leave, often with little warning. They became refugees. Many of them lived in camps or with relatives across Indian Punjab.

My father, then a child, remembers a *maasi* who sheltered his family for months while his father, away in Bombay on business during the upheaval, searched for them. My grandmother spoke of their painfully slow caravan, guarded by village youths on horseback, and of an Army officer from their village



For Punjab, August 15, 1947, marked both freedom and devastation

who came to the rescue midway, ferrying women and children to Amritsar in a military vehicle so packed that they could barely breathe. Then there is a favourite anecdote of the family: a cow that was reunited with them after a neighbour found it in a refugee camp.

Some stories were darker. The much-loved uncle, a serving police officer, was killed by a mob inside his own station in

western Punjab. In uniform. It would have been easier for that generation to embrace victimhood. Instead, they rebuilt their lives. Many joined the armed forces, others started businesses, most returned to farming.

The spirit of resistance and rebuilding is central to Punjab's political memory and has been ingrained in its farmers. Even today, protests in the state draw on the legacy of earlier agrarian

struggles. This is why the 'Pagdi Sambhal Jatta' pitch echoed during the farmers' agitation during 2020-21 against the now-repealed central farm laws.

Ajit had led the original 'Pagdi Sambhal Jatta' movement in 1907 alongside Lala Lajpat Rai, opposing three British laws that threatened farmers' rights and hiked water charges or *abiana*. A gifted orator, he addressed 19 of the 33 meetings recorded by the British intelligence. In March 1907, Lala Banke Dayal's poem titled 'Pagdi Sambhal Jatta' was recited at a rally in Lyallpur, giving the movement its name and anthem. The British withdrew the farm laws, but Ajit and Lajpat were imprisoned in Mandalay, Burma. On their return, Bal Ganhadhar Tilak hailed Ajit as the "king of Punjab peasantry".

But hounded by the British, Ajit was forced into exile for nearly four decades abroad, where he engaged with Indian revolutionaries and nationalists, including Lala Har Dayal

and Subhas Chandra Bose. After the Second World War, he was imprisoned in Germany before Nehru secured his release in early 1947. The slogan 'Pagdi Sambhal Jatta', which continues to resonate in Punjab, also raises a question: What should that spirit of resistance confront today?

Independence Day offers a moment for reflection in this regard. The challenge today is not colonial rule. It is the depletion of a key resource that made Punjab's agrarian success possible: water. Experts warned of impending desertification in Punjab for years. Economists such as Professor SS Johl during the previous Captain Amarinder Singh-led Congress government's tenure, have outlined solutions. The current AAP government, too, has prepared plans on the issue. But their implementation remains negligible. Meanwhile, the acreage under the water-intensive paddy cultivation touched a record high this year.

State governments cutting across party lines have continued to provide free water for political reasons, even as the water table plummets. While farmer unions have been up in arms against free trade agreements, they seem to have overlooked this looming calamity.

Some individual farmers have adopted alternatives. But most remain caught in an unsustainable farming model. The way forward is obvious: reduce dependence on water-intensive paddy, ensure markets for diversified crops, invest in micro-irrigation and food processing, and align agricultural policy with ecology rather than electoral compulsions. The tradition of resistance set by Ajit Singh needs a new focus — not on an external enemy, but on a system quietly destroying Punjab's future. The next revolution Punjab needs is in its fields, not in the streets.

The author is Resident Editor (North), The Indian Express

SC drops FIRs against Samay Raina over remarks against persons with disabilities



Comedian Samay Raina

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 14

THE SUPREME Court on Friday quashed the FIRs registered against comedian Samay Raina and others over alleged insensitive remarks about persons with disabilities, and welcomed their efforts to course-correct and take steps to promote awareness about the life and dignity of the community.

“Once there are genuine efforts, positive results are bound to be there ... They are very bright youngsters... If they have now started working in a positive direction, there will be very good output,” Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, presiding over a three-judge bench, said.

The bench also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana went on to quash the FIRs against Raina and co-accused Vipul Goyal, Balraj Ghai, Sonali Thakkar, and Nishant Tanwar.

“Criminal proceedings against respondents 6-10 registered under FIRs ... are hereby quashed and all other related proceedings are set aside,” the bench ordered while directing that the main petition by NGO Cure SMA India Foundation be retained to consider the larger issue of the need for guidelines to prevent humiliation of persons with disabilities. The bench was hearing the Foundation’s plea accusing Raina and others of cracking insensitive jokes on persons with disabilities (PwDs) on the India’s Got Latent’ show.

On July 14, the bench had imposed a fine of Rs 3 lakh on each of them, noting that they had “taken the court for a ride” by not following its directions in the matter.

SC stays HC order stalling job offer to kin of Karur stampede victims

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, August 14

THE SUPREME Court on Friday stayed the Madras High Court order striking down Tamil Nadu’s decision to provide government jobs to families of 41 victims of last year’s Karur stampede, questioning why the state should be prevented from offering employment to those who have lost their sole breadwinner.

“A stampede took place.... Now if the government decided that the family members should be... compensate them with money, would you have objected?” Justice J B Pardiwala, presiding over a two-judge bench, told the counsel for the original petitioner who had filed the PIL before the HC.

“Who are you to question the policy of the government, saying no employment should be given?... shouldn’t the government give some employment to ... as per their educational [qualification]?” the judge said.

SEVEN OF THE NINE KIRTI CHAKRAS AWARDED POSTHUMOUSLY

9 Kirti Chakras, 19 Shaurya Chakras among 78 gallantry awards on I-Day

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, August 14

PRESIDENT DROUPADI Murmu on Friday approved 78 gallantry awards, including 13 awarded posthumously, for personnel from the Defence Forces and Central Armed Police Forces. The awards include nine Kirti Chakras, of which seven are posthumous; one Bar (conferred second time) to the Shaurya Chakra; and 19 Shaurya Chakras, including one posthumous.

The awards include five Bars to the Sena Medals (Gallantry); 36 Sena Medals (Gallantry), five of them posthumous; three Nau Sena Medals (Gallantry), and five Vayu Sena Medals (Gallantry).

The Kirti Chakra awardees are Lt Col Manoj Francis PF of 21 Para (Special Forces) and Major Jitendra Rathee of 2 Para (Special Forces). Seven other Kirti Chakras were conferred posthumously. The armed forces personnel given the prestigious awards posthumously included Havildar Gajendra Singh of 2 Para (Special Forces), Jagbir Singh (Head Constable), Jaswant Singh (Constable), Balvinder Singh (Constable), Tariq Hussain (Constable), Bashir Ahmad (Head Constable), and Sunil Kumar (Inspector).

Eleven Army personnel have got the Shaurya Chakra, while one each is from the Navy and the IAF. The Shaurya Chakra awardees are Major Paramveer from 36 Rashtriya Rifles; Major Tarun Vasudevan from 57 Rashtriya Rifles; Major Keshav Kumar from 12 Dogra Regiment; Major



Chatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus and Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation headquarters illuminated in Tricolour on the eve of Independence Day in Mumbai. AKASH PATIL

Gaurav Singh Brijwal from 21 Grenadiers; Major Vipeen Kumar from 11 Rashtriya Rifles; Naib Subedar Shankar Ram from 3 Assam Rifles; and Naib Subedar Dabbal Singh Bisht from 21 Para (Special Forces).

Other recipients of the award are Havildar Jagattar Singh from 4 Para (Special Forces); Lance Naik Narender Sindhu from 9 Rashtriya Rifles (posthumous); Lance Naik Kapil Dev from 11 Rashtriya Rifles; Sepoy Jaswinder Singh from 7 Sikh Light Infantry; Lieutenant Commander Shivam Kumar from the Indian Navy; Squadron Leader Sudhir Kumar, a pilot from the Indian Air Force.

The remaining Shaurya Chakra awardees are: Dheeraj Singh Katoch, Deputy Superintendent; Ajay Singh Chhib, Inspector; Sukhvir Singh, Deputy Superintendent; Niyaz Ahmad, Assistant Sub-Inspector; Anjani Kumar, Deputy Commandant;

and Deepak Sah, Constable.

The citation of Lt Col Manoj Francis PF states that he was the Assault Team Commander of a Parachute Regiment (Special Forces) during an operation in Manipur, and he established an intelligence network to dismantle an insurgent group. “After several months of sustained intelligence development about a high-profile violent insurgent group, he launched a operation to raid and dismantle the insurgents... with his superior combat skills,” it added.

Major Rathee’s citation said he was entrusted with a mission to neutralise terrorist groups in the Kishtnar region. “Exhibiting tactical brilliance under intense hostile fire, the officer maneuvered stealthily to an advantageous position, identified a hiding terrorist and with decisive action, lobbed incendiary grenades, eliminating a terrorist and setting fire to the hideout,

thereby trapping and injuring the other two terrorists. After cessation of fire, he closed in to take confirmatory shots, neutralising three foreign terrorists,” it said.

Havildar Gajendra Singh’s citation said he was serving as Intelligence Troop Havildar. “On 18 January 2026, leading a search team in dense jungles in Kishtnar, despite profuse bleeding, he re-engaged terrorists and critically injured a most wanted foreign terrorist. Havildar Gajendra Singh succumbed to his injuries on site...,” the citation said.

Major Aditya Pratap Singh’s citation said his team came under intense automatic and grenade fire from insurgents during patrolling along the Indo-Myanmar border on 5 July 2025. “Undeterred by his injuries and with utter disregard to personal safety, he eliminated a most wanted top operational commander of a high profile insurgent group,” it said.

The citation of Lieutenant Commander Shivam Kumar said he was serving as the NBCD Officer onboard INS Trikand. “On 18 October 2025, while deployed in the Gulf of Aden, the ship was directed to render assistance to MT Falcon, a Cameer-ran-flagged LPG tanker that had suffered a catastrophic explosion and major fire while transiting through the Houthi Attack Zone... Two Indian crew members were... presumed trapped onboard...,” the citation said. He voluntarily chose to lead the operation despite being fully aware of the dangers involved, it said.

WITH PTI INPUTS

• BRIEFLY



Students during a protest in Ranchi on Friday. PTI

JHARKHAND

Recruitment exam stir enters 21st day, students’ Tiranga Yatra today

THE AGITATION by students demanding reforms in Jharkhand’s recruitment examination process entered its 21st day on Friday, with officials meeting protesters at Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium amid plans for their ‘Tiranga Yatra’ on Independence Day. The officials held discussions with the students, and also sought information about the proposed route for Saturday’s procession. The talks, remained inconclusive. ‘JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch’ leader Ravindra Paswan said the students were ready for negotiations whenever the government extended an invitation. PTI

VDG killed after colleague opens fire in Jammu

A VILLAGE defence guard was killed and another injured after their fellow colleague allegedly opened fire on them on Friday during a scuffle in Udhampur district of Jammu and Kashmir. Identifying the deceased as Baldev Singh and the injured Ramesh Singh, officials said that the shootout took place in remote Pancheri area. The accused Surjeet Singh of Sasri Damnot village reportedly had an altercation followed by a scuffle with the victims before opening fire from his weapon. The exact cause of the altercation were yet to be established. PTI

Bihar: 4 die of asphyxiation inside well

FOUR PEOPLE, including a man and his son, died allegedly of asphyxiation after inhaling toxic gas while repairing a motor inside a well in Bihar’s Gaya Ji district on Friday, officials said. The incident occurred at Garh Karmauni village in Dobhi police station area of the district. The deceased have been identified as Chamari Manjhi, his son Dilchand Manjhi, Vikas Chaudhary and Vijay Chaudhary. CM Samrat Choudhary expressed grief over the incident, and directed officials concerned to provide ex gratia of Rs 4 lakh each to the kin of the deceased. PTI

EXPRESS special

Student quarters to live-ins: UP Governor does her homework before she shows up at varsities

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, August 14

WHEN SHE took over as the Chief Minister of Gujarat, she was filling the very big shoes of predecessor Narendra Modi. Now, at 84, she has entered the 7th year of governorship of Uttar Pradesh, making her the longest-serving occupant of one of the hottest seats in the country’s politics. And, Anandiben Patel, shows no signs of flagging.

In recent months, Patel, who is the Chancellor of state universities by virtue of being the UP Governor, has been in the news for dropping in at the institutes, with a critical eye on everything from mess and hostels, to what students eat and how they lead their lives.

Officials at some of the universities and institutions Patel has visited say her approach to these visits is pretty hands-on. Before she arrives, a team from her office visits to take down notes, including on facilities, the mess, sanitation, academic infrastructure and student welfare. More than one university struggles with the details.

At the end of her tour, Patel, who was a teacher before she joined politics, addresses students and faculty at the universities. In these speeches, she has cautioned women students against live-in relationships and pregnancies outside marriage, advised colleges against

non-vegetarian food, commented on the construction, quality and functioning of institutes and, most recently, wondered how things could be no better in a constituency with CM Yogi Adityanath as MLA.

In October 2025, at the convocation of Mahatma Gandhi Kashi Vidyapeeth in Varanasi, Patel regretted “the growing acceptance” of live-in relationships, and advised women students “mat kariye (stay away)”.

In June 2026, at the Ram Manohar Lohia Institute of Medical Sciences in Lucknow, Patel advised against serving non-veg food in the hostel mess. The institute subsequently said the menu was decided by a panel comprising students and they would consider her advice.

At an event at Dr A P J Abdul Kalam Technical University in Lucknow on July 7, Patel spoke about the “responsibilities” of women. “They should at least know how to cook in a family... Aap adhiyapak bano, chahe aap IAS officer bano, ek expert maa bano pehle. Woh zaroorat hai (Become a teacher, an IAS officer, etc, but before that, become an expert mother. That’s essential).”

At the same event, she frowned upon young couples eloping and having children when they have no means to run a family. “Aaj kal ladke-ladkiyan bhaagjaate hain... aur koi pregnant hokar pakda jaata hai... Na maayeka sweekar



The longest serving Governor of UP, Anandiben Patel, who took over in 2019, has toured almost all state universities. FILE

karta hai, na sasural. Toh iska maa-baap kaur? Sarkar? (These days boys and girls elope... and someone gets caught after they are pregnant... Neither her family nor his accepts them. So who is responsible for the child? The government?),” Patel said.

Addressing the 45th convocation of Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Gorakhpur University on August 6, Patel flagged deficiencies in hostel infrastructure, student amenities and food, as well as concerns over possible drug abuse. “Logon ko shayad bura lagega, lekin jo hamari kamiyan hain, woh toh humein batani hi padegi. Aane wale teen mahine mein poora karke dik-

hao. Auryeh toh Gorakhpur hai, jahan swayam hamare Mukhyamantri virajmaan hain. Wahan hi aisi kamiyan rahengi to kya hoga (People may feel bad, but we must talk about our shortcomings. In the coming three months, we need to remove this. And this is Gorakhpur, the turf of our CM himself. If there are shortcomings like these here, what else is there to say)?”

Reacting to her remarks, Samajwadi Party chief and former CM Akhilesh Yadav said, “While unravelling the ‘Gorakhpur model’, irregularities in the ‘Gujarat model’ have come to light. The common point is a BJP government and its corruption in both states.”

On August 13, addressing Bundelkhand University’s convocation in Jhansi, Patel recommended “garbh sanskar” initiatives to “educate” women students on pregnancy, nutrition, healthy lifestyles and the importance of maintaining a positive environment during pregnancy. “University is a lab for creating responsible citizens.”

Patel’s aides defend that she comes from this space, believing sincerely that universities are not only places that award degrees but prepare youth for life beyond campus. And that she has a role to play in this. Sources close to the former BJP leader also talk of her propensity for plain talk, having exhibited the quality during her long journey

since joining politics in 1987, be it in the several organisational posts she held or while serving at different levels in the Gujarat government before becoming the state’s first woman CM.

For years, she worked closely with Modi in Gujarat, before he moved to the Centre as the PM. After following him as CM and serving two years in the post, she was moved as the Governor of Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, before being appointed UP Governor in July 2019. It’s to her credit, those close to her say, that she has taken her role as Chancellor this seriously. She has travelled across the large state, including far-flung areas, to visit almost all universities, officials say, adding there are only two-three now that she is yet to visit. They also point to the weight of her remarks ensuring that authorities work to fill gaps in infrastructure in universities as well as draft anti-narcotics guidelines for universities and colleges.

But, if she has busied herself with universities, Patel has ensured she doesn’t step on toes that may prove more problematic. In 2022, soon after Adityanath returned to power for a second time as the CM, Patel held individual meetings with ministers on completion of 100 days of the government. At the time, there was chatter about unhappiness among the ranks, and the rare move by Patel to meet ministers had drawn eyebrows.

32-year-old woman’s death puts Bengaluru’s bad roads under scrutiny again

Atiya Firdos
Bengaluru, August 14

FOR 32-YEAR-OLD Medha Akarsh, Bengaluru’s Ananthanagar Main Road was part of a familiar daily journey to work. On Wednesday morning, that routine commute ended in tragedy when the two-wheeler on which she was travelling as a pillion rider skidded and a mini goods vehicle ran her over.

Medha, who came from Kerala and worked for the Employees’ Provident Fund Organisation, lived in Bengaluru with her husband and their three-year-old child. Her death has since brought residents of Ananth Nagar onto the streets,

with many pointing to the poor condition of roads in the area and the lack of safe alternatives.

According to police, the accident occurred around 9 am near Hebbagodi. A car travelling ahead of the two-wheeler braked suddenly after a bike moved across the road. The rider, Medha’s colleague Ajay Guru, applied the brakes, causing the two-wheeler to skid. Both fell, but Medha came under the wheels of a mini goods vehicle approaching from the opposite direction. She was taken to hospital but succumbed to her injuries.

Guru’s brother, who did not wish to be named, said the two had been using the Ananthana-

gar stretch regularly because several other roads in the area were in poor condition. He said the crash had also left Guru traumatised. “He saw Medha covered in blood and, at that moment, did not know that she would die. He is still struggling to come to terms with the fact that she is gone,” he said.

Locals say several roads around Ananth Nagar have been affected by underground drainage and Cauvery water pipeline works, with potholes, loose gravel, mud and uneven surfaces making commuting difficult, particularly for two-wheeler riders.

“The roads connecting the area are either dug up or in a



After Medha Akarsh’s death, Bengaluru residents staged a protest demanding action on the roads. EXPRESS

very bad condition. Ananthanagar Road was one of the roads we could still use to reach the Metro. Now that road has also been dug up. If it rains, the situation will become horrible,” said a resident who did not wish to be named.

Kripa Varghese, a resident and dentist who runs a clinic near the affected stretch, said residents had repeatedly approached authorities and held a protest around six months ago, but the condition of the roads had not improved. “The rains have made the situation much worse. The roads are now full of large craters. Ananth Nagar Road was one of the few relatively accessible routes, but

even that has been affected after being dug up for pipeline work,” she said.

Residents held a candlelight march following Medha’s death and later staged a larger protest attended by more than 1,000 people, demanding action on the roads.

Municipal Commissioner Rajendra B L said he met the protesting residents on Thursday and discussed their concerns. He said the ongoing road works were linked to the Cauvery water pipeline project and that officials were assessing the stretches where pipeline-related work was required.

“We are looking into the issues raised by the residents.

The ongoing work will be completed soon. At present, no other major work will be taken up in the area. Since it is raining, commuters are facing difficulties, and we will ensure that the affected stretches are attended to,” Rajendra said.

Medha’s death has also renewed scrutiny of Bengaluru’s persistent pothole and road-maintenance problem.

The Greater Bengaluru Authority told the Karnataka High Court on Friday that around 2,600 potholes across the city’s five corporations were yet to be repaired. Authorities said 10,202 potholes had been identified since April, with the majority attended to.



श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी
माननीय प्रधानमंत्री

माननीय केन्द्रीय गृह एवं सहकारिता मंत्री, भारत सरकार

श्री अमित शाह

के कर कमलों से

₹12,112 करोड़

के विकास कार्यों की सौगात



श्री भजनलाल शर्मा
माननीय मुख्यमंत्री

67 लाख किसानों को किसान सम्मान निधि के ₹667 करोड़ की DBT

प्रधानमंत्री फसल बीमा योजना के अंतर्गत ₹152 करोड़ की DBT

10,548 अभ्यर्थियों को सरकारी नौकरी का नियुक्ति पत्र

**सड़क . ऊर्जा . पेयजल . शिक्षा . डेयरी . लोक निर्माण
स्वास्थ्य एवं अन्य आधारभूत संरचनाएं**



❖ **अलवर** ❖

17 जिले को ₹6,453 करोड़ के 954 विकास कार्य

**387 कार्यों का शिलान्यास
567 कार्यों का लोकार्पण**

❖ **निम्बाहेड़ा, चित्तौड़गढ़** ❖

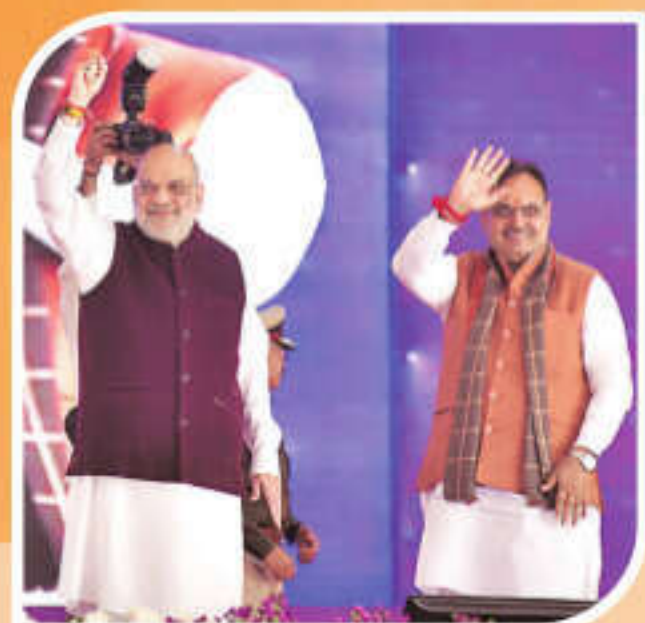
15 जिले को ₹5,659 करोड़ के 944 विकास कार्य

**442 कार्यों का शिलान्यास
502 कार्यों का लोकार्पण**

**विजय नगर ग्राउंड
अलवर**

16 अगस्त, 2026

**डॉ. भीमराव अंबेडकर
राजकीय स्नातकोत्तर महाविद्यालय,
निम्बाहेड़ा (चित्तौड़गढ़)**





The Many Stories That Make India

India’s progress is being shaped every day by the people, ideas and institutions building a stronger, more inclusive and aspirational nation.



INDIA is not one story. It is a million stories unfolding every day—across bustling cities and quiet villages, factories and farms, classrooms and laboratories, hospitals and homes. Stories of people who dream, institutions that build, communities that care and ideas that challenge what is possible.

Our diversity has always been our strength. Different languages, cultures, traditions, professions and perspectives come together to create a nation that is constantly evolving. Yet beneath this remarkable diversity lies a common aspiration—the desire to build a better future for ourselves and for generations to come.

India’s progress is being shaped by countless hands. Entrepreneurs creating new opportunities. Industries powering economic growth. Healthcare professionals bringing hope to lives. Teachers nurturing young minds. Scientists and innovators opening new frontiers. Communities working for inclusion. Citizens taking small but meaningful steps

towards a cleaner, greener and more sustainable tomorrow.

Each of these efforts may tell a different story, but together they form the larger story of India.

As we celebrate Independence Day, it is worth looking beyond the familiar symbols of our freedom and recognising the continuing journey of nation-building. The India of tomorrow will not be created by one institution, one sector or one generation alone. It will emerge from the collective energy, ideas and determination of millions who believe in the possibilities of this country.

This is what makes India’s journey truly inspiring: many paths, many voices, many stories—moving towards one shared vision.

This Independence Day, we celebrate the people, institutions and ideas that are contributing to India’s remarkable journey.

One India. Many Stories. One Vision.



Towards an Inclusive Viksit Bharat: ALIMCO’s Journey from Devices to Dignity

ALIMCO’s 12-year transformation is a powerful journey from accessibility to empowerment.



Praveen Kumar, Chairman and Managing Director

FROM modern manufacturing and home-grown assistive technologies to reaching India’s remotest corners, ALIMCO’s 12-year transformation is a powerful journey from accessibility to empowerment. Beyond rehabilitation, ALIMCO is nurturing para-athletes such as Sarita Dwivedi—its Brand Ambassador and employee, with a World Boccia Ranking of 33 and enabling sporting talent to shine on global platforms. Their achievements are bringing laurels to India while placing ALIMCO on the world stage. This journey demonstrates how technology, opportunity and institutional support can transform ability into excellence. It mirrors the promise of an Inclusive Viksit Bharat—empowering every ability, expanding every possibility, and leaving no one behind.

Building Capacity, Reimagining Purpose

India’s growth story isn’t just about highways and GDP — it’s also about whether every citizen can participate with dignity. That’s the space ALIMCO, a Government of India enterprise under the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment, occupies. Over 12 years, it has grown from a basic device-maker into a full ecosystem of manufacturing, innova-

tion and rehabilitation, lifting production capacity by 2.5x through strategic partnerships.

AI-Powered Assistive Technology: Shaping the Next Frontier at Home-grown Innovation

As assistive technology enters an era of intelligent and personalised solutions, Artificial Intelligence (AI) presents a powerful new frontier for ALIMCO. Building upon capabilities such as 3D scanning, precision manufacturing and advanced electronic technologies, AI can potentially support smarter product design, personalised assistive solutions, data-driven assessment and more responsive rehabilitation services. From intelligent mobility and prosthetic solutions to enhanced accessibility and beneficiary-centric service delivery, the integration of AI can further strengthen ALIMCO’s journey from Make in India to Innovate in India. As the organisation looks towards the future, the convergence of AI, assistive technology and human-centred innovation can help create solutions that do more than compensate for disability—they can anticipate needs, enhance independence and unlock possibilities. Products like the ALIMCO 3-Wheeler EV Scooter and a Clip-on Motorised Wheelchair reflect Atmanirbhar



ALIMCO AT Mart in Kanpur



Bharat in action. Quality is backed by ISO, BIS and CE certifications across its range. Intelligence in Technology. Independence in Life. Inclusion by Design.

Closing the Last Mile

Technology means little without access. ALIMCO now runs 109 PMD-VKs and 102 AASRA service centres nationwide, and opened India’s first Assistive Technology Mart in Kanpur (June 2026) — shifting the narrative from distribution to choice, and from assistance to aspiration.

No Distance Too Far

From Leh-Ladakh to Kozhikode, Andaman & Nicobar to the North-East, ALIMCO’s reach proves accessibility isn’t bound by geography.



Advance Conveyorised Motorised Tricycle assembly line

From Mobility to Medals

Brand ambassador Sarita Dwivedi won double silver at the World Boccia Challenger 2026 in Cairo, supported by ALIMCO’s own ramp operators - a powerful symbol of the arc from rehabilitation to in-

ternational achievement.

Made for the World

With receipt of exports orders from Tanzania and Russia on the horizon, and recognition including the BML Munjal

2.5x boost in production capacity, powered by tech partnerships with international companies in assistive technology, alongside indigenous innovations like the 3-Wheeler EV Scooter.

211 access points nationwide (109 PMD-VKs + 102 AASRA centres) and India’s first Assistive Technology Mart, bringing accessibility from Leh-Ladakh to Kozhikode — capped by brand ambassador Sarita Dwivedi’s double silver at the World Boccia Challenger 2026 in Cairo.

Awards 2026 – Jury’s Special Mention, the Dun & Bradstreet (D&B) Public Sector Excellence Award 2026 – Overall Miniratna Category-II, the SKOCH Award 2026 – Governance Gold, the Global Social Impact Brand Award 2026, and the National Awards for Excellence in Cost Management, ALIMCO is positioning Indian assistive technology as globally credible, affordable and inclusive.

By the Numbers: 2.5x capacity growth | 19 BIS-marked products | 109 PMD-VKs | 102 AASRA centres | 2 Silver medals at Cairo 2026.

The Larger Point

Modernisation, innovation, AI, Sport and global outreach are all threads of one mission: nation-building through inclusion. As India moves toward Viksit Bharat, true progress will be measured not just by distance covered, but by how many are empowered to cover it too.

7 dead, 3 missing after water and debris flood under-construction tunnel in Uttarakhand

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, August 14

SEVEN WORKERS died, and 12 sustained injuries after water and debris gushed into an under-construction tunnel at a hydroelectric project site in Chamoli district on Thursday evening. Three workers remain missing; the search for them continued on Friday.

Tehri Hydro Development Corporation India Limited (THDCIL), the executing agency, in a statement on Friday, said the incident occurred in the Tail Race Tunnel (TRT) of the Vishnugad-Pipalkoti Hydroelectric Project (VPHEP) on Thursday at approximately 6:20 PM when a large volume of water and debris suddenly entered the tunnel at Chainage 1440 meters (face-II), accompanied by a loud noise.

At the time of the incident, concrete lining work was underway at Chainage 1230 meters, where a total of 22



Rescue personnel inside the under-construction tunnel in Chamoli, Uttarakhand, on Friday. PTI

workers deployed by the principal executing agency, Hindustan Construction Company (HCC), were working.

Of the 22 workers trapped, 19 were rescued overnight. Seven of those rescued had died, and the search for three missing continued on Friday.

THDCIL clarified that the

search and rescue operations for the missing workers are being accorded the highest priority and a detailed assessment of the causes and circumstances of the incident will be conducted in coordination with the competent authorities/agencies.

Chamoli District Magistrate Gaurav Kumar said the rescue

operation was launched immediately. "Probably some cavity developed through which water and debris entered the tunnel with a loud sound," he said. Among the injured, 10 are undergoing treatment at the District Hospital in Gopeshwar, one is admitted at the Base Hospital in Srinagar (Pauri Garhwal), and one has been discharged.

The three missing workers have been identified as Chetan Poyam and Devnath from Chhattisgarh, and Lukas Topno from Jharkhand. Among the dead, two were from Uttar Pradesh, two from Chhattisgarh, one from Jharkhand, and two from Tehri Garhwal and Chamoli districts of Uttarakhand.

Among the injured, five are from Jharkhand, two each from Chhattisgarh and Bihar, and one each from West Bengal, Himachal Pradesh and Punjab. Rohit Pandey of Bihar has been referred to the Base Hospital in Srinagar for advanced treat-

ment; Govindo Mandal of West Bengal has been discharged.

Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami on Friday visited the tunnel site, reviewed the search and rescue operations and met injured workers at a government hospital in Gopeshwar. He ordered a magisterial inquiry into the cause of the incident and said rescuing every trapped worker was the government's priority. "There will be no relaxation in the search operation," he said.

Dhami spoke to the chief ministers of the states from which the affected workers came, to ensure their families were informed promptly.

The government has deployed personnel from the National Disaster Response Force, State Disaster Response Force, Indo-Tibetan Border Police, Army, CISF and Uttarakhand Police for the search and rescue operation. Underwater cameras and dog squads are being used.

India locks in 1.7 million tonnes of urea imports at sharply lower price

Harish Damodaran
New Delhi, August 14

IN WHAT could help agricultural operations in the ensuing rabi (winter-spring) crop season, India has secured imports of 17 lakh tonnes (lt) of urea at landed (cost plus ocean freight) prices of \$390.25-\$393.65 per tonne.

This price, at an international tender floated by Rashtriya Chemicals and Fertilizers (RCF) on July 29, is substantially lower than the contracted rates of \$444.9-449.3 and \$935-959 in earlier import tenders issued by state-owned companies.

The RCF tender, the bids for which were opened on August 11 and finalised on Thursday, was for a total quantity of 17 lt, comprising 10 lt to be delivered in western Indian and 7 lt in eastern coast ports. As against this, it attracted offers aggregating 55.47 lt: 31.12 lt for western and 24.35 lt for eastern coast delivery.

The lowest price bids came from the Binningen (Switzerland)-based Ameropa Group - at \$390.25 (east coast) and \$393.65 (west coast) per tonne.

During the current 2026-27 fiscal (April-March), three import tenders have been floated so far. The first one, issued on April 4 and opened on April 15, secured 25 lt of imported urea at \$935 (west coast) and \$959 (east coast) per tonne. The second tender, dated May 27 and opened on June 8, contracted 17 lt imports at \$444.9 (east coast) and \$449.3 (west coast) per tonne.



As paddy sowing is underway in some parts of the country, officials say there is no shortage of urea. PAVAN KHENGRE/FILE

The falling prices are a reflection of two things.

First, an overall easing of the energy supply shock emanating from West Asia, from the peak uncertainty of March-April, when global fuel and fertiliser prices went through the roof. Second, surplus urea availability in China. In-plant inventories there at the end of July were estimated to be about 76 per cent higher than a year ago. "There is also material from Iran that is finding its way into the market through China," an industry source added.

India's urea availability position has staged a significant improvement on account of both imports and domestic production. According to data from the Fertiliser Association of India, urea imports during April-June 2026, at 25.08 lt, were way higher than the 8.38 lt for April-June 2025. Domestic output, too, rose from 67.88 lt in April-June 2025 to 71.53 lt in April-June 2026.

"The government has managed the supply situation well

in urea, whether through proactiveness in procuring imports through global tenders or pushing GAIL (India) Ltd and Indian Oil Corporation to diversify the sourcing of liquefied natural gas (LNG) required for domestic manufacturing. Even as LNG imports from Qatar and Saudi Arabia dwindled to near-zero after the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, more supplies were contracted from other countries such as the US, Oman, Angola, People's Republic of Congo, Indonesia, Trinidad and Norway," the source added.

For now, there is no shortage of urea for the ongoing kharif (monsoon) or upcoming rabi season. Availability of di-ammonium phosphate and complex fertilisers, however, remains a concern. The success achieved in widening the import sources of urea and LNG has not been replicated in the other fertilisers, including their key raw materials/intermediates like sulphur, phosphoric acid and ammonia.

2 Nagas killed in suspected Kuki militant attack on Manipur village

Express News Service
Imphal, August 14

TWO NAGA villagers were killed and two others injured after suspected Kuki militants launched an attack on Langka village in Kangpokpi district of Manipur on Friday morning. The Liangmai Naga Council (LNC) alleged that the attack could have been prevented had authorities heeded repeated security warnings from the community.

Langka (Niulong) is a Liang-

mai Naga village situated along the Imphal-Tamenglong Road, approximately 65 km from Imphal.

The attack took place around 7:30 am as villagers were heading to their paddy fields. According to local sources, militants wielding sophisticated weapons opened indiscriminate fire on the villagers.

Wiriliangbou Chawang, 35, was shot dead on the spot, while Kawidinang Abonmai, 54, succumbed to an abdominal injury

on the way to hospital. The two injured were identified as Nanthiulungbou Prinmai, 45, who sustained a groin injury, and Malinginang Abonmai, 50, who suffered chest and arm injuries.

LNC president Timothy Wijunamai said miscreants had attempted to attack the village a month earlier but failed. Following that attempt, villagers had on several occasions urged the authorities to deploy CRPF personnel in the area, but received no response. "The attack

could have been prevented had the authorities taken the security concerns of the villagers seriously," he said. While the LNC alleged that KNF-P Kuki militants were responsible for the attack, the claim could not be independently verified.

Following the incident, the LNC declared an Emergency Total Shutdown across all Liangmai Naga-inhabited areas of Manipur with immediate effect. All shops and institutions have been asked to remain closed,

with medical, fire and other essential services exempted.

The council urged the community to remain calm and observe the shutdown peacefully, and called on authorities to take immediate measures to ensure public safety and bring those responsible to justice. The attack has heightened security concerns along the Kangpokpi-Tamenglong border belt, where Langka and neighbouring Naga areas have witnessed armed clashes in the past.

ADVERTORIAL

An initiative by **RED**
Read. Engage. Deliver.

INDIA'S journey towards freedom has been marked by struggle, heroism and determination to gain independence from the British. As the nation celebrates 80 of its Independence and is at the threshold of another defining chapter, the journey to becoming one of the world's major economies has been marked by numerous achievements.

The next stage is more ambitious, with a focus on building a Viksit Bharat which is economically strong, socially inclusive, technologically advanced, environmentally sustainable and confident on the global stage. The vision of India@2047 is ultimately about creating better opportunities and a higher quality of life for every citizen.

To achieve this sustained progress across several interconnected areas, a strong and resilient economy is much needed, which will act as a foundation of this very transformation. Expansion of manufacturing, strengthening infrastructure, encouraging entrepreneurship and creating qual-

The India we dream, The India we build

ity employment will be critical to ensuring that economic growth translates into greater prosperity. India's growing role in global supply chains and its expanding domestic market provide a strong platform for this journey. However, this development cannot be measured by just economic numbers. Its true impact will be only visible in the opportunities available to ordinary citizens.

Education and skills will be central for preparing India for the future. With a large youth population, the country has an extraordinary demographic advantage. Quality education, vocational training, digital skills and research opportunities can help young Indians participate in emerging sectors and

shape new industries.

Innovation will have an upper hand in order to strengthen this advantage. From space technology and digital public infrastructure to artificial intelligence, startups and advanced manufacturing, India is increasingly demonstrating its capacity to develop solutions at scale. The ambi-

tion for 2047 is to deepen this ecosystem and make India not just a consumer of technology, but a creator of globally relevant ideas.

For a developed nation, inclusivity holds great significance. Rural communities, women, entrepreneurs, workers and traditionally underserved sections need access to ed-

ucation, healthcare, finance, technology and economic opportunities. Strong social infrastructure and greater participation of women in the workforce can help ensure that the benefits of growth are widely shared.

Equal importance is placed on sustainability. India's development journey requires balancing economic aspirations with environmental responsibility. Renewable energy, water conservation, sustainable cities, cleaner mobility and climate-resilient infrastructure can help create growth that remains viable for generations.

ADVERTORIAL

TROOP COMFORTS LIMITED

A GOVERNMENT OF INDIA ENTERPRISE, MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

AS INDIA celebrates Independence Day 2026, Troop Comforts Limited (TCL) stands as a premier symbol of Atmanirbhar Bharat. Established in 2021 as a 100% Government-owned Defence Public Sector Undertaking, TCL has modernized a 160-year manufacturing legacy to become a powerhouse in defence technical textiles and combat gear.

At the heart of TCL's mission is an **unwavering commitment to serving the Indian Armed Forces**. Whether outfitting soldiers in -50°C glacial heights with Advanced Extreme Cold Weather Clothing Systems or equipping them for +50°C scorching deserts, TCL ensures our frontline guardians have uncompromising protection. By indigenously manufacturing critical life-cycle clothing, ballistic protection, and specialized mountaineering equipment, TCL remains the trusted backbone of troop comfort, mobility, and safety.

Beyond securing domestic supply chains, TCL is actively expanding its global footprint by focusing on defence exports. By producing gear that meets rigorous international military standards, TCL contributes significantly to India's national **defense export** goals, taking world-class, "Made in India" technical textiles and tactical equipment to allied nations globally.

This Independence Day, TCL proudly reaffirms its vision: elevating India's global defense standing through export excellence while standing steadfastly beside every Indian soldier. Jai Hind!

**FOR EVERY FRONTIER
FOR EVERY SOLDIER**

स्वातंत्र्या दिवस

की सभी प्रदेशवासियों को हार्दिक शुभकामनायें

कार्यालय, निदेशक

हृदय रोग संस्थान, कानपुर

वर्तमान उपलब्ध सेवायें

- आयुष्मान भारत प्रधानमंत्री जन आरोग्य योजना में अब तक (माह जुलाई 2026) कुल 8820 हृदय रोगियों को भर्ती कर उपचार किया गया है।
- असाध्य रोग निःशुल्क उपचार योजना के अन्तर्गत संस्थान में वित्तीय वर्ष 2013-14 से अभी तक (माह जुलाई 2026) कुल 32231 निर्धन रोगियों का निःशुल्क (फ्री) उपचार किया।
- आकस्मिक सेवायें (24x7)।
- सभी रक्त परीक्षण लिपिड प्रोफाइल तथा डॉप-टी सहित।
- सीटीओ एन्जियो 128 स्लाइस।
- एक्स-रे तानों मजिलों पर बेड साइड एक्स-रे सहित।
- इंसीजी।
- होल्टर मॉनिटरिंग।
- इकोकार्डियोग्राफी-एडल्ट एवं ट्रांसडोप्लेयरिजल तथा बीएमओ (बलूनिंग), इंट्रा एवं ओटी में।
- एन्जियोग्राफी-एन्जियो द्वारा इमरजेंसी।
- लेजर सर्जरी-वैरिकोज वेन्स।
- वीडियो ब्रॉकोस्कोपी, वीडियो इंडोस्कोपी तथा फोरिनबीडी रिमूवल।
- वैस्क्यूलर सर्जरी-सभी प्रकार की।
- थोरेसिक सर्जरी-सभी प्रकार की।
- सूक्ष्म छिद्र प्रणाली सर्जरी (मैट्रोस)।
- फिजियोथेरेपी एवं कार्डियक रिहैबिलिटेशन।
- प्रथम 24 घंटे समस्त उपचार निःशुल्क।
- सर्जिकल आईसीयू में पोस्ट ऑपरेटिव हृदय रोगियों के लिये CRRT मशीन की सुविधा।

वर्ष 2026 की उपलब्धियाँ

- मेडिकल ऑफिसर, मैट्रन, नर्सिंग ऑफिसर हेतु 32 प्लेट का निर्माण।
- डे-केयर ब्लॉक का निर्माण प्रारम्भ जिसमें ऑपरेशन थिएटर एवं कैथलेब की सुविधा उपलब्ध होगी।
- संस्थान में 33 कंटीए सबस्टेशन की स्थापना, जिससे निरन्तर निरन्तर विद्युत आपूर्ति की जा सके।
- संस्थान के मुख्य भवन में 60 नये बेडों की व्यवस्था।
- हृदय रोगियों को उच्चतम स्तर की सेवायें देने हेतु शिक्षण/प्रशिक्षण पर विशेष बल।
- संस्थान के उत्कृष्ट शैक्षणिक एवं उपचार कार्य के परिणामस्वरूप एमसीएच सीटीपीटीएस-12 सीट तथा डीएम (कार्डियोलॉजी)-12 सीट एवं डीएम (कार्डियक एनेस्थीसिया)-सीट 6 सीट के साथ सुपरस्पेशियलिटी कोर्स का संचालन किया जा रहा है।
- डीएनबी वैस्क्यूलर सर्जरी-2 सीट, डीएनबी थोरेसिक सर्जरी-1 सीट के साथ संचालित है।
- संस्थान में एमएससी कार्डियो थोरेसिक नर्सिंग-20 सीट एवं बीएससी ओटी-20 सीट, ओटी टेक्नीशियन-40 सीट एवं कार्डियक टेक्नीशियन-40 सीट के साथ पैरामेडिकल कोर्स संचालित है।
- सम्पूर्ण संस्थान भवन एवं प्रांगण का एलईडी लाइट एवं हरे पौधों द्वारा सौन्दर्यीकरण।
- रोगियों की सुविधा हेतु 24x7 इमरजेंसी कंट्रोल रूम का संचालन।
- बाउण्ड्रीवाल तथा भव्य प्रवेश द्वार का निर्माण।
- संस्थान अब NABH मान्यता प्राप्त संस्थान बन गया है।

आयुष्मान योजना के अन्तर्गत प्रथम आयुष्मान लाभार्थी के उपचार करने का गौरव तथा असाध्य रोग नियमावली के अन्तर्गत हृदय रोगियों में सर्वाधिक लाभार्थियों को निःशुल्क उपचार प्रदान करने का गौरव हृदय रोग संस्थान, कानपुर को प्राप्त है।

संस्थान में प्रधानमंत्री जन आरोग्य आयुष्मान योजना, पं० दीन दयाल उपाध्याय कैरालेस योजना एवं असाध्य रोग (हृदय रोग) नियमावली के अन्तर्गत हृदय रोगियों का पूर्णतः निःशुल्क उपचार किया जाता है।

Brief triple hydraulic failure in Phuket-Delhi flight: Airbus initial assessment of flight data

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 14

THE AIR India A320 aircraft that suddenly dropped 300 feet while flying from Phuket to Delhi on August 4 experienced a temporary loss of hydraulic systems, which led to loss of key control surfaces for about four seconds, an initial assessment of the digital flight data recorder (DFDR) data by aircraft manufacturer Airbus is learnt to have said. The aircraft — bearing registration VT-EXO — was cruising at an altitude of about 36,000 feet over Odisha when the altitude-loss incident occurred.

While the government and Air India had initially attributed the incident to severe turbulence, a series of snags involving the aircraft's hydraulic systems and flight control surfaces have emerged as a key focus area for investigators. Notably, the pilot-in-command (PIC) of the aircraft also tested positive for marijuana, but given the initial assessment by the Airbus, it now appears unlikely that his positive drug test may be directly related to the serious incident involving the aircraft. On Monday, *The Indian Express* had reported quoting sources the aircraft likely faced a series of snags pertaining to hydraulic systems and flight control at time of the incident.

The incident, which led to 24 people on board sustaining injuries, is under investigation by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB), with Airbus and French aircraft accident investigation body BEA assisting in the probe. In its initial analy-

The Airbus A320 aircraft has three independent hydraulic systems — coded green, blue, and yellow — built as a redundancy so that the loss of one such system doesn't result in total loss of hydraulic control

sis, which was sought by Air India, Airbus didn't identify the underlying cause of the failure of hydraulic systems, and asked the airline to conduct a series of maintenance tests and inspections — including checks of hydraulic pressure switches, pressure transducers, wiring, and the aircraft's flight-control and automatic-flight systems, it is learnt. The manufacturer has also asked Air India to provide maintenance activities performed on the plane's hydraulic system in the last month.

A request for comment didn't elicit a response from Air India. In a statement, Airbus said, "In accordance with ICAO Annex 13, Airbus is providing technical assistance to the relevant investigating authorities and actively supporting the airline. We do not comment on ongoing investigations."

The Airbus A320 aircraft has three independent hydraulic systems — coded green, blue, and yellow — built as a redundancy so that the loss of one such system doesn't result in total loss

of hydraulic control. Hydraulic pressure is essential for moving several of the aircraft's flight-control surfaces. According to experts, simultaneous loss of the three hydraulic systems was virtually considered an impossibility on the A320, one of the most flown aircraft types globally.

According to an August 10 communication to Air India, Airbus is learnt to have said that as per the DFDR data, the aircraft's three independent hydraulic systems were lost in quick succession, resulting in the loss of control over elevators and ailerons for around four seconds. During this period, the aircraft's nose pitched upwards and the autopilot disengaged.

The first officer — who was the pilot flying the aircraft — commanded for the nose to be pushed down, but the flight control surfaces were non-responsive due to loss of hydraulic control, it is learnt. Then the hydraulic systems recovered within seconds, and the sudden lowering of the nose to bring the aircraft under control likely threw passengers and cabin crew upwards, resulting in injuries to some of them.

As per the initial analysis, the aircraft first experienced a loss of the green hydraulic system shortly before 09:32:44 am, followed by the loss of blue and yellow hydraulic systems at 09:32:45. At 09:32:51 am, the blue system recovered, followed a few seconds later by the yellow and green systems, it is learnt. As hydraulic pressure returned, the flight-control surfaces also recovered.

Odisha start-up tests drug manufacturing in space

Amtabh Sinha
New Delhi, August 14

IN AN important feat for the private space industry in India, a Bhubaneswar-based start-up has successfully flight-tested a prototype satellite that is designed to carry out some crucial steps in pharmaceutical manufacturing process under micro-gravity conditions of space.

Serendipity Space, which began operations just last year, used a high-altitude balloon at the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research balloon facility in Hyderabad to launch its satellite system and experience near-space like conditions. The satellite carried an 'autonomous pharmaceutical factory' that the company calls 'Alchemy'.

The company said the system operated continuously in harsh space conditions, and successfully executed the processes



SERENDIPITY SPACE
The prototype satellite being carried by a balloon

it was designed for, before making a controlled return to Earth.

"The vehicle tested core technologies for the company's future orbital fleet, including the advanced heatshield systems, avionics and its autonomous pharmaceutical factory, Alchemy," the company said in a statement.

Space-based drug manufacturing is a concept that has been studied and experimented with for decades. The

E. EXPLAINED

Expanding footprint

The fact that Serendipity Space is located in Bhubaneswar is an indication of the expanding footprint of private space ecosystem in India. Most of the Indian space companies are located in Bengaluru, but emergence of such start-ups in cities like Pune, Ahmedabad and now Bhubaneswar not just strengthens the ecosystem, but can also act as magnet for fresh talent, jobs and ancillary industries.

microgravity conditions of space offer a conducive environment for completing some steps of the manufactur-

Sangeet Natak Akademi award for Odissi exponent Varadkar

Suanshu Khurana
New Delhi, August 14

COMING FROM a family of illustrious academics, lawyers, freedom fighters and medical practitioners, Shubhada Varadkar grew up in a home where neither music nor dance was considered a vocation. Her mother was enthusiastic and encouraged her but there was no vision of a professional career.

"There was no legacy of dance anywhere around. Nobody even knew what classical dance was. That atmosphere, however, did allow for democratic decision-making. When I wanted to dance, there was no resistance. My father said if you

like it, do it," says 65-year-old Mumbai-based Shubhada, who went on to choose dance as her path and was conferred the Sangeet Natak Akademi award for Odissi on Thursday at Vigyan Bhavan by President Droupadi Murmu.

"A recognition for your work always gives you extra energy but with that also comes the responsibility to be better at what you have been doing, improve on that," says Shubhada.

Daughter of freedom fighters Manohar and Manik Varadkar, and granddaughter of famed pathologist V R Khanolkar, who was the first Dean of the Tata Memorial Cancer Research Institute, Shubhada



Shubhada Varadkar

is also the first cousin of Leo Varadkar, former PM of Ireland and the country's first openly gay head of State.

Shubhada is also the grandniece of Savitri Bai Khanolkar (born Eve Yvonne Maday de Maros) of Swiss origin, who de-

signed the Param Vir Chakra, India's highest gallantry award.

Shubhada, who enjoyed dancing in school, began her official training as a dancer after her Class 10 results. Her parents set a condition to dance: she had to get a distinction and they would allow official training.

She began Bharatanatyam training under Guru Shri Mani in Mumbai "because it was near the house". Some years later, Odissi legend Kelucharan Mohapatra visited Mumbai's National Centre for Performing Arts for a workshop. Shubhada got permission from her very "open-minded guru" to attend it.

At the Centre, she fell in love with the lyricality, flow, and

movement of Odissi. She would go on to study economics and went on to become a professor at RR Ruia College in Mumbai.

She also learned from Mohapatra in Bhubaneswar at his gurukul. "I was very fortunate as I belong to the last batch that learned from him in the gurukul system. We saw him teach his senior students like Sanjukta Panigrahi. We stayed there and learned and there was no clock on a class or exams. It was learning for the purpose of learning. The choreography we do now is entirely his reflection. He would choreograph 50 different poses for one word and then teach one," says Shubhada, who is also a two-time cancer survivor.

रजिस्ट्री सं. डी.एल.- 33002/99

REGD. No. D.L.-33002/99

भारत सरकार
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA



सत्यमेव जयते

दिल्ली राजपत्र
Delhi Gazette

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असाधारण
EXTRAORDINARY

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No. 233] DELHI, MONDAY, AUGUST 10, 2026/SHRAVAN 19, 1948 [N. C. T. D. No. 163

REVENUE DEPARTMENT
NOTIFICATION

Delhi, the 7th August, 2026

Declaration by Secretary, Revenue Department

F. No. DMS-S015/1/2026-LAC-DM(SOUTH)/E-383994/411-418. The declaration under Section 19(1) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 [in accordance with Rule 10 of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement (Compensation, Rehabilitation and Resettlement and Development Plan) Rules, 2015] regarding proposed acquisition of Land measuring 3406.057 square meters is urgently required for public purpose, namely, for SAARC to CAPFIMS Road in Revenue Village Maidan Garhi, Sub-Division Chattarpur, District South, Delhi for construction of approach Road leading to Central Armed Police Forces Institute of Medical Sciences (CAPFIMS) for Delhi Development Authority.

Whereas, it appears to the Government that a total of land measuring 3406.057 square meters (0.3406057 hectares) is required in the village Maidan Garhi, Sub-Division Chattarpur, South District for public purpose namely, for the construction of approach road leading to Central Armed Police Forces Institute of Medical Sciences (CAPFIMS).

Therefore, declaration is made that a total land measuring 3406.057 square meters is under acquisition for the above said project in Revenue Village Maidan Garhi, Sub-Division Chattarpur, District South whose detailed description is given below in schedule of land:-

S. No.	Kh. No.	Type of title	Type of land	Area under acquisition (in Sqm)	Name and address of person interested	Boundaries			
						N.	S.	E.	W.
1.	974/421 422 Min	Private	Vacant	1179.546 (136.168 in Kh No. 421 and 1043.378 in Kh No. 422)	1. Bhudan Yagya Samiti, 2. Smt. Abha Devi W/o Satish Kumar Modi, R/o Modi Nagar, U.P.	Kh. No. 423	Kh. No. 424	Kh. No. 420	Remain- ing part of Kh.No 974/ 421-422 min & Kh. No. 424
2.	442 min	Private	Vacant	1760.744	1. Maan Singh Dagar S/o Ramphal R/o Maidan Garhi 2. Narain Singh Dagar S/o Ramphal R/o Maidan Garhi 3. Laxmi Devi D/o Ramphal 4. Maya D/o Ramphal 5. Smt Yashi Jaspal W/o S.S. Jaspal R/o 96 C, Eastern Avenue, Sainik Farm, New Delhi 6. Subhas S/o Maan Singh 7. Adarsh S/o Maan Singh 8. Anil Kumar S/o Maan Singh 9. Kulshrestha S/o Maan Singh 10. Nargeshwari D/o Maan Singh 11. Rajkala w/o Ashok Kumar 12. Ankur S/o Ashok Kumar 13. Smt.Kavita D/o Ashok Kumar 14.Smt.Kanchan D/o Ashok Kumar 15. Satbir S/o Phool Kaur	Kh. No. 424	Kh. No. 443	Remain- ing part of Kh. No. 442 Min	Remain- ing part of Kh. No. 424 Min
3.	519 min	Private	Vacant	41.995	Sh. Karan Kumar Modi S/o Satish Kumar Modi, R/o Modi Nagar, U.P.			Kh. No. 520 & 424	Kh. No. 424
4.	520 min	Private	Vacant	423.772	Smt. Abha Devi W/o Satish Kumar Modi, R/o Modi Nagar, U.P.			Kh. No. 424 & 424	Kh. No. 424

Trees

S. No.	Kh. No.	Number of trees
1.	974/421-422 Min	4
2.	519 Min	1

Structures

S. No.	Kh. No.	Number of trees	Number
1.	974/421-422 Min	Vacant	NA
2.	442 Min	Vacant	NA
3.	519 Min	Vacant	NA
4.	520 Min	Vacant	NA

This declaration is made under Section 19(1) read with section 40 (1) and (4) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 to all whom it may concern. Mines of coal, iron-stone, slate or other minerals lying under the said land or any particular portion of the said land, except such parts of the mines and minerals which may be required to be dug or removed or used during the construction phase of the project for the purpose of which the land is being acquired are not needed. A plan of the land may be inspected in the office of the Deputy Commissioner/ Collector, District South, Delhi and Director (LM)-II, DDA on any working day during the working hours.

By Order and in the Name of Lt. Governor of National Capital Territory of Delhi, Sh NEERAJ SEMWAL, IAS, Secy.

DIP/SHABDARTH/CLASSIFIED/0181/26-27



GOVT. OF NATIONAL CAPITAL TERRITORY OF DELHI
OFFICE OF LAND ACQUISITION COLLECTOR (SOUTH)
M.B ROAD, SAKET, NEW DELHI - 110068

F.No.-DMS-S015/1/2026-LAC-DM(SOUTH)/Satbari/527-539

Dated: 13/08/26

Public Notice under Section 21 of the RECTLARR Act, 2013

Whereas, earlier, vide notification no. DMS-S015/1/2026-LAC-DM (SOUTH)/E-3899/373-380 dated 06.08.2026, a total of 8884.967 square meters of land is required at Gaushala Road in Revenue Village Satbari Sub-Division Chattarpur District South for public purpose, namely, widening of approach road leading to Central Armed Police Forces Institute of Medical Sciences (CAPFIMS) for Delhi Development Authority was notified under section 11(1) read with Section 40(1) and 40 (4) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013 (30 of 2013) and published in the Part IV of the NCT of Delhi Gazette.

And whereas, the declaration under section 19 of RFCTLARR Act 2013 was notified vide Notification No. DMS-S015/1/2026-LAC-DM(SOUTH)/E-383994/419-426 dated 07.08.2026 and published in the Part IV of the NCT of Delhi Gazette.

The particulars of land under acquisition are as under:-

S.No.	Kh.No.	Area under acquisition (in Sqm)
1	269 min	1224.931
2	270 min	1236.669
3	273 min	1244.879
4	274 min	1244.964
5	275 min	1241.131
6	293 min	647.241
7	295 min	46.246
8	297/1 min	66.64
9	298 Min	76.06
10	299 Min	79.07
11	313/1 min	106.103
12	314/1 min	197.95
13	401 min	264.766
14	402 min	260.881
15	427 Min	260.955
16	428 Min	269.188
17	429 Min	417.293

As such now, in accordance with section 21 of RFCTLARR Act 2013, notice is being given for intimating to all concerned that the Government intends to take possession of the land mentioned above notifications which is required for "public purpose" and that claims to compensation in above land may be made by all interested persons by appearing personally or by agent or advocate stating the nature of their respective interests in the land and the amount and particulars of their claims to compensation for such interests, along with their objections if any, before the Land Acquisition Collector on 14th September 2026 at 02:00 PM in the Conference Hall of the office of District Magistrate (South).

(Lakshay Singhal, IAS)
Collector and District Magistrate
(South Delhi)

DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0184/26-27

epaper.indianexpress.com



PRADEEP KUMAR KASHYAP

AFIAG GOES UP

For years, Kondapalli served as the base for Battalion No. 1, the armed unit of the Maoists. The village school shut down, the bus service was halted and people lived in fear, caught between security forces and the Maoists. Ahead of Independence Day, JAYPRAKASH S NAIDU travels to the village in Chhattisgarh's Bijapur district to see what happens when the State finally moves in



PHOTOS: JAYPRAKASH S NAIDU

HUNGA MUCHAKI says little. When he speaks, he does so haltingly — unsure of the question asked of him, probably suspicious of the outsider who wants to know more about him. In his 28 years, most of it as a Maoist, rarely has anyone asked him what he wanted for himself, his wife, his daughters, about his dreams. So he listens, doesn't talk for very long, and then says, "We want a borewell for irrigation, a pond, land rights and small roads. We want a doctor to visit us, otherwise we have to travel over 30 km to Basaguda."

As a Maoist commander, Muchaki had resisted government intervention; but now, five months after surrendering and opening a kirana store in his Kondapalli village, Muchaki is unapologetic as he demands from the State what he sees as rightfully his.

And then, he goes quiet, his attention returning to the reels on his smartphone.

The phone came to Kondapalli, in Chhattisgarh's Bijapur district, in December last year, when a cellphone tower was erected on the edge of the village. The steel tower, which rises above the mud houses and small shops, was among the first few signs of change in a village that was until two years ago deep in the Maoist heartland, one of nearly 400 villages in Chhattisgarh's Red Corridor where the state had little say or presence.

Kondapalli was part of the Maoists' South Bastar division and served as a base for Battalion 1, the most dreaded unit of the armed People's Liberation Guerrilla Army. Located 79 km from Bijapur, it was where roads wound deep into the dense jungles of sal, teak and bamboo, where government offices and the school building stood empty, and the buses never came.

Now, 80 years after Independence, with Union Home Minister Amit Shah declaring the country Maoist-free, the State is back in Kondapalli, establishing itself through a string of visible markers of development — roads, panchayat bhawans, an anganwadi, an upper primary school and a road.

Along the Red Corridor

Former Bijapur Superintendent of Police Jitendra Kumar says Kondapalli, a village of 600 people, lay in the Maoists' South Bastar division, part of what they called the 'Liberated Zone'. Every year, the Maoists would gather hundreds of villagers to a 64-foot-tall memorial in Komatpalli, part of the Kondapalli gram panchayat, to celebrate Martyrs' Week.

The division, he says, was one of the strongest Maoist formations and among the last to fall. "They could gather the support of over 400-500 people in no time," says SP Kumar, who is now posted in Kabirdham. "Kondapalli was important to the Maoists also because their supplies came from its local market."

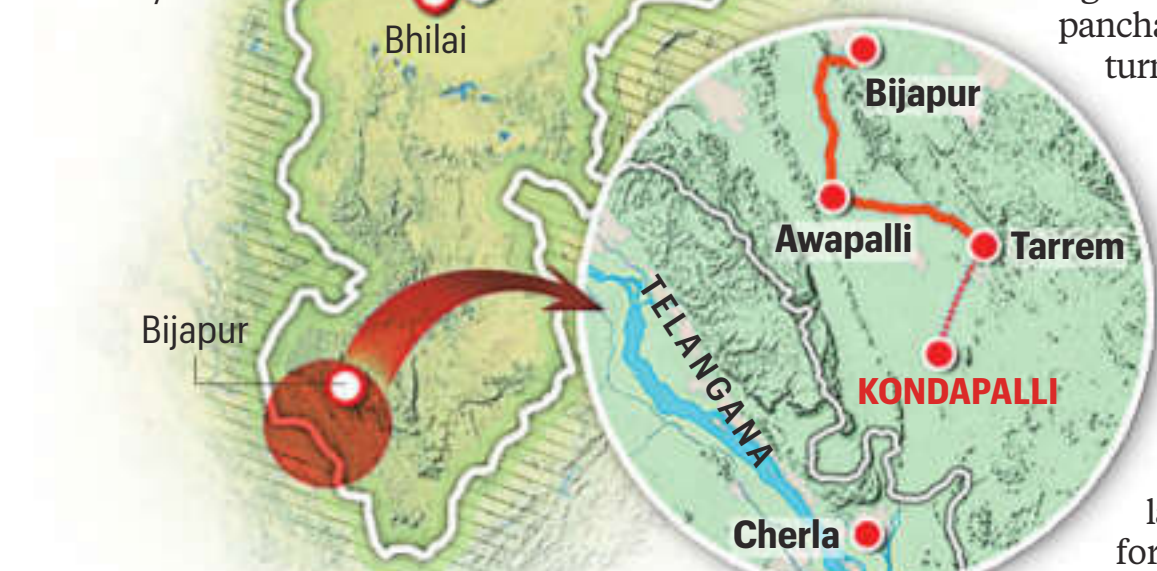
That changed in November 2024, when the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) announced that it was establishing a forward base in Kondapalli. A series of encounters followed, after which the Maoists were pushed into Telangana, where they eventually laid down arms in March 2026.

For the State, the entry into Kondapalli and nearby villages signalled the end of a decades-long insurgency that had claimed at least 4,741 lives in Bastar region alone since 2000.

"The battalion (Battalion No. 1) used to

ROAD TO KONDAPALLI

Kondapalli, which sits on the border with Telangana, is closer to Cherla (46 km) in the neighbouring state than its own district headquarters of Bijapur, which is 79 km away



camp in the jungle outside our village. They are gone now, but in their place, security forces camp," says Manish Esam, husband of the sarpanch of Kondapalli panchayat.

It's an uneasy space to be in, so Hunga Muchaki prefers to largely stay quiet and cautious, glancing up from the reels he is watching only when a customer turns up at his kirana store, asking for a packet of biscuits. He says he watches action flicks and tribal songs, pointing to the YouTube and Instagram icons to indicate how he gets there.

A former commander of the Revolutionary People's Committee, a grassroots governing body of the Maoists, Muchaki surrendered in March 2025 with 12 other villagers and set up the shop with the money he got as part of the state's rehabilitation policy.

Muchaki was a teenager when he joined the Bal Sangam, the Maoists' children's wing, and later, its cultural troupe, the Chetna Natya Manch, where he mostly sang about saving *jal*, *jungle*, *zameen* (the land and its resources).

He didn't have much of a choice, says his younger brother Lachu Muchaki, 22, a CRPF

recruit. "Those days, at least one person from every village had to join the Naxals. So there was a lot of pressure on families to give up their sons or daughters. Once he joined them, the Naxals convinced Hunga (Muchaki) that the government would steal his land and they would eventually have to leave the village. All he wanted was to save his land," says Lachu, who left the village and completed his school while staying in a hostel in Usoor, Bijapur.

The Maoists ruled with an iron hand — villagers say those leaving Kondapalli gram panchayat were questioned on their return.

But residents claim that for many of them, even this came with a feeling of being seen. "There wasn't much development, but there was a sense of security. They redistributed land and gained our trust. They helped us make our houses, though cutting trees was punishable. If anyone fell sick, villagers were asked to donate money for the treatment. They also made small roads and a pond. But then, the forest officials and *patwari* (the village records keeper), stopped coming. When the administration brought electric poles, they destroyed them and we had to depend on solar lamps. When those failed, we got used to staying in the dark," says a villager who doesn't want to be identified.

The Maoists came down heavily on violators and those they suspected of being police informers. "Wrongdoers were publicly beaten up under a tree, and those who were suspected of being informers were killed. Those who learnt their lessons stayed back while others left the village," he says.

"We were people caught in the middle," says Lachu, talking of how his uncle Masa was killed by security forces on the suspicion that he was a Maoist.

Suka Tamo, a villager, talks about the time in December 2022 when his 18-year-old daughter Somdi left home to take the cattle out to graze, but joined the Maoists instead. Last year, Tamo learnt that she was among the 30-odd Maoists killed in a security operation in Telangana's Karregutta hills.

"I had no idea why she joined the Maoists. But my sons stayed away," he says.

A bus comes to Kondapalli

As a blue bus from Cherla in Telangana turns the corner on the main road and stops just outside the Kondapalli school, a group of villagers lurch forward. The bus is already full, a few sitting on the luggage rack on the roof. Since March 2025, when the bus service began under the state's rural bus scheme, it has been making two trips a day, taking villagers both to Bijapur, 79 km to the north, and to Cherlam in neighbouring Telangana on the other side, where many of the young men work as daily-wage labourers.

Venkat Swami Punem, the 53-year-old village head or *mukhiya* of Kondapalli, is glad the bus has returned before it could fade from his memory. "Back in the 1980s, I used to take a bus from our village to go to school in Awapalli, some 27 km away," says Punem as he watches the bus groan and disappear in a cloud of dust on the unpaved road outside the village.

Years after the Maoists came from Telangana in 1985, the bus stopped, and an entire generation grew up without ever seeing one.

Kondapalli, which sits on the border with Telangana, is closer to Cherla (46 km) in the neighbouring state than its own district headquarters of Bijapur.

Those days, says Punem, a circuitous 209-km, five-hour journey through Cherla was the only way to travel from Bijapur to Kondapalli.

Now, a 90-minute car ride from Bijapur to the village doesn't have to cross into Telangana, instead passing through two busy junctions, Awapalli and Basaguda, and reaching Tarrem on the Sukma-Bijapur border. For the next 18 km beyond Tarrem, Google Maps falters, still recommending the older, longer route through Telangana.

The Defence Ministry's Border Roads Organisation (BRO) began working on the Tarrem-Kondapalli road soon after November 2024, when security forces pushed back the Maoists in a series of encounters.

The road, which snakes through jungles, is still a work in progress, with the occasional motorcycle or truck carrying construction material lumbering along.

The road passes Kondapalli to eventually

(Top) At the new school building in Kondapalli; Hunga Muchaki at the kirana store he set up after leaving the Maoists

Soon after the Maoists came from Telangana in 1985, the bus stopped, and an entire generation grew up without ever seeing one

cross over into Telangana, a stretch where the BRO installed nine Bailey bridges over river streams and 43 precast culverts to ensure smooth connectivity during the rains.

Before the road came up, says Punem, he and the others who worked in Telangana would walk for two days, carrying their food supplies, including 30 kg of rice. "Once we reached, we would stay there for 45 days and get work plucking chillies on farms. Now, we have a daily bus to get there," he says.

He doesn't go to Telangana for work anymore. Both of his sons stayed outside the village to complete their technical diploma courses. "I talk to them on the phone," he says, proudly displaying a smartphone that one of his sons gifted him.

The light's back

While the Maoists ruled, all signs of the State had ceased to exist. Voting stopped, government offices were broken, and officials stopped coming.

"The village voted for the first time last year, in the local body polls. When the Maoists were around, we were told not to make any demands from the government," says Manish Esam, a 41-year-old villager.

Last July, Kondapalli got electricity from the grid; the cellphone tower came up next. Other changes followed: villagers were told to turn up at the police camp where they were enrolled under Aadhaar, and given birth certificates and bank accounts.

An anganwadi and a residential school are also under construction in the village. "Over the next two years, the village will get a cricket ground, a health centre, a cement road and government scheme benefits," says Bijapur District Collector Vishwadeep.

Then, on June 2, Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai visited Kondapalli, a first for the village.

A new, blue school

But nothing symbolises the village's transition, and hope, better than the government school.

Sometime in the 2000s, the Maoists had burnt down the only school in the village and the adjoining hostel to dissuade security forces from using it as their shelter. And then, just like that, an entire generation of youngsters in Kondapalli were left staring at a blank slate.

Muchaki was among those who dropped out that year. But now, he sees hope. His two daughters study in the new school building that came up in the summer of 2025.

The school stands by the main road, painted in a bright, happy blue. Days ahead of Independence Day, tricolours flutter in the open compound where children queue up for the morning assembly.

Mangal Ram Veko, 42, one of the seven all-male teaching staff, says, "After the school was burnt down, children studied in a shanty in the same compound. Then, in 2020, we got an asbestos shade made there. Now, a proper building has been made for primary and middle school students. We also have blackboards and benches and students are able to focus better. We have 158 students, and the numbers are increasing."

Veko, who calls himself "the first graduate in Kondapalli", says he could complete his education only because he left during the Salwa Judum days to study in a hostel in Basaguda and then moved to Dantewada for college. The Salwa Judum, a civilian counter-insurgency force set up in 2005, was declared illegal by the Supreme Court in 2011.

The Kondapalli school has classes from 1 to 8, beyond which students have to travel 33 km to Basaguda or Pamed, 23 km away.

As Veko talks, 14-year-old Mantu Tamo looks on in admiration. Tamo, whose uncle is a surrendered Maoist, now has an ambition: he wants to be a teacher, just like Veko. "They teach well," he says.

'There is so much to do'

Geeta Esam, 25, remembers growing up scared of the knock on the family door — the

Maoists would turn up, and they had no option but to give them rice, salt and chillies. Geeta hated it that she had to do this for her father's assaults. "In 2006, during the Salwa Judum days, they beat up my father for hours. I still do not know why," says the 25-year-old who works as a cook in the village school.

Geeta says she never went to school — there was enough to do at home, and three younger siblings to take care of. While one of her brothers died in a road accident on his way home from college, another works as a farmer after completing his Class 12, while her sister works as a teacher in Pamed.

Life has always been tough in these parts, more so if you are a woman. "We had women dying in labour or on the way to hospital because there were no medical facilities nearby. There was no road either. We carried women on cots. Even to get rice, we had to travel to Awapalli, which used to be a day's journey," she says.

Last year, her mother opened a bank account and now gets Rs 1,000 from the government under the state's Mahatari Vandana Yojana for women. There's much more the government needs to do, she says. "We need a health facility, a school for higher studies and a self-help group for women so we can do poultry work, farming and other livelihood activities."

But what changed her life was her phone, a Redmi model that she bought for Rs 10,000 after the Maoists left. "They used to seize phones and ask villagers not to use them. Now, I use it freely. I call my mother at home while I am at work," she says. "I like watching Telugu movies, news, cooking videos, sewing and stitching tutorials. I plan to learn some skills online and earn some money. There is so much to do," she says.



(Clockwise from below, left) Villagers gather for a chat in Kondapalli; the new ration shop is painted in the colours of the Tricolour; the road from Bijapur to Kondapalli



SATURDAY, AUGUST 15, 2026

Lot Said, Little Done

Shubhra Gupta

IT'S opening credits, *Batwara 1947* brings back a significant logo. The title appears in Urdu along with Hindi and English, like it used to through so many decades, a practice which vanished quietly in the last decade.

That erasure, gradual but evident, is an indicator of the state of the nation, which is busy being polarised over religion and language.

It also brings a reunion between Rajkumar Santoshi and Sunny Deol, a director-star duo who gave us *Ghayal*, *Damini*, *Ghatak*, some of the most enduring hits of the '90s. Capturing a specific time and place, those films had a strong streak of social realism which Santoshi had a knack

The film should have felt like a balm on fissured souls if only it had been contemporised without losing its essence. While its messaging is relevant, the storytelling is banal



for, and which Deol channelled with rage and purpose.

The last solid film from Santoshi was the 2004 *Khakee*; everything that came after has been a slide.

But with *Batwara 1947*, which began life as 'Lahore 1947', I was hoping for a little more, for a couple of reasons. It is based on the celebrated Asghar Wajahat 1989 play, *Jis Lahore Nai Vekhya Vo Jamya E Nai*, one of the most humane accounts of Partition, highlighting the futility of it all; and it has Shabana Azmi playing Mai, the Hindu woman left behind in her Lahore *haveli*, which is allotted to the Mirza family, who

cross over after their home was burnt down by rioters.

The central conflict plays out inside the home and outside. The Mirza family — Sikandar (Sunny Deol), his wife Hamida (Preity Zinta), his son (Karan Deol), and their young daughter — tries to face down a stubborn old woman, Durgawati (Shabana Azmi), who refuses to leave. She is waiting for her son and his family, and no one in the *mohalla* has the courage to tell her that they will never return, having perished in the riots. The tension builds, pumped up by a lumpen fellow (Abhimanyu Singh), who goes about making dire

BATWARA 1947

★★★

DIRECTOR:

Rajkumar Santoshi

CAST:

Sunny Deol, Preity Zinta, Ali Fazal, Shabana Azmi, Abhimanyu Singh, Karan Deol

threats against those *kaafirs* who do *puja*, and celebrate Diwali.

Santoshi's film, in contentious making for a few years, is finally out now, at a time when August 14 has been termed as Partition Horrors Remembrance Day. It should have felt like a balm on fissured souls if only it had been contemporised without losing its essence. But while its messaging is even more relevant in these times, the storytelling is dated and banal.

To find a light touch in a subject like this is tough, so when a hand pump is referenced, you smile. The bits featuring a poet-type (Ali Fazal) also tries for a lighter vein.

But the rest of it is the usual stagey dialoguing — here are your bad-and-good Hindus, and there your bad-and-good-Muslims. Sunny Deol still roars satisfactorily (no hand pumps are hurt, though), Preity Zinta does her part and Shabana Azmi is in great form, landing on the exact *sur* between well-judged theatricality and melodrama.

The message is loud and clear: No religion is evil, only humans are; *nafrat* can be conquered through *pyaar*, *siyasat se mazhab ko na milao*; and above all, *maanavta se bada koi dharam nahin*. But they come as a listicle, instead of making you feel.

Dino Rumble Makes Grumble

Shalini Langer

FOR THE foreseeable future, dinosaurs will not be going extinct in Hollywood. The challenge now is how to make this era meet that era.

Writer-director David Robert Mitchell (with the impressive *It Follows* behind him), has half-an-idea to pull this off. Since it involves a wormhole, and "ripples in space", it's just as much then he doesn't labour the point too much.

But then, labouring isn't the strength of *The End of Oak Street*.

The eponymous area is a neighbourhood full of large, happy, playing families, who all know each other and drop into each other's houses. Denise (Anne Hathaway) and Greg Platt (Ewan McGregor) are one of those happy couples on Oak Street, with a well-behaved daughter and son, Audrey (Maisy Stella) and Brian (Christian Convery).

There is tension, though, beneath the surface, evident clearly in a book Denise has been writing, about a wife and mother who is preparing to leave home. All that is swept aside when, one night, after a flash of light, gusts of wind, and rumbling of doors, windows and furniture, the Platts wake up to a changed world outside their window. Oak Street and beyond have been taken over by dinosaurs, big and small and ferocious, and run over by dense plantations dating back millions of years.

Most of us would think we are in a nightmare or — billionaires being what they are — guinea pigs in a new experiment involving Jurassic life. Audrey is the scientifically inclined one in the family (as the film underlines more than once), but



THE END OF OAK STREET

★★★

DIRECTOR:

David Robert Mitchell

CAST:

Anne Hathaway, Ewan McGregor, Maisy Stella, Christian Convery, P J Byrne

it is Denise who comes up with an explanation that's astounding and, if we are being charitable, audacious.

So what happens when T-Rex discovers the American suburb? Again, don't hold your breath for any deep dive of a sociological kind. This is pure and simple dystopia, with the Platts and pterodactyls having a go at each other, repeatedly.

A more thoughtful film could explore how two species adjust to life outside their natural habitats. But not only are there no dinosaurs with even a streak of grey, on the human side, the neighbourhood doesn't have a single odd ball with an armoury of guns, or even a brave policeman being the hero. In fact, there is hardly a person of any consequence in Oak Street but for the Platts.

Hathaway and McGregor do the best they can with their flimsily written roles, as do actors playing their children.

Of course, the family that fights dinosaurs together, stays together. And if that involves watching two dinosaurs hump, you better have as co-witness a life partner, who can vouch for it.



AWARAPAN 2

★★★★

DIRECTOR:

Nitin Kakkar

CAST:

Emraan Hashmi, Disha Patani, Puran Gabbi, Aniruddh Rawal, Shabana Azmi, Suvinder Vicky, Vijayant Kohli, Atul Kumar

the design, while keeping crime thriller conventions in place, with slick production values, and a cracker ensemble: This collection of goons is headed by Zorawar (Puran Gabbi), his closest aides JD (Suvinder Vicky) and Mehmood (Vijayant Kohli), a formidable

rival in the shape of Nafisa (Shabana Azmi), an Interpol officer (Atul Kumar), as well as Zorawar's sister Zara (Disha Patani) and brother Sikandar (Aniruddh Rawal) who has special needs.

The mix of the comparatively fresh and experienced faces gives this Bangkok-set caper an initial kick which takes us smoothly through the first half, which uses the city well, giving us a real sense of it. It also gives us an interesting new antagonist: Gabbi pitches in his version of the hopped-up, ultra-vicious baddie, who kills in the

•STREAMING WATCHLIST



Bharat Bhhagya Viddhaata

HINDI ZEE 5

SET AGAINST the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks, *Bharat Bhhagya Viddhaata* the dark chapter in India's history to spot-

light a group of unsung heroes whose courage and selflessness saved countless lives. The film follows the extraordinary actions of nurses and other hospital staff who became the first line of defence for the patients in their care. The film is headlined by Kangana Ranaut.



Don't Say Good Luck

NETFLIX

SOPHIE BIRENBAUM is finally getting her moment when she lands the lead role in her high school musical. But the excitement takes a back seat when her family life suddenly becomes far more dramatic than anything on stage. As Sophie tries to navigate the pressures of school, friendships and teenage life, she must also deal with the unexpected chaos at home. Sunny Sandler stars as Sophie, alongside Melanie Lynskey as Elizabeth.



Aakhri Sawal

LIONSGATE PLAY

PROFESSOR GOPAL Nadkarni (Sanjay Dutt), a respected academic with deeply held beliefs, finds his worldview challenged when a disagreement with his student Vicky (Namashi

Chakraborty) escalates into a larger ideological and moral conflict. As the debate forces buried truths and uncomfortable questions to the surface, Nadkarni is compelled to confront the historical legacy that has shaped his convictions.



The Traitors S2

PRIME VIDEO

THE SHOW returns with 21 celebrity players entering a high-stakes game of trust, deception and betrayal, where alliances can shift in an

instant and no one is quite what they seem. Hosted by Karan Johar, the season pits players against one another as they navigate secret strategies, psychological games and shifting loyalties. New episodes stream every Thursday.

Cocktail 2

NETFLIX

TEN YEARS into their relationship, Diya and Kunal seem to have settled into a comfortable life together. Their world is turned upside down when Ally, an old friend, unexpectedly reappears. As buried emotions resurface and loyalties are tested, what starts as a carefully laid plan between two women quickly snowballs into a series of wildly unpredictable events. Directed by Homi Adajania, *Cocktail 2* is the spiritual successor to the 2012 hit of the same name.

ALAKA SAHANI



A Blast with Basic

Shubhra Gupta

REACHER FANS, rejoice. I'm delighted to report that Season 4 of the one and only Jack No Middle Name Reacher, which has him up against a formidable pair of enemies, is a humdinger.

Based on *Gone Tomorrow*, Lee Child's 13th novel featuring Reacher, it begins in a Philadelphia subway in which a woman kills herself. It catapults our hero, busy minding his business till someone makes it their business, into a breakneck adventure involving an assortment of characters, including bent cops, incompetent CIA agents, evasive US presidential candidates, and sundry others, all looking desperately for a missing pen-drive.

What's so important on that drive that it needs to be found at all costs? How is it connected to congressman John Samson (Marc Blucas) and his fiercely protective wife (Kathleen Robertson)? What is it that two women from Indonesia, the attractive Lila Hoth (Agnez Mo) and her mother, Amisha (Anggun) are searching for? Why are people being killed in the most ghastly manner, with dismembered corpses strewn all over the place?

By this season, Ritchson has colonised Reacher so completely that we can't imagine anyone else as the ex-US military cop, permanent drifter, used to being the biggest guy in the room, armed with an unshakable sense of fair play, and a sense of humour so literal that when he does crack a slightly subtle joke, he seems overcome by his own smartness.

But wisely, he is not left too long to his own devices. Ritchson is absolutely unbeatable when it comes to devising imaginative and violent ways of killing the bad guys who come after him, or the ones he feels he is responsible for. But in between all those choreographed fights which keep the adrenaline rushing, you need for the show to breathe, and on that count, Season 4 has truly found the right beats.

That comes with the appearance of Christopher Rodriguez Marquette as Philly cop Jacob Merrick, stunned by the death of his beloved sister. And he's not alone. In these 8 episodes, each weighing in at a solid 45-55 minutes, there are others who make you invested in what happens to them. There's Tamara Green (Sydelle Noel), the denoted detective counting down to retirement, finding her mojo. Along comes

freelance journalist Russell Plum (Kevin Weisman), introduced as a flaky conspiracy theorist who feels like he's been thrust into the narrative strictly for laughs, turning into a character we begin taking seriously.

This unlikely trio joins Reacher in racing around Philly and DC, while being chased by varying sets of gun toting hoods. It's when the knives come out that things get serious: For those who remember the villains from the book (I'm giving out no spoilers), the description of how they torture and kill their victims is bone chilling. Their encounters with Reacher are high stakes stuff, vicious enough that for once, you begin feeling worried for him, even when you know that he is invincible: He will always be the last man standing.

Of course, in all this attempted fast-and-furiousness, there are some slack moments. When the fights — taking place in a dizzying variety of places, including a library, a dock, a bar (one of Reacher's favourite places for a brawl), stairwells, hotel rooms, high terraces — seem to go on for just a little too long. When a specific scene is looped back

upon itself — Green comes looking for a ride back to the same hapless garage owner, and by the second time around, it loses edge. Sometimes, the screen-play forgets that it has too many villains tumbling about, and things can get a bit confused. Plus, and this is something all *Reacher* seasons suffer from: Sometimes, the acting and the writing and the framing is just too basic for words.

But, and this is the thing. That basic-ness is actually so *Reacher*. It fits right in. One of my favourite things is to watch Reacher take down self-important suits. One snappily dressed officer says, 'Do you think we are stupid?' Reacher responds with just one word: 'Yes', with Ritchson deadpanning it with the slightest of smirks. You can't help smile back. And the lax bits are papered over by and an even faster spurt, and we're off and away again.

So yeah, even as the basic bits can sometimes grate, any kind of sophistication or tarding up stuff will feel out of character: When your guy travels light, carrying only a passport, a credit card, and a toothbrush, he doesn't need much, except to crack wise ones once in a while, and crack as many skulls as he can, as fast as he can.

And on that score, *Reacher* rules. No one does it like him. I binge-watched the whole thing, and had a blast, and I can't wait for the fifth season. Bring it.

Slacky End Mars Slick Start

Shubhra Gupta

SHIVAM PANDIT, the straggly-haired shooter with a golden heart, is back. And it would seem, miraculously, that nothing much has changed between the 2007 *Awarapan* and this sequel, which doesn't stray far from the thematic palette of the original, keeping the lead actor intact. It's yesterday once more.

Emraan Hashmi is clearly older. But his hair is as straggly. He is as much a wounded hero, a role Hashmi owns, as he was back in the day. And he is as lethal, which is a good thing because he is up against a new set of mobsters, gun-toting henchmen, helpless young women, as he goes about looking for a little girl in the clutches of a gang of human traffickers.

It doesn't matter if you haven't seen the original. Like a faithful sequel, there are enough flashbacks to tell us how Shivam betrayed his mob boss, even as the woman he loved died to keep him safe. Kakkar elevates

DRAFT SHANTI ACT RULES RELEASED

Foreign nuclear technology must have its design certified in country-of-origin

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 14

FOREIGN NUCLEAR technology sourced for a nuclear power plant or reactor must have its design certified or approved by the regulatory body in its country of origin and must already be operational there or in another foreign country, according to the draft rules of the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) Act, released by the Department of Atomic Energy on Friday.

“The technology intended to be imported or acquired domestically does not adversely affect the interest of India, does not constitute an unreasonable risk to public health and safety and is in conformity with the national policies framed under the Act,” the rules read.

The rules define “the country of origin” as those countries which are self-reliant in nuclear reactor design and supply chain ecosystem whose regulatory approvals are trusted

globally. As per the rules, technology providers shall ensure availability of design support and all necessary permissions and supporting documents from original technology developer unless there has been a complete transfer of technology.

“Provided also that the person sourcing the technology shall ensure that all related Intellectual Property Rights vests with the technology developer,” it added.

The draft rules provide for a single composite licence for building, owning, operating and decommissioning a nuclear power plant or reactor.

The rules also recognise captive nuclear power, including its use by energy intensive industries such as aluminium and cement, as well as data centres, semiconductor manufacturing and AI applications.

A key provision is the proposed “in-principle approval”, which the licensing authority may grant after admitting an application where the applicant has not yet selected a site or re-



Technology providers shall ensure availability of design support and all necessary permissions and supporting documents from original technology developer, rules say. REUTERS

actor technology. The draft defines it as a “statement of support to proceed towards applying for formal licence”, subject to specified conditions. “Upon receipt of a valid ‘in-principle approval’, the applicant may proceed with negotiation with reactor technology vendors and for acquiring the land and other necessary infrastructure,” the draft rules state.

The approval, however, would not amount to a final licence. The draft also provides that an in-principle approval can be revoked if there is a supervening public interest or if material facts emerge indicating that the applicant is owned, controlled or dominated by entities considered inimical to defence and national security or public health and safety. It can

also be revoked if obtained through misrepresentation or suppression of material facts.

On nuclear liability, operators would be required to maintain insurance or financial security for nuclear damage, with the financial security remaining in place until spent fuel is removed from the relevant storage pool. The draft also provides for a Nuclear Liability Fund, to be funded through a levy on operators. For specified government-owned installations, the Central Government would assume liability under the conditions set out in the rules. The draft rules lay out the regulatory framework for a wider nuclear power ecosystem, including private participation, captive nuclear generation, foreign reactor technology, licensing, safety oversight and nuclear liability.

The Department of Atomic Energy has invited comments and suggestions on the draft rules, with September 4, 2026 as the last date for submission.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

\$52-bn in, FCNR(B) window closes early

• MOBILISING CAPITAL

- The RBI had introduced the special US dollar-rupee forex swap facility on June 8, allowing banks to mobilise fresh three-to-five-year FCNR(B) deposits and swap these deposits with central bank at concessional rate
- The latest data reported by authorised dealer banks show that the three components of the special forex facility have attracted a total of **\$56.846 billion** till August 13



Total foreign currency inflows under the RBI's special forex swap facility	Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) or FCNR(B): \$52.3 billion	Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings: \$2.805 billion	External Commercial Borrowings: \$1.741 billion
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George Mathew
Mumbai, August 14

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) on Friday said it has decided to close its special forex swap facility for fresh Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) — FCNR(B) — deposits prematurely on August 31, following an “encouraging response” that has brought in \$52.3 billion through this route.

The swaps against FCNR(B) deposits mobilised under the facility, however, can be undertaken with the RBI till September 11, the central bank said.

The schemes for External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs) will continue to remain open until December 31, 2026.

The RBI had introduced the special US dollar-rupee forex swap facility on June 8, allowing banks to mobilise fresh three-to-five-year FCNR(B) deposits and swap these deposits with the central bank at a concessional rate.

The facility effectively covered the entire hedging cost for banks.

The latest data reported by authorised dealer banks show that the three components of the special forex facility have attracted a total of \$56.846 billion

in foreign currency inflows till August 13. FCNR(B) deposits accounted for the overwhelming majority at \$52.3 billion, followed by OFCBs at \$2.805 billion and ECBs at \$1.741 billion.

The scale of FCNR(B) mobilisation is significantly higher than the amount raised in the initial weeks of the scheme. At that stage, bankers expected the inflows to accelerate in August and September.

Non-resident Indians and persons of Indian origin can open FCNR(B) deposits. It's fully repatriable and exempt from tax in India.

The RBI's special facility was part of a broader package announced in June to encourage foreign capital inflows, strengthen the rupee and improve foreign exchange reserves. The central bank had also eased norms for state-owned enterprises to borrow overseas and provided a concessional swap facility to encourage ECBs by public sector firms.

“Unlike 2013, the rupee has not appreciated significantly due to global uncertainties, geopolitical risks, and weaker capital flow dynamics. Additionally, RBI's large forward forex obligations may constrain any visible rise in reserves,” CareEdge Ratings said

in a report. Overall, the scheme should be viewed primarily as a liquidity and stability measure rather than a driver of sharp currency appreciation or reserve accumulation, it said.

At the core of the FCNR(B) facility was the RBI's decision to absorb the hedging cost for banks. By allowing banks to swap the foreign currency raised through eligible deposits with the RBI at concessional terms, the central bank made FCNR(B) deposits a more attractive source of overseas funding. The move was important because the cost of hedging foreign currency deposits had made the mobilisation of such funds less attractive for Indian banks.

The central banks's intervention effectively lowered that cost and enabled banks to offer more competitive rates to non-resident depositors.

The RBI had also temporarily withdrawn the interest rate ceiling on fresh FCNR(B) deposits of three-to-five-year tenors until September 30.

Banks subsequently began offering higher rates to attract overseas funds.

Several banks were offering rates of around 7% on FCNR(B) deposits to attract capital.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• BRIEFLY

SEBI floats easier KYC norms for NRIs, OCIs and foreign investors

Mumbai: The SEBI on Friday proposed a set of relaxations in KYC norms for individual Persons Resident Outside India (PROI), including Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs) and foreign nationals. The proposals, aimed at making it easier for overseas individuals to enter India's securities market, seek to simplify onboarding through digital processes and reduce the need for physical documentation. ENS

India's forex reserves climb past \$700 billion

Mumbai: India's foreign exchange reserves rose to a four-month high of \$707 billion as of August 7, bolstered by robust inflows under policy measures to strengthen balance of payments. The reserves jumped \$14.1 billion week-on-week, the largest rise since January, the RBI said on Friday. The rise was led by a \$9.9 billion weekly gain in the central bank's foreign currency assets. Measures to draw dollar inflows announced in June include discounted hedging facilities for overseas borrowings by govt firms and banks alongside tax cuts on foreign investments in government bonds and a free-of-cost hedging facility for banks to raise overseas FX deposits. REUTERS

Ashok Leyland Q1 net profit rises 1.5% at Rs 667 cr

New Delhi: Commercial vehicle maker Ashok Leyland Ltd on Friday reported a 1.5% increase in consolidated net profit at Rs 667.77 crore for the first quarter ended June 30, 2026. The company had posted a consolidated net profit of Rs 657.72 crore in the corresponding period of the previous fiscal, Ashok Leyland Ltd said in a regulatory filing. Consolidated revenue from operations stood at Rs 13,069.59 crore in the quarter under review as against Rs 11,708.54 crore in the year-ago period, it added. PTI

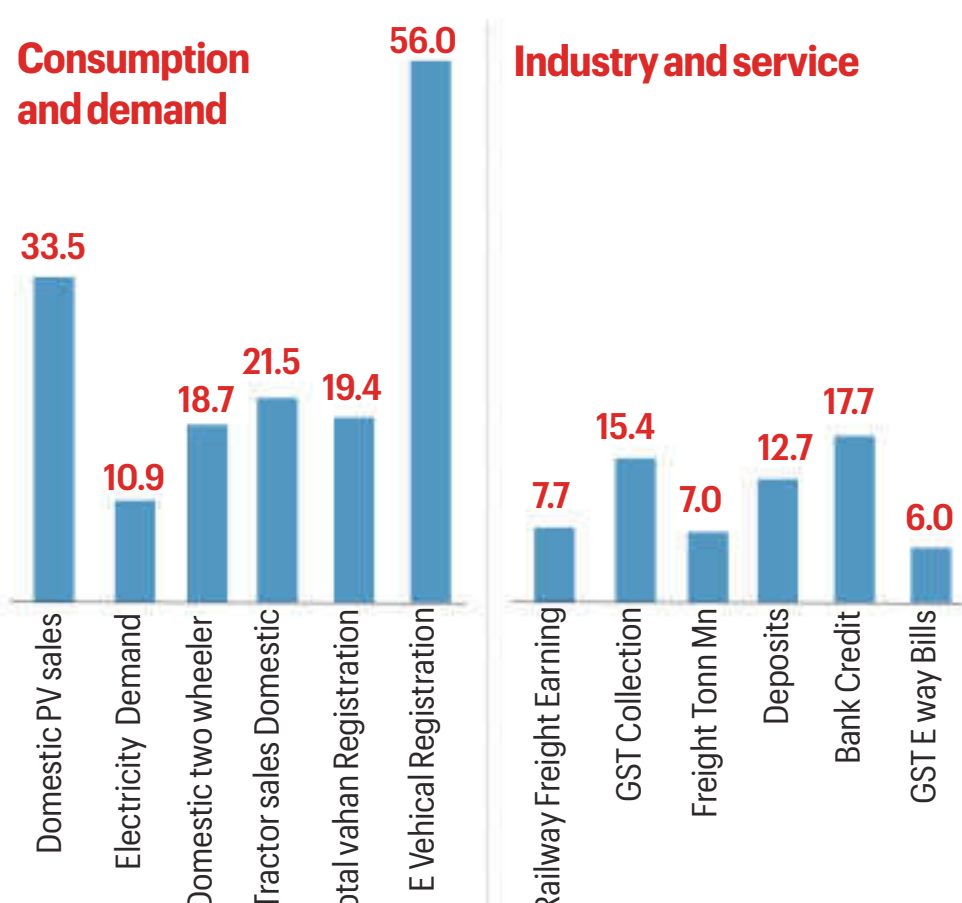
NMDC Q1 net profit grows to Rs 2,005.71 cr

New Delhi: State-owned NMDC on Friday posted a 2% rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 2,005.71 crore in the June quarter, supported by a growth in revenues from iron ore sales. The company had clocked a net profit of Rs 1,967.46 crore in the same quarter a year ago, according to a regulatory filing. During April-June, the company increased its total income to Rs 7,142.54 crore, up 1.5% from Rs 7,038.97 crore in the first quarter of the preceding 2025-26 fiscal. NMDC said it earned revenue of Rs 6,802.12 crore from iron ore sales, around 10% higher. PTI

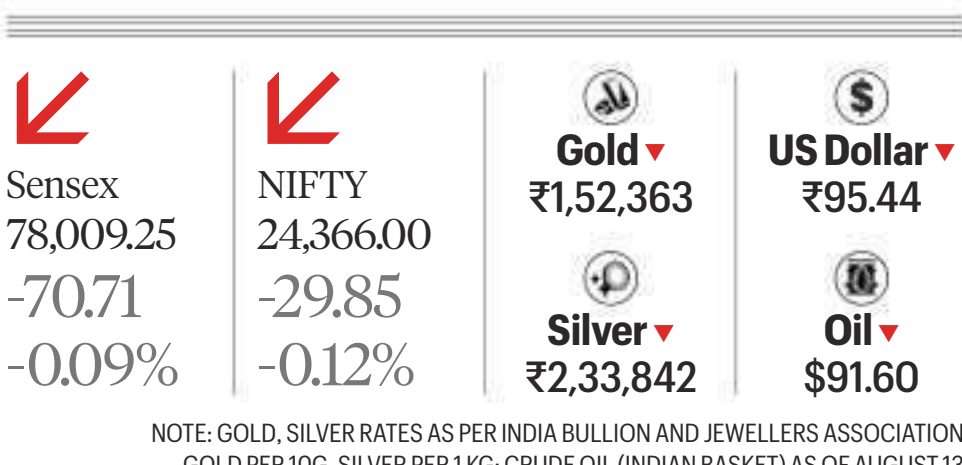
• Robust growth

SBI Research, in its recent report, said that the Indian economy is expected to have logged an 8% growth in the first quarter of the financial year 2027 (Q1FY27). It said that most leading indicators pointed towards this robust expansion. And it also said that the early trends seen in July also indicate a similar trend in the second quarter (Q2FY27).

Leading indicators July 2026 (%YoY)



• MARKETS



Heavy correction in share prices at the start of 2026 has provided investors an opportunity to rack up cheap IT stocks

IT stocks partly recover H1 losses, but longer-term outlook remains clouded

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, August 14

THE INDIAN IT services sector broadly maintained a cautious near-term outlook while announcing April-June quarter earnings, citing headwinds such as AI-related revenue deflation, subdued spending by US-based clients, and uncertain earnings visibility.

While these factors had weighed on IT stocks in the first half of the year, most have since recovered a substantial portion of their losses after hitting their 2026 lows around the start of July. The benchmark Nifty IT index, which was down 32% for the year on July 1, has since recovered and is now down around 17%.

Bellwether TCS is now down 26.5% in 2026, compared with 38% at the start of July.

Some have even risen into positive territory. Tech Mahindra, which was down around

16% at its lowest for the year and was the best-performing large-cap IT stock, is now up 2% in 2026. Coforge, which had slumped 35% at its lowest, is now up nearly 9% for the year.

Thus, near-term concerns remain for the industry, but the stocks have rallied. So what has then changed for the sector?

Cheap valuations provide opportunity

The heavy correction in share prices at the start of the year has provided investors an opportunity to rack up cheap IT stocks as a valuation bet, even as their trajectory remains uncertain. The Nifty IT currently trades at a valuation of around 19-20 times its one-year forward earnings (FY27 in this case), compared to the 5-year average of around 25-27 times.

This has allowed institutions such as mutual funds to top up IT stocks as earnings remain more resilient than

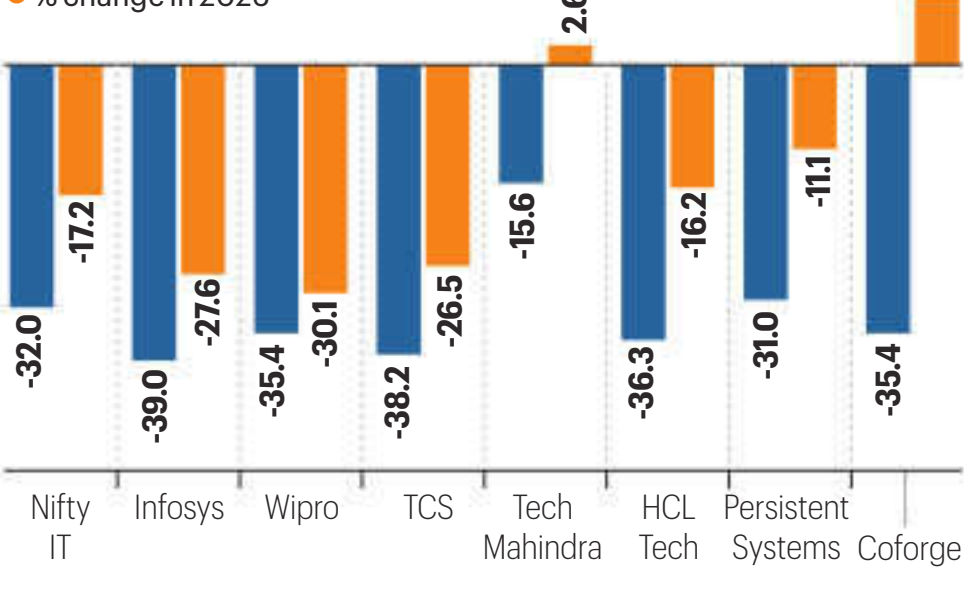
most had expected. “The market has already discounted the news (of uncertain outlook projected by companies in Q1). There is no major negative news in sight currently, like a new model from Anthropic, which will incrementally impact IT services,” said Sumit Pokharna, an analyst tracking the sector at Kotak Securities.

“Most mutual fund guys still have a decent exposure in the IT sector. They realised that this is a good time to average (by accumulating more IT stocks), and they came on news channels and highlighted that they are looking to add more positions in IT because they believe most of the concerns are already priced in,” he added.

Major fund houses such as Motilal Oswal, ICICI Prudential, and SBI MF have recently turned more positive towards the IT services sector due to a strong risk-reward profile and a hedge against the exorbitant

• Turning the corner

- % change at lowest in 2026
- % change in 2026



AI bets seen globally.

While data for the last month will only be available once the July-September quarter ends, the April-June quarter has seen domestic institutions add to their exposure across many IT companies.

Better-than-expected Q1 earnings

While revenue growth was subdued across the sector, profits and margins remained robust for most players during the quarter.

“IT firms continue to win large deals across a wide range of themes such as vendor consolidation, digital transformation, legacy modernisation, new outsourcing to save costs, and GCC set-up.

“Deal wins were reasonable for TCS, Infosys and HCLT, muted for Wipro and healthy for TechM,” a report by Kotak Institutional Equities from last week noted.

However, while the performance was positive, concerns regarding AI deflation, a subdued demand environment, high competition, and margin pressure remain in the upcoming quarters. In fact, the AI impact of deflation has already started to show in Q1.

Viable anti-AI bet

The Indian IT sector also provides a strong anti-AI bet for investors and has benefited from foreign institutional investors (FIIs) returning to the Indian market in July, according to experts.

FIIs bought Indian equities worth \$2.1 billion in July, turning buyers after four straight months of selling as the geopolitical uncertainty eased, crude oil prices subsided, and the AI-heavy South Korean stock market crashed.

This buying has continued in August. “We have possibly seen FIIs also buy IT stocks as a strong bet against AI as they returned to India.

It's early to say if it's a definitive change in trend or a short-term bet, with AI productivity still at a very nascent stage. We will have to wait and watch if more investors bet against AI, or if AI will surge again,” a fund manager track-

ing the sector at a domestic AMC said.

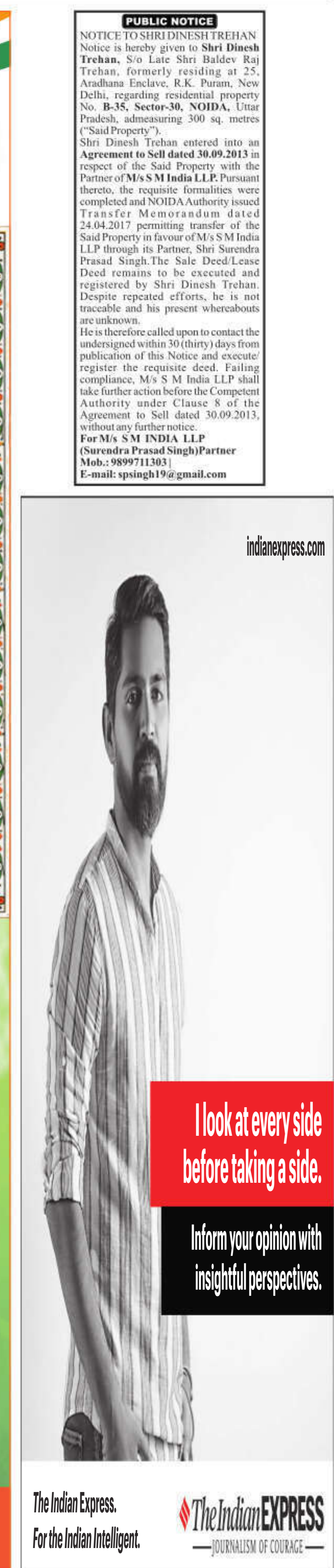
The crash of the AI-heavy South Korean market, which had more than doubled at its highest in 2026, coincided with the rise of Indian IT stocks.

The Kospi index started crashing in late June and is currently down around 23% from its peak.

Data from the National Securities Depository Ltd showed that FIIs bought IT services shares worth \$352 million in July, compared to the \$788 million of IT shares they had dumped in the previous month.

In fact, these investors turned positive on Indian IT stocks after five months of selling, during which they had dumped IT shares worth \$3.5 billion. Other global IT services companies have also seen a similar trend.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM





Udyog Mitra

DEPARTMENT OF INDUSTRIES

Tender Notice No:560/UMDate: 13/08/2026

Online e-tender are invited by the CEO, Udyog Mitra, Department of Industries, Govt. of Bihar, Patna for empanelment of travel agencies for providing air ticketing, rail ticketing ground transport and hotel accommodation services across India and abroad.

Sl. No.	Tender Schedule/Program	
1	Name of the customer and address from whose website the RFP documents can be obtained	Chief Executive Officer , Udyog Mitra, Department of Industries, 1 st floor, Indira Bhawan, RCS Path, Patna, Bihar-800001, Telephone No:0612-2547695 Email Id:udyogmitrabihar@yahoo.co.in
2	Bid submission start date	14.08.2026, 06:00 PM
3	Last date & time for submission of Written queries for clarification	20.08.2026 up to 05:00 PM
4	Date, Time & venue of Pre-bid conference	21.08.2026, 3:00 PM, Conference Hall, Ground Floor, Indira Bhawan, Patna, Bihar - 800001
5	Bid submission end date	06.09.2026 up to 5:00 PM
6	Technical Bid Opening Date	07.09.2026, at 3:00 PM, Conference Hall, Ground Floor, Indira Bhawan, Patna, Bihar - 800001
7	Financial Bid Opening Date	To be Communicated Later
8	Validity of Bids	180 days
9	Tender Fees	INR 5,000/- Five Thousand Only
10	Tender Processing fee	As Per Eproc2
11	EMD	INR 5,00,000/- (Online mode only)

Note:

- CEO, Udyog Mitra, Department of Industries, Patna, Bihar reserves the right to reject or cancel the tender or any part thereof without assigning any reasons.
- The tender document can be obtained from the website of Department of Industries, Government of Bihar
- For any queries regarding tender please contact: 0612-2547695 and email:udyogmitrabihar@yahoo.com or ramp.bihar@bihar.gov.in

Toll Free Number: 1800 572 6571
 Email Id: eproc2support@bihar.gov.in

During 08:00 AM to 07:00 PM (All days in week except state holidays)

eProc 2.0 Help Desk Address:
 RJ Complex, 2nd Floor, Opposite Vidyapeeth Institute,
 Khajpura, Ashiana Road, P.S. - Shastri Nagar,
 Patna 800 014, Bihar

PR. No. 0010048 (Industry) 2026-27

Chief Executive Officer
Udyog Mitra, Department of Industries

This information is available on website www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar also

**यौन जनित रोग छुपाओ नहीं ईलाज कराओ,
 खद के साथ अपने जीवन साथी को भी सरक्षित करै।**

Notice No. 04/2020-27 Bid for Construction of Building/Road work Sanctioned are invited from interested bidders upto 6:00 PM dt. 24.08.2026 (Monday). Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the eProcurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.raj.nic.in) of the state and DIPR department website. The approximate value of the eProcurement is Rs. 207.50 Lakhs. UBN Code No.: PWD2627WSOB09259, PWD2627WSOB09266 DIPR/C/14460/2026		Sd/- Executive Engineer PWD Division Jalore
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, PWD CIRCLE, PRATAPGARH Email: sepratap@gmail.com		
No.- 377	<u>Notice Inviting Bid No. 02/2026-27</u> NIB Code PWD2627A2065	Date- 7-08-2026
Bids for 15 works of Road are invited from interested bidders upto 6:00 PM of 01.09.2026, other particulars of the bids may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in) of the Rajasthan state; and departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 2560.50 lakhs. UBN No.- PWD2627WSOB09136, PWD2627WSOB09139, PWD2627WSOB09141, PWD2627WSOB09145, PWD2627WSOB09147, PWD2627WSOB09150, PWD2627WSOB09162, PWD2627WSOB09165, PWD2627WSOB09168, PWD2627WSOB09171, PWD2627WSOB09173, PWD2627WSOB09194, PWD2627WSOB09197, PWD2627WSOB09200, PWD2627WSOB09226		
DIPR/C/14433/2026		Sd/- Superintending Engineer PWD Circle, Pratapgarh



माटी का मान
मातृभूमि की शान
देशभक्ति का रंग चढ़ा
तिरंगा ही अभिमान



Government of Haryana



Heartiest Greetings
to all on the occasion of
Independence Day

August 15, 2026

“Wishing everyone a very happy Independence Day.
May this day inspire us to keep working even harder
to realise the dreams of our freedom fighters and
build a Viksit Bharat. Jai Hind!”

– **Narendra Modi**





JODHPUR VIDYUT VITARAN NIGAM LIMITED
(MATERIAL MANAGEMENT & CONTRACT WING)
NEW POWER HOUSE, INDUSTRIAL AREA, JODHPUR-342003, PHONE: 0291-2742223, FAX: 0291-2746539

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
E-Procurement Tenders are invited for purchase of Automatic CT/PT Test Set up having Digital Control Panel with Complete System (with AMC for 5 years)
TN-2173 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00390), Details regarding Quantity, Tender cost, Earnest Money, Schedule date of tender opening for aforesaid tenders are available on our website at energy.rajasthan.gov.in/jdvvn1 and also at <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>
SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (MM&C)
For Electricity Complaints Toll free No. 1800 180 6045



NORTHERN RAILWAY
Sr. DMM/NS/LP/93265531A/2026 Date:-14/08/2026

Invitation of Tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement systems)
Sr.DMM, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items :-

Sr.No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
1.	93265531A	Supply of 24 Fiber armoured Optic Fiber cable asper RD50 SPEC.NO. RD50/ SPN/TC/110/2020 and with latest amendment/revision till the date of opening of tender (Inspection by RDSO).	97 KM.	09/09/2026

Note : 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained. 2815/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE



JODHPUR VIDYUT VITARAN NIGAM LIMITED
(MATERIAL MANAGEMENT & CONTRACT WING)
NEW POWER HOUSE, INDUSTRIAL AREA, JODHPUR-342003, PHONE: 0291-2742223, FAX: 0291-2746539

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
E-Procurement Tenders are invited for purchase of Three Phase LT AB Cable of Size 3Cx25+25 Sq. MM under **TN-2194 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00409)**, 11 KV Porcelain Type Pin Insulator under **TN-2195 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00411)**, 11 KV Stay Insulator under **TN-2196 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00410)**, ACSR Rabbit Conductor under **TN-2197 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00412)** & ACSR Weasel Conductor **TN-2198 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00413)**.
Details regarding Quantity, Tender cost, Earnest Money, Schedule date of tender opening for aforesaid tenders are available on our website at energy.rajasthan.gov.in/jdvvn1 and also at <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>
SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (MM&C)
For Electricity Complaints Toll free No. 1800 180 6045



UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Govt. of Uttarakhand Undertaking)
Corporate Identity No. UA40109UP2001SGC0258672358
Victoria Cross Vijeta Gabar Singh Urja Bhawan, Kanewal Road, Dehradun-248001
Telephone:-0135-2763672-76, Website: www.uttarakhandpc.org

CORRIGENDUM TO E-TENDER NOTICE
This office e-tender specification no. CCP-11/7/2026-2027 invited previously for supply of 500 Nos. LT Puffer Resistant Metering Cubicle is hereby extended due to unavoidable reasons. The e-tender can be purchased and submitted upto 17:00 hrs. of 31.08.2026. Part-I of the e-tender shall be opened on 01.09.2026 at 15:30 hrs.
Other terms and conditions will remain same as per original tender notice. For further details, please visit our website www.uttarakhandpc.org.
Superintending Engineer
Corporate (Contract & Procurement-II)
No.-: 618/EE(CM)/UPCL/A-2 Date:- 14.08.2026
"SAVE ELECTRICITY IN THE INTEREST OF THE NATION" Use LED Bulb to Save Electricity (Toll Free No. 1912) "Pay Electricity bill online 24x7 from www.upcl.org." (For information on Electricity theft, informer may report to Toll Free No. 18001804185 0405/Fax No. 0135-2760911)



उद्यपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, राजस्थान
No.-: F-2(01)Acct/Contract/2026-27/148 - 150 Date:- 10/08/2026

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या : 38/2026-27
उद्यपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, उद्यपुर द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्यें मय डिफेक्ट लाईबिलिटी अवधि के लिये जो कि निविदा प्रपत्र में अंकित है के लिये उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत संवेदको से निविदा प्रपत्र में ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :-

निविदा कार्य की कुल लागत	रुपये 604.33 लाख (62 कार्य)
ऑनलाईन निविदा प्रपत्र डाउनलोड / अपलोड करने की अवधि	12.08.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 08.09.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
Online EMD, Tender Fee & Processing Fee जमा कराने की तिथि	12.08.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 08.09.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
ऑनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तिथि	09.09.2026 को प्रातः 11.00 बजे (तकनीकी विंग)

विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाईट urban.rajasthan.gov.in/uitdaipur, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in व www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।
UBN No. :- ITU2627WSO800231, ITU2627WSO800232
अभिधायी अधिकृतता - पवन उद्यपुर विकास प्राधिकरण
तज्ञ.संख/सी/26/9711



NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE
(Through e-tendering)

Name of work with its location	Comprehensive Annual maintenance Contract of IPS of HBL make for three years over Delhi Division
App. Cost of the work (₹)	Rs. 2,99,49,652.8/-
Bid Security (₹)	Rs. 5,99,000.00/-
Address of the office	Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer-C, Northern Railway, 3 rd Floor, Annexe-1, DRM Office, New Delhi-110055.
Date & Time for uploading the tender/closing of the tender	Tender uploading 14.08.2026 / closing date & time- 07.09.2026 up to 15.00 hrs.
Website particular & notice board/location where complete details of the tender can be seen etc.	See the Northern Railway website www.ireps.gov.in & Notice board at S&T branch, 3 rd Floor, DRM office, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055.
Tender No. 558-Sig-16-M-T-AMC-094 Dated: 14.08.2026	2816/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE



CHHATRAPATI SAMBHAJINAGAR MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
Garden & Tree Authority Section

Tel. No.(0240) 2333536-40	Address: Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj Municipal Corporation, Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj Head Office: Town Hall, Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj 431001 (Maharashtra)
Fax/No. 0240-2331213	E-Mail ID: aidsmt.amc@gmail.com

No.CSMC/Garden Section/358/2026 Date: 13/08/2026

Sr. No.	Work Name	Final Date of Tender Submission
1	Construction Of Dressed Stone Road Divider And Ornamental Tree Plantation From Mahatma Phule Statue To Savarkar Chowk, Savarkar Chowk To Shekari Statue, Savarkar Chowk To Satish Petrol Pump, Phule Statue To Mill Corner At Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj. (B-1 Tender) Tender Amount Rs. 4,77,86,635.00	Date: 20/08/2026 Time: 5:00 pm

Note: Tender Notice is published on website www.mahatenders.gov.in

Sd/-
(V.R.Bhoye)
Executive Engineer, Garden
Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj Municipal Corporation



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, JAYAPUR (R&B) CIRCLE, JAYAPUR
INVITATIONS FOR BIDS (IFB)
e-mail ID - supenger_rbjyp@yahoo.co.in

Bid Identification No. C.C.E.J.C (R&B) - 10/2026-27
No. 4388 Date. 12.08.2026

No.	4388	Date.	12.08.2026
1.	Nature of the work	:	STMC WORKS
2.	Total No. of Works	:	14 (Fourteen) Nos.
3.	Tender cost	:	Rs. 103.30 Lakhs. to 257.42 Lakhs.
4.	Period of completion	:	12 (Twelve) Calendar Months each.
5.	Cost of Bid Document	:	Rs. 10,000/-
6.	Bid Security (EMD)	:	Rs. 1,03,300/- to Rs.2,57,420/-, as per column no. 06 of IFB.
7.	Class of Contractor	:	"B" & "A" Class as per CI no. 05 of TCN & according to Financial Eligibility.
8.	Date & time of availability of bid Document in the portal	:	from 12:00 hours of 25.08.2026 to 17:00 hours of 08.09.2026
9.	Last date for receipt of bids in the Portal:	:	17:00 hours of 08.09.2026
10.	Opening date of Bid:	:	10:00 hours of 09.09.2026
11.	Name and Address of the Officer Inviting Bid:	:	Chief Construction Engineer, Jayapur (R&B) Circle, Jayapur

Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal <https://tendersodisha.gov.in> in Any addendum / corrigendum / cancellation of tender can also be seen in the said website only.

Sd/-
Chief Construction Engineer
Jayapur (R&B) Circle, Jayapur
OIPR-34001/34108/1/26-27/0012



Haryana Medical Services Corporation Limited
(Registered under Companies Act, 2013)
DHL Square Plot No 09, 5th Floor, Sector 22, HSIIDC, IT Park, Panchkula, Haryana 134109
Website. Hmscl.org.in

Inviting Request for Proposal (for) selection of Chartered Accountant or Cost Accountant (CMA) Firm for Internal Audit for FY 2026-2027 for Haryana Medical Corporation Ltd.
Haryana Medical Services Corporation Limited (HMSCL) intends to hire a Chartered Accountant / Cost Accountant (CMA) Firm for conducting the Internal Audit of the Corporation for the Financial Year 2026-2027. The detailed Request for Proposal (RFP) document containing the scope of work, eligibility criteria, terms and conditions and other relevant details can be downloaded from the official website of HMSCL, i.e. www.hmscl.org.in. The complete proposal, duly filled in all respects, shall be submitted to the undersigned on or before 07.09.2026 up to 11:00 AM. Proposals received after the stipulated date and time shall not be accepted.
Dated 17.08.2026
Managing Director
HMSCL



JAIPUR VIDYUT VITRAN NIGAM LIMITED
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (MM-I), MM Building, Old Power House Premises, Near Ram Mandir, Banipark, Jaipur-302006, Tel. 0141-2208098, E-Mail id: semm1@jvvn1.org

NOTICE INVITING BID
e-tenders are invited for purchase of 33 KV Cable Termination & Joining Kits for XLPE Cable (TN-5089) (UBN- VVN2627GLOB00337). All the details regarding tenders are available at web site <http://energy.rajasthan.gov.in/jvvn1> and www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in.
Raj.Samwad/C/26/9900 JPR-3214 (2026) SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (MM-I)
For Electricity Complaints Toll Free No. 1800 180 6507



कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता विद्युत वितरण मण्डल
उत्तराखण्ड पावर कारपोरेशन लि० गनीखेत
ई-निविदा निरस्तीकरण सूचना
इस कार्यालय द्वारा प्रकाशित ई-निविदा संख्या ई.डी.सी. (रा) -46, 47, 48, 49, 50, 51, 52 एवं 53/2026-27 को अपरिहार्य कारणों से निरस्त किया जाता है।
" राष्ट्र हित में बिजली बचाये "

दिनांक: 14/08/2026 हस्ता/-
पत्रांक: 5151/वि.वि/म०(रा) /ई-निविदा अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
Customer Toll Free No-1800 419 0405



ICAR-Vivekananda Parvatiya Krishi Anusandhan Sansthan,
Almora - 263601 (Uttarakhand)

WALK-IN-INTERVIEW
It is proposed to conduct Walk-in-interview on **02.09.2026** for filling up the temporary and time bound positions of **Senior Research Fellow, Junior Research Fellow, Young Professional - I & II, Field Assistant and Field Worker** under the projects at this Institute on contractual basis. For other details of eligibility, terms & conditions and emoluments etc., the interested candidates may contact:
Email ID - vpkasheadoffice@gmail.com
Mobile Number: 8351016208 (Radhika Arya)
Administrative Officer



BSES
BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi

TENDER NOTICE Date: 15.08.2026
Sealed tenders under two Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) is invited for following job from all bidders.

NIT No.	Brief Item Description	Estimated Cost	Cost of EMD	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/ FK/CR/SS/1384	Civil Works of Water proofing for Roof top solar installations on 13 nos. Grid in BRPL.	₹ 1.11 Crore	₹ 2.22 Lakhs	28.08.2026, 15:00 HRS	28.08.2026, 15:15 HRS

Cost of each Tender Document : ₹1,180/-
For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submission of tender documents etc. Please visit our website www.bsesdelhi.com Head (Contracts & Materials)
Regd. Off. :- BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No: U40109DL2001PLC111527 Telephone No. :- +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsesdelhi.com



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, KENDRAPARA-JAJPUR
AT CHANDIKHOL PO- SINGUDA, JAIPUR-754296, Tel No. 0671-2444488, Email-serv kpd@yahoo.com

Letter No.- 4717 Date: 13.8.26
2nd Corrigendum Notice
2nd Corrigendum to Bid Identification No. Tender Online RCK-15/26 invited by this office vide Letter No.- 4387, DL-18/07/2026.
The changes as detailed below are hereby made in the above N.I.T.:-
1 Clause no-06 of NIT modified below:-

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on-line for bidding	Last Date & Time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of tender	
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Kendrapara Jajpur	Tender RCK-15/26	Previously fixed on 10.08.2026 At 11.00 A.M To 21.08.2026 Up to 05.00 P.M	Previously Modified on 08.08.2026 At 02.00 P.M	Previously fixed on 21.08.2026 up to 02.00 P.M	Previously Modified on 28.08.2025 up to 02.00 P.M
		Previously fixed on 21.08.2026 up to 02.00 P.M	Previously Modified on 28.08.2025 up to 02.00 P.M	Previously fixed on 24.08.2026 At 11.00 A.M	Previously Modified on 29.08.2026 At 11.00 A.M

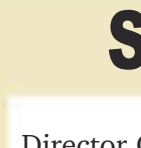
All other conditions of NIT remain unaltered.

Sd/-
Chief Construction Engineer,
Rural Works Circle, Kendrapara-Jajpur
OIPR-25001/25129/1/26-27/0017

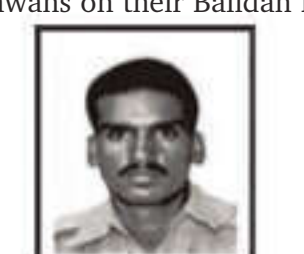
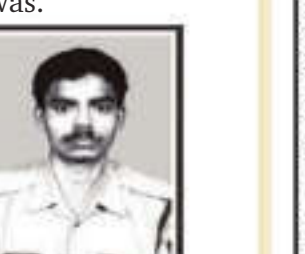


FORM NO. 14
[See Regulation 33(2)] By Regd. A/D, Dasti failing which by Publication.
OFFICE OF THE RECOVERY OFFICER - I/II DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL DELHI(DRT 2)
4th Floor, Jeevan Tara Building, Parliament Street, New Delhi-110001
DEMAND NOTICE
NOTICE UNDER SECTIONS 25 TO 28 OF THE RECOVERY OF DEBTS & BANKRUPTCY ACT, 1993 AND RULE 2 OF SECOND SCHEDULE TO THE INCOME TAX ACT, 1961.
RC/64/2026 22-07-2026
THE HONGKONG AND SHANGHAI BANKING CORPORATION
Versus
M/S M. S. INTERNATIONAL

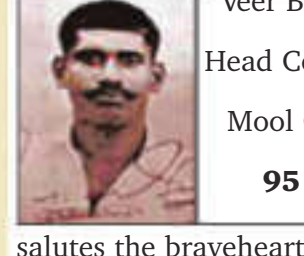
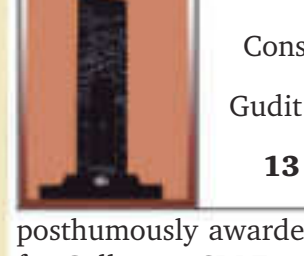
To
(CD 1) M/S M. S. INTERNATIONAL, SRIVASTAVA Akhilesh, Manisha Srivastava, 240, First Floor SECT.-19 Dwarka, New Delhi - 110075, Also at: 11661/1 First Floor Near Tank Road, Sant Nagar, Karol Bagh.
(CD 2) AKHILESH SRIVASTAVA, House No. 312 3rd Floor, Pocket B Sector 19 Dwarka, New Delhi - 110075 Also at: 11661/1 First Floor Near Tank Road, Sant Nagar, Karol Bagh.
(CD 3) MANISHA SRIVASTAVA, House No. 312 3rd Floor, Pocket B Sector 19 Dwarka, New Delhi - 110075 Also at: 11661/1 First Floor Near Tank Road, Sant Nagar, Karol Bagh.
This is to notify that as per the Recovery Certificate issued in pursuance of orders passed by the Presiding Officer, DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL DELHI(DRT 2) in OA/224/2023 an amount of Rs. 24762536.99 (Rupees Two Crore Forty Seven Lakhs Sixty Two Thousands Five Hundred Thirty Six And Paise Ninety Nine Only) along with pendente lite and future interest @ 10.50 % Simple Interest Yearly w.e.f. 15/03/2023 till realization and costs of Rs. 150005 (Rupees One Lakh Fifty Thousands Five Only) has become due against you (Jointly and severally/Fully/Limited).
2. You are hereby directed to pay the above sum within 15 days of the receipts of the notice, failing which the recovery shall be made in accordance with the Recovery of Debts Due to Banks and Financial Institutions Act, 1993 and Rules there under.
3. You are hereby ordered to declare on an affidavit the particulars of yours assets on or before the next date of hearing.
4. You are hereby ordered to appear before the undersigned on 09/10/2026 at 10:30 a.m for further proceedings.
5. In addition to the sum aforesaid, you will also be liable to pay:
(a) Such interests as is payable for the period commencing immediately after this notice of the certificate execution proceedings.
(b) All costs, charges and expenses incurred in respect of the service of this notice and warrants and other processes and all other proceedings taken for recovering the amount due. Given under my hand and the seal of the Tribunal, on this date: **22/07/2026**
Recovery Officer
Debts Recovery Tribunal Delhi(DRT 2)
COPY TO:- THE HONGKONG AND SHANGHAI BANKING CORPORATION, 25, BIRLA TOWER, NEW DELHI - 110001



SALUTE THE SOLDIER
BORDER SECURITY FORCE
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Diwas.

 CONSTABLE RAJ KUMAR 195 BN BSF 05.06.1968 - 15.08.1990	 CONSTABLE NAND KISHOR SINGH 76 BN BSF 25.02.1969 - 15.08.1990	 CONSTABLE K JOTHI BASU 18 BN BSF 01.05.1973 - 15.08.1995
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INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)
ITBP salutes its braveheart Head Constable Nandan Singh of 54th Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Arunachal Pradesh in 2017.

 Veer Balidani Shri Pramod Kumar Commandant 49 Bn 15-10-1972 To 15-8-2016	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Commandant Pramod Kumar of 49 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while leading from the front during an encounter with terrorists at Nowhatta Chowk, Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir on 15 August 2016. For his unparalleled gallantry, he was posthumously awarded the Kirti Chakra. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
 Veer Balidani Head Constable Arun Kumar Singh 65 Bn 15-7-1952 To 15-8-2000	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Arun Kumar Singh of 65 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely defending CRPF post in, Shillong, Meghalaya on 15 August 2000. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
 Veer Balidani Head Constable Mool Chand 95 Bn	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Mool Chand of 95 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a cowardly attack by insurgents while performing sentry-checking duties at the NPCL factory camp in Nagaland on 15 August 1998. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
 Veer Balidani Constable Gudit Singh 13 Bn	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Gudit Singh of 13 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely defending the CRPF post at Yumarg, Jammu & Kashmir, on 15 August 1965. For his conspicuous gallantry and valour, he was posthumously awarded the President's Police and Fire Services Medal for Gallantry. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
 Veer Balidani Constable Salam Iboyima Singh 11 Bn 1-2-1972 To 15-8-1993	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Salam Iboyima Singh of 11 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while leading the attack during a fierce encounter with militants in Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir on 15 August 1993. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
 Veer Balidani Constable Chandrajeet Yadav 133 Bn 8-6-1974 To 15-8-2007	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Chandrajeet Yadav of 133 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating insurgents during a Road Opening Patrol in Tripura on 15 August 2007. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
 Veer Balidani Constable Ajeet Kumar Singh 52 BN 5-6-1966 To 15-8-1999	 Veer Balidani Constable B. R. Sable 52 BN 1-6-1967 To 15-8-1999
 Veer Balidani Constable Ranjeet Kumar Mondal 52 BN 22-11-1973 To 15-8-1999	DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to 3 brave hearts of 52 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating insurgents during a fierce encounter at Bishnupur, Manipur on 15 August 1999. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.



RajCOMP Info Services Limited (RISL)
C-Block 1st Floor, Yojana Bhawan, Tilak Marg, C-Scheme, Jaipur

RISL invites bids from the eligible bidders for RFP regarding "Empanelment of firms for Supply, Installation and Maintenance of Computer Systems and Allied items for one year". The details can be seen on the websites:
<https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> in <https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>, <https://doitc.rajasthan.gov.in>
UBN No. :- RIS2627GLOB00047
Raj.Samwad/C/26/9708 General Manager (Technical) & OIC (Store), RISL



PRESS NOTICE
HIMACHAL PRADESH PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

The Executive Engineer, Jawali Division HPPWD, Jawali -176023 on behalf of the Governor of Himachal Pradesh invites e-tenders on percentage basis, from approved and eligible contractors registered with HPPWD for the following work.

S. No	Division	Name of Work	Estimated cost (Rs.)	Earnest money (Rs)	Time allowed for completion (Months).	Cost of documents (Rs)	Class of contractor / Firms	Location/ Office where e-tenders will be opened	Date and time of opening of tenders
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
1	Jawali	Improvement of Single Lane to Intermediate Lane from (Ghera) Nagrota Surian to Jawali Km. 39/180 to 660. (SH-1 Formation cutting (R.O.P.D). Retaining/Breast wall, Cross Drainage work and Parapets in between Km. 47/320 to 63/885).	5,37,32,920/-	10,75,000/-	Nine Months	5,000/-	Class-A	Jawali Division HPPWD Jawali	05.09.2026

Tender documents, other instructions and terms and conditions can be downloaded or viewed on line from the portal <https://hptendershp.gov.in> by the firms/individual registered on the website which is free of cost.
2. As the bids are to be submitted online are required to be encrypted and digitally signed.
3. Key Dates:-

1.	Date of online publication	27.08.2026 at 11:00 AM
2	Downloading of e-tender document	From 27.08.2026 at 11:00 AM up to 04.09.2026 at 5.00 PM
3	Date of submission of e-tendering	From 27.08.2026 at 11:00 AM up to 04.09.2026 at 5.00 PM
4	Date of technical bid opening, evaluation of technical bid followed by financial bid	05.09.2026 at 11.30 AM

HIM SUCHANA AVAM JAN SAMPARK.
Executive Engineer,
Jawali Division, HP, PWD, Jawali -176023
Telephone No 01893264186 e-mail ee-jaw-hp@nic.in
For on behalf of Government of H.P.

No.2673/HP

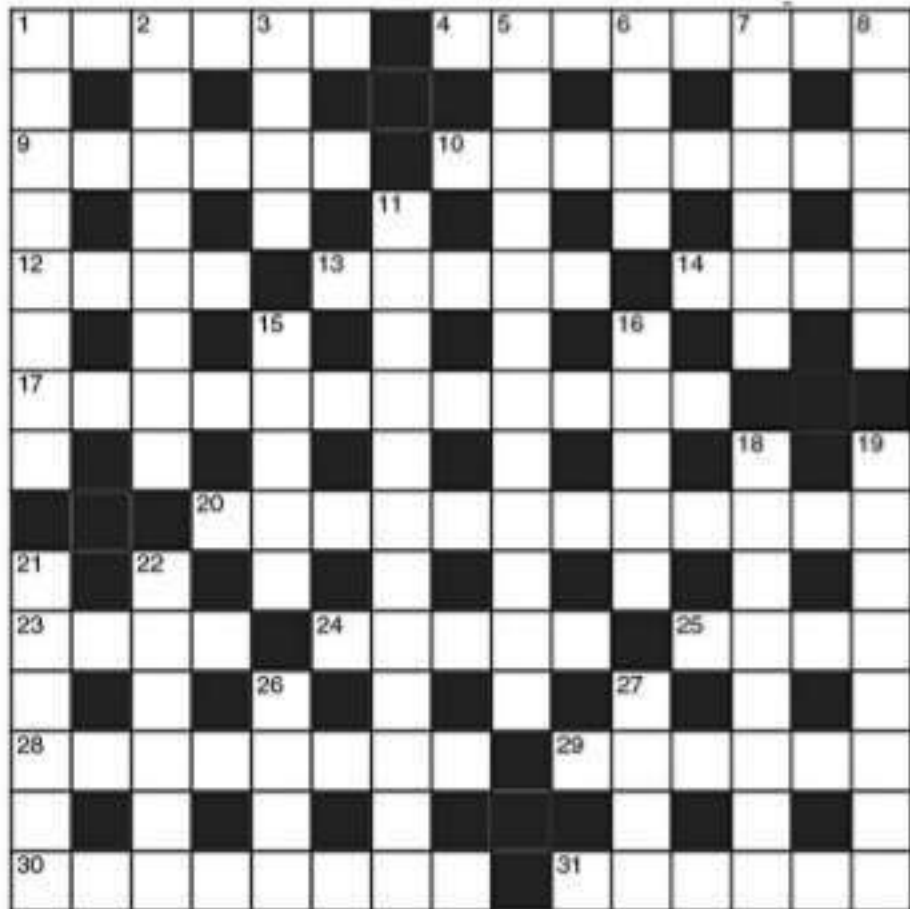


KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar, Bengaluru-560009. Phone No. 080-22265383, Website: www.kiadb.in

No. IADB/ENGG/ETND-EP-30/2660/2026-27 Date: 13.08.2026
SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)
Item Rate Tenders under two cover bid system are invited as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 and Rules 2000 through electronic procurement from eligible Contractors who have got adequate financial resources, state of the art technology, suitable construction equipments, technical man power & sufficient past experience for the work of :
Name of the Works: Providing Power Infrastructure at Doothnur Kaval Industrial Area, Channarayapatna Taluk, Hassan District.
The last date and time of receipt of tender is : **03.09.2026 upto 4.00 pm.**
Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>.
Sd/-
Engineer in Chief,
KIADB, Bengaluru
DIPR/CP/2170/SMCL/2026-27

epaper.indianexpress.com

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 Listen otherwise there is nothing to hear (6)
- 4 Put on heavy music symbolic of Ireland? (8)
- 9 Make straight for this (6)
- 10 Plant in grade A condition (8)
- 12 Plenty at the auction (4)
- 13 That celebratory bit on the fourth of July (5)
- 14 Return before reaching source of burning issue (4)
- 17 Most appealing features of newspapers perhaps (5,7)
- 20 A fair swimmer? (7,5)
- 23 Approve of American fashion (4)
- 24 Spending some surplus in gold (5)
- 25 Small yet troublesome inflammation (4)
- 28 Dora and Rita may get you warmer - or cooler! (8)
- 29 Stop side replacing good man (6)
- 30 An accommodating woman (8)
- 31 Bow to a lady? It's a sign (6)
- DOWN
- 1 With luck pals arranged some capital cover (8)
- 2 Spot a feline holding another with love (8)
- 3 The average Pole or Frenchman? (4)
- 5 Jealousy - caused by overindulgence? (12)
- 6 Produced under pressure? (4)
- 7 Decorated about noon, has to deliver a speech (6)
- 8 Knock out, sad to say, furry animals (6)
- 11 He'll fulfil his promise (3,2,3,4)
- 15 How government works as a rule (2-3)
- 16 Admirers of high status (5)
- 18 Sole - yet not the only one (8)
- 19 He chooses though losing his head as he votes (8)
- 21 Stock type of pen (6)
- 22 Excuse to knock up a Spaniard (6)
- 26 Boat made to swing off course to port (4)
- 27 Clothes which people drive in (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6067 ACROSS: 1 Rally, 4 Stencil, 8 Fog, 9 Army corps, 10 Retinue, 11 Abhor, 13 Ethics, 15 Amoral, 18 Capri, 19 Algebra, 21 Momentous, 23 Aid, 24 Capsize, 25 Order DOWN: 1 Referee, 2 Lightship, 3 Yearn, 4 Samuel, 5 Exclaim, 6 Car, 7 Loser, 12 Hardboard, 14 Chianti, 16 Leander, 17 Galore, 18 Comic, 20 Gusto, 22 Map

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip. If you can't explain it ____, you don't understand it well enough. — Einstein (6)

HTXIS

●●●●●●

RSULY

○●●●●●

MRRUUM

●●●●●●

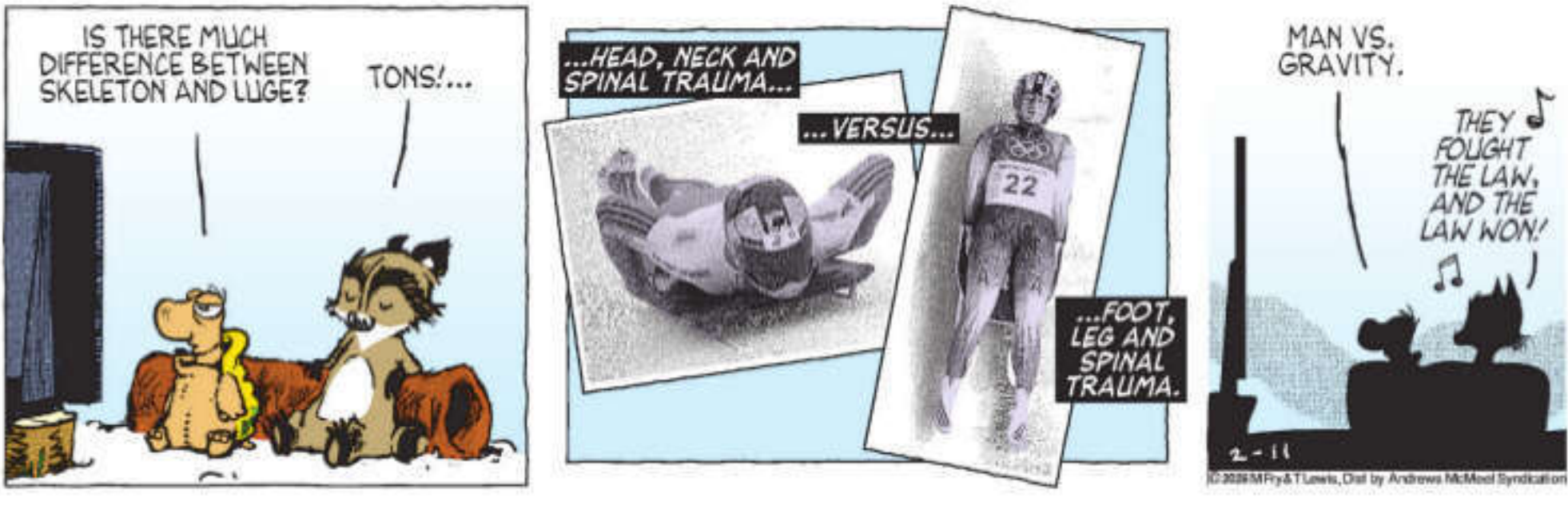
EOPRRP

●●●●●●

ANSWER: If you can't explain it simply, you don't understand it well enough. — Einstein

SOLUTIONS: Sixth 'Sunny, Murrmur, Proper

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



SUDOKU 6411

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 4s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6410

5 4 1 3 9 8 7 6 2

9 6 8 5 7 2 1 3 4

2 3 7 4 6 1 9 5 8

1 9 5 8 2 7 6 4 3

3 7 6 9 5 4 8 2 1

8 2 4 1 3 6 5 9 7

6 8 3 7 4 5 2 1 9

4 1 2 6 8 9 3 7 5

7 5 9 2 1 3 4 8 6

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of Tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

N.I.T. No.	NIT No.11(A,B,C,D,E,F)26-27/WE
(A) Repair and improvement of vacant quarters in the section of SSE/W/SSB under ADEN/E-IV.	(B) Repair and improvement of vacant quarters in the section of SSE/W/PB under ADEN/E-IV.
(C) Repair to Unpopular/Newly Allotted qtrs. in the section of SSE/W/DKZ-I under ADEN/E-IV.	(D) Repair to Outlived sewage/drainage system & replacement of old rusted water supply pipe line in block no. 1 to 14, 42 to 44 at DKZ-I Railway colony in the section of SSE/W/DKZ-I under ADEN/E-IV.
(E) Repair to Unpopular/Newly Allotted qtrs. at DKZ-II railway, colony under ADEN/E-IV.	(F) Improvement of firefighting system, addressable alarm system, PA system provision of fire sprinkler system in record room and DAO building as per instruction of Delhi Fire Service for annual maintenance contract of fire fighting system for 36 month at DAO building in the s/o SSE/W/T, Camp. And Operation & maintenance of Fire Fighting system at ORH Abhinandan for 36 month at TKJ in the section of SSE/W/MNTB under ADEN/E-I.

Approx. Cost of work	(A) ₹11999928.54	(B) ₹7999856.78	(C) ₹8999625.13
	(D) ₹8999901.61	(E) ₹8999892.70	(F) ₹31528496.68
EMD Amount	(A) ₹240000.00	(B) ₹180000.00	(C) ₹180000.00
	(D) ₹180000.00	(E) ₹180000.00	(F) ₹630600.00

Completion period of work	For Sr. No. A, B, C, D & E	8 Months
	For Sr. No. F:	36 Months
Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender	Closing Date of Tender on 07.09.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.	
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. http://www.ireps.gov.in	

No.: 128-W/269/O.E.T./NIT No. 11 (A, B, C, D, E, F)26-27/WE/ Dated: 12.08.2026 2805/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

SIKKA PORTS & TERMINALS LIMITED

Registered Office: Admin Building, MTF Area, Village Sikka, Taluka & District Jamnagar - 361140, Gujarat, India.

Phone : 022-35577700 • Email: debenture.investors@sptl.co.in • Website: www.sptl.co.in CIN: U45102GJ1997PLC031906

EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED STANDALONE FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30TH JUNE 2026

(Rs. in crore, except per share data and ratios)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended 30 Jun '26	Year Ended 30 Jun '25	Year Ended 30 Jun '26
1	Total Income from Operations	1,277.30	1,276.54	5,331.12
2	Net Profit before Exceptional Item and Tax	664.75	974.74	1,360.15
3	Net Profit before Tax (after Exceptional Item)	664.75	974.74	6,774.45
4	Net Profit after Tax	310.91	673.47	5,734.22
5	Total Comprehensive Income (Comprising Profit (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (OCI) (after tax))	4,717.99	1,381.09	6,145.29
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital	2,475.00	2,475.00	2,475.00
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	-	-	29,944.92
8	Securities Premium Account	17,967.47	17,967.47	17,967.47
9	Net worth	30,514.90	28,367.29	29,848.23
10	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	12,771.02	24,573.82	19,608.76
11	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	47.00	47.00	47.00
12	Outstanding Non-Cumulative Optionally Convertible Preference Shares	-	3,500.00	-
13	Debt Equity Ratio	0.39	0.90	0.60
14	Earnings per Equity Share for the period/ year of face value of Rs. 1 each :-			
15	- Basic and Diluted (in Rupees)	0.13	0.27	2.32
16	- Basic and Diluted (in Rupees) Before Exceptional Item	0.13	0.27	0.13
15	Capital Redemption Reserve	3,500.00	-	3,500.00
16	Debiture Redemption Reserve	400.00	1,316.80	1,316.80
17	Debit Service Coverage Ratio	0.11	2.69	0.56
18	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	3.39	3.22	1.82

Notes:

1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Unaudited Standalone Financial Results for the quarter ended 30th June 2026 filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 52 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosures Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Unaudited Standalone Financial Results for the quarter ended 30th June 2026 are available on the website of BSE Limited (www.bseindia.com) and can be accessed on the Company's website (www.sptl.co.in).

2 For the other line items referred in Regulation 52(4) of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosures Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the pertinent disclosures have been made to BSE Limited (www.bseindia.com) and can be accessed on the Company's website (www.sptl.co.in).

3 The Audit Committee has reviewed, and the Board of Directors has approved the above results and its release at their respective meetings held on 14th August 2026. The statutory auditors of the Company have carried out a Limited Review of the aforesaid results.

For Sikka Ports & Terminals Limited Sd/- Sangeet Dandekar Chairman DIN : 00022797

Place: Mumbai Date : 14th August 2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement system

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:

Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
07260319	BOGIE BOLSTER ARRANGEMENT	74 Nos	26.08.26
07260305	WHEEL SET EARTHOING EQUIPMENT	2999 Nos	28.08.26
07263466	SEALED GLASS UNIT	6600 Nos	03.09.26
19252801	ENHANCE CAPACITY (HT) SCREW COUPLING 60 TONNES	285 Nos	14.09.26
08260851	SITEL PRIMARY CELL	58151 Nos	16.09.26

NOTE: 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details.. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No.: 35/2026-2027 Dated: 14.08.2026

SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE 2819/2026

WORKS DEPARTMENT

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, EASTERN CIRCLE (R&B), BALESHWAR

e-mail: - seec_bls@rediffmail.com

Government of Odisha "e" Procurement Notice

Bid Identification No. CCEEC-11/2026-27

No: 5711 Dt: 12.8.26

Nature of work: - Building Works.

Number of works: - 01 Nos. Building.

Amount put to Tender: - Rs. 189.38 lakh.

Class of Contractor: - "B" & "A" Class.

Date & Time of availability of bid document in the portal: - Dt. 25.08.2026 at 10:00 AM

Last Date / Time of receipt of bid in the portal: - Dt. 08.09.2026 up to 05:00 PM

Date of opening of bid: Dt. 09.09.2026 at 11:00 AM

Name & address of the Office inviting bid: Chief Construction Engineer, Eastern Circle (R&B), Baleshwar.

The bidders have to participate in ONLINE bidding only. Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement portal "<http://tendersodisha.gov.in>". All future corrigendum will be available on ONLINE mode only.

Sd/- Chief Construction Engineer, Eastern Circle (R&B), Baleshwar.

OIPR-34001/34026/1/26-27/0013

UP Rajya Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Ltd.

PARICHHA THERMAL POWER PROJECT - PARICHHA, JHANSI

1. GEM/2026/B/7901108 Dated 11.08.2026 "Refurbishment Reconditioning Fabrication Machining of various spares of Boiler-Turbine Mills Fans of CTPS Parichha." Estimated Cost Rs. 38,22,623/-, EMD Rs 45,000/-, Bid Submission end dt. 01.09.2026 up to 12:00 PM.

2. GEM/2026/B/7873927 Dated 04.08.2026 "Radiography NDT work job stress relieving of boiler pressure part of PTPP Parichha." Estimated Cost Rs. 12,86,825/-, EMD Rs 20,000/-, Bid Submission end dt. 19.08.2026 up to 04:00 PM.

3. GEM/2026/B/7888866 Dated 07.08.2026 "Thermal Insulation works pertaining to TG area during Overhauling of unit no. 4, BTPS Parichha." Estimated Cost Rs. 6,37,200/-, EMD Rs 5,500/-, Bid Submission end dt. 28.08.2026 up to 04:00 PM.

4. GEM/2026/B/7877784 Dated 05.08.2026 "Hire of agency of consultancy services for ISO IMS for All Project of UPRVUNL." Estimated Cost Rs. 23,36,400/-, EMD Rs 20,000/-, Bid Submission end dt. 31.08.2026 up to 12:00 PM.

5. GEM/2026/B/7868598 Dated 03.08.2026 "Rewinding repairing of distribution transformers of various capacity ratings for PTPP colony Parichha." Estimated Cost Rs. 17,67,930/-, EMD Rs 29,000/-, Bid Submission end dt. 02.09.2026 up to 02:00 PM.

NOTE:- For Information regarding Addendum / Corrigendum/ Rejection of Bids kindly regularly visit website <https://gem.gov.in> & uprvunl.org.

Sd/- 140 / टी.एस.डी.-प्र० / सीटीपीपी/ दिनांक 14.08.2026

"Save Electricity for Nation"

JODHPUR VIDYUT VITARAN NIGAM LIMITED

(MATERIAL MANAGEMENT & CONTRACT WING)

NEW POWER HOUSE, INDUSTRIAL AREA, JODHPUR-342003, PHONE: 0291-2742223, FAX: 0291-2746539

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

E-Procurement Tender is invited for supply of 33 KV 800 Amp. Isolator with Post Insulator without Earth Blade (Assembled) TN-2199 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00414), 11 KV Horn Gap Fuse Sets With Post Insulator (Un-Assembled) TN-2200 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00415) and 33 KV Horn Gap Fuse Sets with Post Insulator(Un-Assembled) TN-2201 (UBN JVV2627GLOB00416).

Details regarding Quantity, Tender cost, Earnest Money, Schedule date of tender opening for aforesaid tenders are available on our website at energy.rajjasthan.gov.in/jdvvn1 and also at <http://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in>

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (MM&C)

For Electricity Complaints Toll free No. 1800 180 6045

UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LTD.

(A Govt. of Uttarakhand Undertaking) CIN NO: U40109UR2001SGC025867

Office of the Superintending Engineer, Electricity Distribution Circle, Chakrata (HQ - Kalsi) Distt. Dehradun. e-Mail: edc.chakrata@upcl.org, edcchakrata@gmail.com Website: www.upcl.org, Mobile No. 9411746161

E-Tender Cancellation Notice

In compliance to the Corporation's Order No. 4545 / निदे० (वि०एम्परि०) /उपाकासि./ A-1 दिनांक 13/08/2026, the following e-tenders, invited under Electricity Distribution Circle, Uttarakhand Power Corporation Ltd., Chakrata (HQ-Kalsi), Dehradun, by the undersigned, are hereby cancelled-

1. E-tender No. -	31/EDCC(K)/2026-27
2. E-tender No. -	32/EDCC(K)/2026-27
3. E-tender No. -	33/EDCC(K)/2026-27
4. E-tender No. -	34/EDCC(K)/2026-27
5. E-tender No. -	35/EDCC(K)/2026-27

For more details, kindly visit the website www.uktenders.gov.in

"विद्युत बिलों के 24x7 ऑनलाईन गुप्तता हेतु www.upcl.org पर जायें"

Superintending Engineer EDC, Chakrata टोल फ्री नं० 1800-419-0405

"राष्ट्र हित में बिजली बचायें"

कार्यालय आयुक्त, नगर पालिक निगम, ग्वालियर

प्रक्र. 89/26x6/4/विद्युत/517 या, दिनांक 12/08/2026

नगरपालिका RO क्रमांक 564 //ई निविदा सूचना// दिनांक : 14/08/2026

निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केन्द्रीयमक प्रणाली में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमन्त्रित की जाती है। निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट पोर्टल www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र.	टेकर क्र. जारी दिनांक	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की समाप्ति एवं लागत	निविदा प्रारंभ का मूल्य एवं ई.एम.डी.	निविदा की अंतिम तिथि
1	2026 UAD 528563_1 dated 10-08-2026	"RFP for regular Energy Bill Audit services & its compliance electrification work cum operation and maintenance service for streetlights, PHE, Tubewells, Public gardens, Office Buildings, Subah Complex electrical connection" etc. under GMC Gwalior (MP) File No. 89/26x6/4.	42 months Rs. 1,50,36,000/-	Rs. 12,500/- Rs. 75,180/-	11.09.2026

नोट: निविदा से संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन का प्रस्ताव ऑनलाइन वेबसाइट www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

राज्यक संजी (विद्युत), नगर पालिक निगम, ग्वालियर

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Engineer (CO) / S.E.C. Railway, Nagpur invites E-Tender for execution of following works:-

Sl. No.	Name of the work	Tender Notice No.	Approx. Tender Value in ₹	Earnest Money/ Bid Security in (₹)
1.	1. (f) Provision of office cum store with facilities for SSEs of S & T department at Tumsar Road of Nagpur Division. & (2) Reliability improvement through the shifting of old OFC hut to new El Building OFC Hut for four station (NITR, GBRI, DGBZ & TRDI) under the jurisdiction Sr DEN / C / Nagpur.	C/23/NAG/2026-2027	2,05,77,956/-	4,11,800/-
2.	Carting and picking of released rails, sleepers, and other engineering materials by the Crane mounted on BFR/BTRBN over Nagpur Division.	C/24/NAG/2026-2027	1,10,31,775/-	2,20,600/-

For all the above tenders the Bidders will be able to submit their original/revised bids up to 15.00 hrs of 08.09.2026 only. Manual offers are not allowed. Details are available on our website: www.ireps.gov.in

PAM/36/88 Sr. Divl. Engineer (Central)/S.E.C.Railway/Nagpur

f South East Central Railway X @sccrail

ROYAL STARS

By Georgia Nicols

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today the Moon is opposite your sign, which means you have to go more than halfway when dealing with others. Be accommodating and generous, because conversations might be confrontational as well as confusing. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Despite family discussions, home repairs and a strong emphasis on your domestic world, today you're focused on your work, your health and perhaps a pet. Unfortunately, there seems to be confusion that can trigger tension. Tonight: Get better organised.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a dicey day for romance, fun socializing, sports and playful activities with kids, because confused communications are likely. Plus, you might not have the energy to follow through on your plans. Go gently. Tonight: Socialise.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Family disputes are likely today. Unfortunately, miscommunications and false expectations might contribute to this. Assume nothing. Keep in mind that many people don't grasp how sensitive your feelings are. Tonight: Relax at home.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is the classic day for tension in communications with your everyday contacts. This could be due to confusion, misdirection, misunderstandings or possibly deceit. Tonight: Conversations.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Be careful spending money and dealing today. You might not have all the facts, or you might be confused or misled. Therefore, double-check everything. Tonight: Check your possessions.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a tricky day. You have the advantage because the Moon is in your sign. However, today Mars and Neptune are at odds with the Moon, creating conflict with authority figures and confused communication with partners and close friends. Tonight: You win.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Steer clear of controversial subjects today, because there's too much confusion and misunderstandings. Meanwhile, Mars can create irritability. Tonight: Enjoy solitude.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Today you might want to enjoy time with a friend or a group. You might even spit-ball some ideas you have about your future goals. Be aware that friction with someone about shared property or costs, is impossible to avoid today. Tonight: Be friendly.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): This is a poor day to ask for permission from an authority figure. Meanwhile, be aware that you are noticed today. Guard against a public argument with a partner or friend. Tonight: You're admired.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Communications are confused today, which is why this is a poor day for important discussions about controversial subjects. Issues that are health-related also might be confusing. Tonight: Explore.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You might be involved in social outings today, including sports events, fun activities with kids or romantic dates. If so, be patient, because misunderstandings and confused communications are par for the course. These are relatively minor influences. Don't let them ruin a meaningful relationship. Be patient. Tonight: Check your finances.

उत्तराखण्ड महापौराखण्ड (सि०), 30330 राज्य औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण ए-1/4, लखनपुर, कानपुर

ई-निविदा सूचना

एनएडएल सूचित किया जाता है, कि विभिन्न औद्योगिक क्षेत्रों के अन्तर्गत विकास /अनुसंधान /उत्पत्तिकरण कार्य हेतु सरकारी भित्ति /सर्वसाजनिक उपक्रमों /निर्माण /प्रतिकरणों /परिचालन /नगर निकायों में कार्यरत फर्मों/ठेकेदारों से ई-निविदाओं आमंत्रित की जाती है, जिसको अपलोड करने की समयसीमा निम्नवत् है-

क्रमांक 1 व 2 वा अंतिम कार्य की निविदा दिनांक 17.08.2026 को पूर्वान्ह 11.00 बजे से दिनांक 24.08.2026 को अपरान्ह 5.00 बजे तक अपलोड की जा सकती है, जिन्हें दिनांक 24.08.2026 को अपरान्ह 5.30 बजे खोलता जायेगा (अव्यक्तिक)

निविदादाताओं द्वारा केवल शपथपत्रों की मूल प्रतियाँ निविदा प्रपत्रों में उल्लिखित दिनांक तक कार्यालय में जमा की जा सकेंगी। ई-निविदा के माध्यम से आमंत्रित की जाने वाली निविदाओं का विवरण निम्नवत् है-

क्रमांक	कार्य का नाम	बड्डी की लागत (₹ लाख में)
1	Construction / Development of Park P-2 at Industrial Area CDF Complex District- Aligarh.	126.83
2	Construction / Development of Park P-2 at Industrial Area Salempur, District- Hathras	139.13

नोट:- निविदादाता अपनी निविदाओं में सम्मिल कर सहित दर्द अंतिम करें। जीएसटीडीसी बजट से देय होमा। निविदा सम्बन्धी विस्तृत जानकारी प्राप्तिकरण की website: <http://beta.upsidamarketplace.com> पर लिखत ई-बिडिंग एवं सुविधाएँ की website: <http://eender.up.nic.in> पर देखा जा सकता है। अन्य जानकारी हेतु कार्यालय हेतु कार्यालय के वॉरिंग प्रत्यक्ष (लिखित) के श्री प्रवीण कुमार सहाय निम्नलिखित नं० 9871080103 पर सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है।

महापौराखण्ड (सि०), 30330 राज्य औद्योगिक विकास, कानपुर

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Sangeet Sharma S/o Jagdish Prasad Sharma R/o 8/604, Gali No. 3, Adarsh Nagar, Modi Nagar, District Meerut, Uttar Pradesh has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 283/2012 U/s 382/411/34 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Sangeet Sharma cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Sangeet Sharma has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Sangeet Sharma of case FIR No. 283/2012 U/s 382/411/34 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 17.09.2026.

By Order Ms. Upasana Satija Chief Judicial Magistrate North West District, Room No. 108, 1st Floor Rohini Courts, Delhi DP/10353/NW/2026/Court Matter)

GOVERNMENT OF ARUNACHAL PRADESH

OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR GENERAL OF POLICE

POLICE HEADQUARTERS ::ITANAGAR

No.PHQ/WT/PP-032025 Dated Itanagar, the 7th August 2026

TENDER NOTICE

On behalf of the Governor of Arunachal Pradesh, Director General of Police, Arunachal Pradesh, Itanagar invites sealed Tenders under a Two-Bid systems (Technical & Financial Bid) from eligible manufacturers, authorized distributors, authorized dealers and suppliers of reputed firms based in Arunachal Pradesh, in accordance with the Government policy of "Vocal for Local" and "Aatma Nirbhar Bharat" for supply of various Wireless Telecommunication (WT) equipment for the Office of the Superintendent of Police (Telecom), Chimpu, Arunachal Pradesh.

For Tender details & Specifications please visit our web site - www.arunpol.nic.in.

Sd/- Director General of Police Itanagar, Arunachal Pradesh.

DIPR/ARN/0212-2016